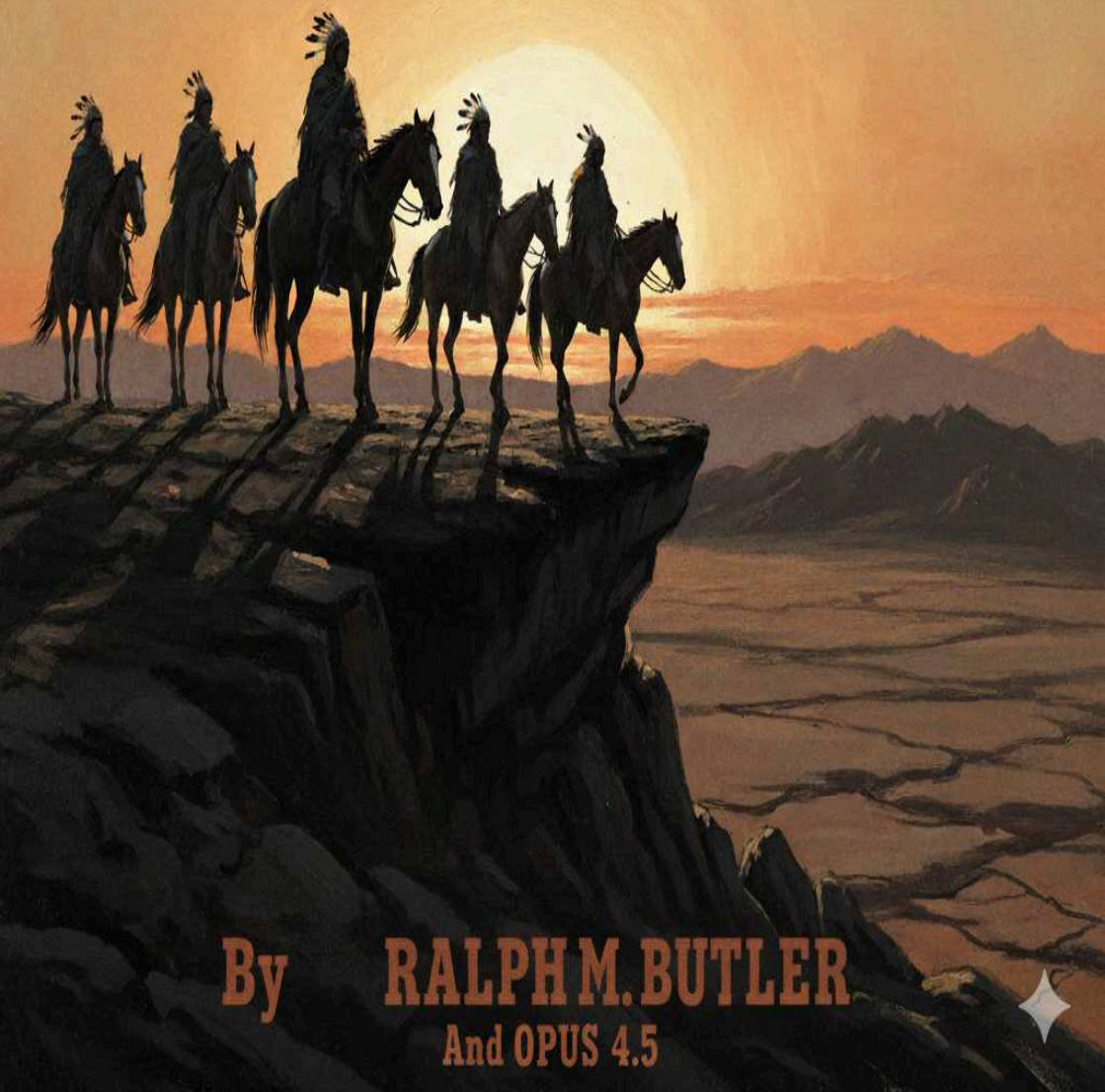


AGAINST THE SUN



By **RALPH M. BUTLER**
And OPUS 4.5



Contents

Part I: Chapters 1-6 (Camp/Catalyst) 2

 CHAPTER ONE 2

 CHAPTER TWO 15

 CHAPTER THREE 26

 CHAPTER FOUR 34

 CHAPTER FIVE 46

 CHAPTER SIX 55

Part II: Chapters 7-11 (The Journey) 62

 CHAPTER SEVEN 62

 CHAPTER EIGHT 70

 CHAPTER NINE 79

 CHAPTER TEN 91

 CHAPTER ELEVEN 102

Part III: Chapters 12-14 (Washington DC) 114

 CHAPTER TWELVE 114

 CHAPTER THIRTEEN 130

 CHAPTER FOURTEEN 140

Part IV: Chapters 15-17 (The Reckoning) 155

 CHAPTER FIFTEEN 155

 CHAPTER SIXTEEN 163

 CHAPTER SEVENTEEN 172

Part V: Chapter 18 (The Return Home) 181

 CHAPTER EIGHTEEN 181

Part I: Chapters 1-6 (Camp/Catalyst)

CHAPTER ONE

The wind came from the west that morning, as it did most mornings, pushing the grass flat and carrying with it the smell of dust and distance. Crow sat on a buffalo robe outside his lodge and watched the sky turn from grey to pale yellow along the horizon. The sun would be up soon. He could feel it coming the way a man feels rain before it falls.

He had been awake for some time, thinking about nothing in particular, which was his preferred way of thinking. Across the camp, maybe forty paces off, Stone was already working on something. Crow could see him crouched near the horse line, his back to the wind, hands moving in that slow deliberate way of his. Probably mending tack. Stone was always mending something.

The camp was scattered across a shallow draw where a seasonal creek had left behind a few pools of brown water and some scrub willow that gave the horses something to stand behind when the wind turned mean. There were eleven lodges in all, arranged without any particular order that a white man would recognize, though anyone who lived here understood the logic of it—who was kin to whom, who needed to be near the water, whose horses didn't get along.

Crow's lodge sat slightly apart from the others, which suited him. He liked being able to see the whole camp without turning his head too much. He liked watching people go about their business without them knowing he was watching. It was one of the few pleasures left to a man his age.

Rain came out of the lodge behind him, carrying a water skin. She didn't say anything, just walked past him toward the creek. He watched her go. She moved well for a woman who had seen hard years. Her hair was still black, mostly, and she wore it in two braids that swung against her back as she walked.

Hawk had walked like that. The same loose stride, the same way of holding the shoulders. Crow pushed the thought away, but it came back, as it always did in the quiet moments. Eight months now. Eight months since Two-

Kettles had ridden into camp alone, bleeding from his side, and the world had split in two.

He thought about saying something to Rain—something about the weather, or the water, or nothing at all—but she was already too far away, and anyway she would be back soon enough.

The wind gusted and flapped the hide covering of the lodge. Somewhere a dog barked twice and then stopped. A child's voice rose and fell in one of the far lodges, not crying exactly, just making noise. The sounds of the camp waking up.

Stone had not moved from his spot by the horses. Crow could see now that he was working on a bridle, holding it up close to his face to see the stitching. Stone's eyes were not what they had been. Neither were Crow's, if he was honest, but he didn't have to be honest about it because he wasn't the one squinting at leather in the early light.

He thought about walking over there. It would give him something to do, and Stone would not object to the company even if he wouldn't welcome it either. That was how it was between them, and had been for thirty years. Crow talked. Stone mostly listened. They understood each other—two men who had seen the same things and no longer needed to explain themselves.

They had both lost family to the soldiers. Crow's boy Hawk, Stone's brother Walks Far. The same patrol, the same afternoon, the same meaningless violence near the Brazos. Stone never spoke of it—Stone never spoke of anything—but Crow saw it in the set of his shoulders, his watchfulness over Fox, a weight that went beyond an uncle's duty. Fox was all that remained of Walks Far now. Stone carried that.

But the robe was warm where he sat, and the sun was just now breaking over the edge of the world, throwing long shadows across the grass, and Crow decided he would wait a little longer before he did anything at all.

The sun climbed. The shadows shortened. Crow remained where he was.

He was considering whether to ask Rain to bring him something to eat, or whether that would start a conversation he didn't want to have this early in the morning, when the donkey appeared.

It came around the back of Stone's lodge at a purposeful walk, going nowhere in particular but heading there with conviction. It was a grey donkey, sway-backed and long-eared and not pretty in the way that only donkeys can be not pretty, and believing that it belonged to no one, but Crow knew it belonged to him because he had been foolish enough to trade for it two summers ago.

He had gotten it from a comanchero named Refugio who had promised him it was a good pack animal, strong and patient and not prone to wandering. The comanchero had been a liar. The donkey was none of those things. What it was, was stubborn in a way that suggested actual malice, and it had a habit of often appearing wherever it was least wanted.

Crow watched it walk past Stone without stopping. Stone did not look up from his work, but Crow saw his shoulders tighten slightly, which was as close as Stone ever came to expressing irritation at something that wasn't worth killing.

The donkey continued on its path, which took it directly toward the horse line. The horses saw it coming. Two of them—a buckskin mare and a paint gelding that belonged to Stone's nephew Fox—shifted uneasily and pulled at their tethers. They did not like the donkey. No horse in the camp liked the donkey. Crow believed the donkey felt actual disdain for the horses.

It stopped about ten feet from the horses and stood there, ears forward, as if waiting for something. The buckskin mare snorted and stamped. The donkey did not move.

"That animal," Crow said to no one, "is a test from the spirits."

Rain had returned from the creek and was standing beside the lodge, watching. "You could shoot it," she said.

"I have considered it."

"But you won't."

“It would be wasteful.” He paused. “And it would give the comanchero too much satisfaction, wherever he is.”

“He is probably dead by now.”

“Then his ghost would be satisfied, and that is worse.”

Rain made a sound that might have been a laugh if she had let it out all the way. She carried the water skin inside and did not come back out.

The donkey had begun to move again. It walked directly into the horse line, threading between the tethered animals with a kind of insolent grace, and stopped in front of the paint gelding. The gelding’s eyes rolled white. It tried to back away but the tether held it. The donkey leaned forward and, very slowly, very deliberately, bit the gelding on the neck.

The gelding screamed. It reared against the tether, came down hard, reared again. The other horses pulled and kicked. The whole line was suddenly chaos—dust rising, animals crying out, hooves pounding the packed earth.

Stone was on his feet and moving before Crow had finished standing up. He covered the forty paces in what seemed like no time at all, grabbed the donkey by the mane, and hauled it backward out of the horse line with a strength that Crow sometimes forgot he possessed. The donkey brayed once, outraged, and then went still in Stone’s grip, as if it had suddenly remembered that this particular human was not one to test.

Stone held the animal for a long moment, looking at it. His face showed nothing. Then he let go, and the donkey walked away at a dignified pace, as if being detained had been its idea.

The horses calmed. Stone checked the paint gelding’s neck—the bite had drawn blood, but not badly—and then stood there with his hand on the animal’s flank, not moving.

Crow walked over. It took him longer than it would have taken Stone. His knees were not what they had been, and he saw no reason to hurry.

“That animal,” he said when he arrived, “is going to cause a death someday.”

Stone said nothing.

“It will be my death, probably. Or yours. It will wait until we are old and slow—” he paused, “—older and slower, I mean—and then it will do something unforgivable, and one of us will have to deal with it, and that will be the end.”

Stone looked at him. His eyes were dark and flat and revealed nothing, but Crow had known him long enough to see the faint crease at the corner of his mouth. It was not quite a smile. Stone did not smile. But it was an acknowledgment that something had been said, and that the thing that had been said was not entirely without merit.

“Fox needs to teach his horse to fight,” Stone said. It was the first thing he had said all morning. His voice was low and rough from disuse.

“The horse is young.”

“The horse is stupid.”

“That too.” Crow looked at the paint gelding, which was still trembling slightly. “But it will learn. Everything learns, eventually. Even that donkey learned not to bite you.”

Stone grunted. He turned back to the horse line and began checking the other animals, running his hands along their legs, looking for injuries. Crow watched him for a while and then turned and walked back toward his lodge, taking his time, feeling the sun on his face and the wind at his back.

The donkey was standing near the creek now, drinking. It looked up as Crow passed, water dripping from its muzzle, and regarded him with an expression of perfect indifference.

“One day,” Crow told it. “One day I will find a use for you.”

The donkey went back to drinking. It did not seem concerned.

The smell of woodsmoke and roasting meat began to settle over the draw, thick enough to taste. Crow followed the scent toward the center of the camp, where Sage had a small fire going between two large, flat stones. She was Stone’s mother, and she had a way of standing over a fire that made it look like she was personally responsible for the sun coming up.

She was older than Rain, with hands that looked like they had been carved from the same cedar as the lodge poles—knotted and hard and capable. She had always been sharp-tongued, but since Walks Far died, her words came out like flint—quick, hard, cutting. Grief made some people soft. It made Sage into a blade. As Crow approached, she was using a stick to turn several strips of buffalo fat on the hot stones.

“If you’re coming for the fat, you’re late,” Sage said, without looking up. “The boys already took the best of it.”

“The boys have no appreciation for the nuances of fat,” Crow said, easing himself down onto a low stump. “They just want the grease. I am here for the craft.”

Sage made a sharp, clicking sound with her tongue. “You are here because you’re hungry and you’re too lazy to hunt your own breakfast. Stone is still out with the horses. Why aren’t you helping him?”

“I was helping him,” Crow said. “I provided the commentary. It’s an essential part of the labor. Without someone to point out the folly of the donkey, Stone would just be a man pulling a grey animal by the hair. With me there, it becomes a story.”

“It becomes a headache,” Sage said. She flipped a piece of meat toward him. It landed on a broad leaf she had placed near his feet. “Eat. And don’t talk to me about stories. Fox came by earlier, nearly crying because his paint got bit. He wanted Stone to shoot the donkey.”

“He’s young,” Crow said, picking up the meat and blowing on it. It was hot and rich, the kind of fat that stayed with a man all day. “He thinks the world should be orderly. He hasn’t learned that the world is mostly donkeys.”

“He hasn’t learned that Stone is a soft-hearted fool when it comes to that animal,” Sage muttered, though there was no real bite in it. She looked toward the creek where Rain was still working with the water skins. “Rain says you were sitting out there since before the light. Thinking again?”

“I was,” Crow admitted. “About the distance.”

Sage stopped turning the meat. She looked at him then, her eyes narrowed against the smoke. “What distance?”

"The distance between where we are and where we're going," Crow said vaguely. "Or maybe just the distance the wind travels. It felt long this morning."

"It's the same distance it was yesterday," Sage said, turning back to the fire. "And it'll be the same tomorrow. You get too much sun on your head, Crow. You start thinking the grass is moving when it's just the wind."

"Maybe," Crow said.

Across the draw, Stone was finally walking back from the horses. He moved with a heavy, swinging gait, his shoulders slightly hunched as if he were carrying an invisible weight. Behind him, Fox was trailing along, still looking sullen, leading the paint gelding. The boy was talking, his hands moving excitedly, while Stone simply walked, staring at the ground in front of his feet.

"Here comes the trouble," Sage said, though she was already pulling more meat from the pack. "Fox won't let it go. He'll want Stone to trade the donkey to the Comancheros next time they come."

"He won't trade it," Crow said. "Stone likes having something in camp that's more stubborn than he is. It makes him feel flexible by comparison."

Sage chuckled, a low, dry sound that was the closest she ever came to a laugh. "Then we're all in trouble," she said.

Stone reached the fire and sat down without a word. He took the meat Sage offered him and began to eat, his eyes fixed on the flames. Fox stood behind him, still holding the lead rope of the paint. The boy's face was flushed, and there was a line of sweat across his forehead.

"He bit him right on the neck," Fox said, as if the conversation had never stopped. "Drawn blood. He's going to be jumpy now. Every time a grey shadow moves, he's going to bolt."

"Teach him to kick," Stone said, his mouth full of buffalo fat.

"I tried! He just stands there. He's afraid of it."

"Then get a better horse," Stone said.

Fox looked at Crow, seeking an ally. “Is he right? I should just let that flea-bitten thing ruin a good animal?”

Crow chewed slowly, savoring the richness of the meat. He looked at the paint gelding, then at the donkey, which was now grazing peacefully near the scrub willow.

“The donkey isn’t the problem, Fox,” Crow said. “The donkey is the donkey. The problem is your horse hasn’t learned to kick yet.”

Fox looked at Stone, who was studiously ignoring him, and then at Sage, who was busy with the fire. Finally, he let out a long, frustrated breath and tied the paint to a nearby willow.

“You’re all crazy,” the boy said, sitting down cross-legged on the dirt. “All of you. It’s the age. It’s rotted your brains.”

“Probably,” Crow agreed. “But we’re the ones with the fat. Sit down and eat, before Sage decides you’re too young for the nuances.”

The four of them sat there in the growing heat of the morning—the two old men, the sharp-tongued woman, and the restless boy—while the camp hummed around them. Somewhere, a drum started a slow, rhythmic beat, and the voices of women calling to one another drifted across the draw. The world felt wide and permanent, as if it had always been this way and always would be.

By noon, the sun had hammered the color out of the sky, leaving it a bleached and blinding white. The wind had died, as it often did when the heat settled in, and the camp fell into a heavy, shimmering silence. Even the dogs had dug themselves into the dirt beneath the lodge flaps, panting with their eyes closed.

Crow and Stone had moved to the shade of a cottonwood that grew crookedly near the water. It wasn’t much shade—the leaves were thin and rattled dryly when the air moved—but it was better than the lodges, which were baking like clay ovens.

Stone had brought a bundle of dogwood shoots and a small fire-pot. He was straightening arrow shafts, a job that required infinite patience and hands

that didn't tremble. He would heat a section of the wood over the coals, sight down the length of it with one eye closed, and then use his teeth or the heel of his hand to bend it true. He had been working on the same three shafts for an hour.

Crow was doing something easier. He had a trade mirror, a small rectangular piece of glass with a cracked wooden frame, and he was using it to inspect his face.

"The lines are getting deeper," Crow observed. He tilted the mirror to catch the light. "My face looks like a map of the canyon lands scratched into the sand."

Stone didn't look up. He rotated a shaft over the heat. "You look like an old man."

"There is a difference. An old man is just a thing that happens. A map implies there is somewhere to go." Crow lowered the mirror. "I heard the Penateka band is down near the Colorado River. Trading with the Texians."

Stone grunted. It was a dismissive sound, low in his throat.

"They say the Texians have new guns," Crow continued. "Not the flintlocks. The ones with the caps. You don't have to keep the powder dry."

"They say a lot of things."

"It would be useful. In the rain."

Stone took the shaft from the fire and sighted down it. He said nothing.

"They are adapting," Crow continued, as if Stone had argued. He picked up a smooth stone and began to polish the wooden frame of the mirror. "The world changes. The Spanish came, and we took their horses. That was a change. If we hadn't taken the horses, we would still be walking in the mountains, eating roots. The Penateka take the guns. Maybe that is the same."

Stone grunted. It was not agreement.

"But you think it is different," Crow said. "You think the guns are a leash. You break a gun, you have to go back to the white man to fix it. You can't

mend it with a knife and a fire like you can an arrow.” He watched Stone work. “That is what you’re thinking.”

Stone set the shaft down and picked up another. “You talk enough for both of us.”

“Someone has to. You would sit there all day saying nothing, and then where would we be? Two old men and a pile of arrows and not a single idea between us.” Crow tilted his mirror, catching the light. “I would like to see one of those guns, though. Just to know.”

“You want one because it is shiny,” Stone said. “Like that mirror.”

“The mirror is practical. It lets me see my enemies approaching from behind.”

Stone almost smiled. “The only thing approaching you from behind is your own shadow. And it is trying to get away.”

Crow smiled. It was a comfortable disagreement. They had been having versions of this conversation for forty years—Crow looking at the horizon, wondering what new things were coming, and Stone looking at the ground, ensuring they stood firm on what was already there. It wasn’t that Stone was blind to the changes; he just refused to grant them permission to matter.

Fifty yards away, near the edge of the creek where the mud was cool, Sage and Rain were scraping a buffalo hide staked out on the ground. Rain used an elk-horn scraper, her movements fluid and steady. Sage used a sharpened piece of iron she had fashioned from a broken wagon hoop.

“Look at them,” Sage said, nodding toward the cottonwood. “Stone making arrows he’ll never shoot. Crow admiring himself.”

Rain wiped sweat from her forehead. “He worries.”

“About the wrong things.” Sage drove the scraper across the hide. “Winter is coming early. I can feel it in my knuckles. We need more fat.”

“Fox saw a herd yesterday. Two days’ ride.”

“Fox sees what he wants to see. But Stone will go. He’s getting restless.” Sage bent back to her work. “Men.”

Rain said nothing for a while. Then: “Crow watches the horizon a lot.”

“There is never nothing there,” Sage said. “That is what worries him.”

The heat pressed down. The cicadas began to whine in the willow branches, a high, sawing sound that seemed to come from everywhere and nowhere. Under the cottonwood, Stone bent the wood with his hands, testing its will against his own. Crow tilted his mirror, catching a beam of sunlight and sending it dancing across the dry grass, a fleeting, brilliant thing that touched the earth but left no mark.

The evening brought a mercy that the morning had not promised. As the sun dipped, the air lost its weight and a thin, cool breeze began to slide down the draw from the north. The sky turned the color of a bruised plum, then a deep, translucent indigo that made the stars look like they were floating in water.

A few of the younger men had gathered near the center of camp for a game of *ha-bi-tu*—the hiding game. They had a buffalo robe spread out and were singing a low, rhythmic song, their bodies swaying as they passed a small, polished bone from hand to hand beneath a piece of hide.

Crow sat on the edge of the circle, watching. He liked the gambling, not because he cared for the stakes—usually a few arrows or a length of braided hair—but because he liked watching the faces. A man’s face during a game of chance told you more than his face during a fight. In a fight, a man was what he had to be; in a game, he was what he actually was.

Fox was currently the one hiding the bone. He was trying to look indifferent, but his eyes kept darting to the man across from him, a tall, thin warrior named Two-Kettles. There was a scar on Two-Kettles’ side, still pink and puckered—the place where a soldier’s ball had passed through him eight months ago. He had been the one to bring the news. He had been the one to watch Hawk and Walks Far die while he crawled into the brush, bleeding, unable to help. He played games now with a kind of desperate intensity, as if winning at bones could balance out the thing he had survived.

“He’s going to lose,” Stone said. He had appeared silently at Crow’s shoulder, as he always did. He was carrying a fresh-cut willow branch and a knife.

“He’s young,” Crow said. “He thinks he can hide his heart. He doesn’t realize his heart is sitting right there on his sleeve for everyone to see.”

“He needs to learn to sit still,” Stone said. “If he can’t sit still for a game, he won’t sit still in a thicket when the Rangers are passing.”

“The Rangers are far away, Stone. Let the boy have his game.”

As if to prove Stone right, Two-Kettles suddenly slapped his hand down on Fox’s right hand. Fox’s face fell. He opened his palm to reveal the white bone. The circle erupted in laughter and shouts, and Two-Kettles gathered up his winnings—a small pile of beads and a hawk feather.

Fox stood up, kicking at the dirt. He saw Crow and Stone watching and walked over, his shoulders high.

“The luck is gone from this spot,” Fox said. “The ground is sour.”

“The ground is fine,” Stone said. “Your head is sour. You were thinking about the bone. You should have been thinking about nothing.”

“How can you win a game if you don’t think about the bone?” Fox asked, exasperated.

“You win by being the bone,” Crow offered, his eyes twinkling. “You must become inanimate, Fox. Like a rock. Or like Stone, here. Nobody ever wins against Stone because nobody can tell if he’s even alive most of the time.”

Stone grunted and began whittling at the willow branch. “I don’t play games.”

“That’s because you’re afraid you’d lose to a donkey,” Crow said.

Fox ignored the banter. He sat down between them, looking out at the darkening horizon. “We should go after that herd tomorrow. If we wait, they’ll move into the broken country. It’ll be twice the work to get the meat out.”

“We go when the horses are ready,” Stone said.

“The horses are ready now,” Fox said. “My paint is fine. The bite didn’t go deep. He’s got fire in him.”

“He has fear in him,” Stone corrected. “That’s not the same as fire. Fear makes a horse run into a hole. Fire makes him run over the thing that’s trying to kill him.”

Stone looked at Crow. “What do you think? About the herd?”

Crow looked up at the stars. The Great Bear was high. “The wind is holding. If we move at first light, we can be on them by the time the sun is up. It’s a good time for a hunt. The calves are fat. Sage will be happy.”

“Sage is never happy,” Stone said, though they both knew he was lying.

“She is happy when there is marrow,” Crow said. “And when I am not talking. If we go on the hunt, I will be too busy to talk. It’s a gift to her.”

Stone stood up, brushing shavings from his leggings. “First light then. Tell the others. But if that paint gelding throws you, Fox, don’t look at me. You’ll walk home.”

“He won’t throw me,” Fox said, his voice regaining its confidence.

Stone walked away toward his lodge, his silhouette sharp against the dying light. Fox stayed for a moment, looking at Crow.

“Do you really think I should become a rock?” the boy asked.

Crow stood up slowly, his joints popping like dry twigs. “In the game, yes. On the hunt, no. On the hunt you just have to be faster than the buffalo.” Crow smiled. “And quieter than Stone, which is impossible. That’s why he does the killing and I do the talking. Now go. Get some sleep.”

As Crow walked back to his own lodge, Rain was already inside, a shape beneath the blankets. He stood at the entrance for a moment, looking out at the dark expanse of the Llano. To anyone else, it was empty. To him, it was a living thing, a giant lung that breathed with the seasons.

The horses were quiet, huddled together against the cool. Only the donkey was still awake, standing near the creek, its long ears twitching as if it were listening to something very far away.

Crow watched it for a moment. Then he dropped the hide flap and went inside.

CHAPTER TWO

The sun was not yet up, but the world had gone grey and sharp-edged, shedding the softness of the night. In the corral, the horses stood with their heads low, breath steaming in the damp air.

Stone was painting his horse. He used a mixture of red ochre and bear grease, kept in a small horn container he wore at his belt. He worked with his thumb, drawing a single jagged line down the shoulder of his roan mare. It was a lightning mark, old medicine intended to give the animal speed and the rider a heavy hand. He did not sing while he did it, and he did not pray aloud. The grease smelled of rancid fat and earth.

Fox was three horses down, working on his paint gelding. The boy was taking longer. He had painted circles around the horse's eyes to help it see danger, and now he was carefully drawing hail stones on the animal's flanks. He was humming something under his breath, a nervous, high-pitched sound that vanished into the silence of the morning.

Crow leaned against a lodge pole, wrapped in his robe, watching them.

"You're putting too much on him," Crow said. "He'll be too heavy to run."

Fox looked up, his thumb hovering over the horse's hip. "It's protection. He needs it."

"He needs legs," Crow said. "Paint doesn't make a horse brave. It just makes him colorful while he runs away."

Stone wiped his thumb on his leggings. He capped the horn container. "Leave the boy alone," he said, though he didn't look at either of them. He checked the cinch on his saddle, a piece of worn Spanish leather that had seen more miles than most men. "If he wants to paint a story, let him paint."

"I'm just saying," Crow murmured. "If the buffalo see that horse, they might die of laughing. Then we save arrows."

Fox scowled and wiped a smudge of ochre from his cheek. "He looks fierce."

"He looks like a clown who fell in the mud," Crow said. But he smiled when he said it, and he walked over to his own horse, a sturdy bay with a scarred neck. Crow did not paint his horse. He tied a hawk feather to the mane and

spat into his palm, rubbing it against the animal's wither. "There. Now we are ready."

They mounted up in the grey light. The camp was quiet, though Crow saw smoke rising from Sage's fire. She would be awake, waiting for the sun, sharpening her knives.

They rode out of the draw and up the slope to the high ground. The grass was wet and brushed against the horses' legs with a hushed, swishing sound. To the west, the land rolled away in long, endless undulations, like a blanket thrown over sleeping giants. It was vast and empty and indifferent.

They rode for two hours without speaking. Stone took the lead, his eyes scanning the horizon, the ground, the sky. He rode loose in the saddle, moving with the roan as if they were cut from the same piece of wood. Fox rode behind him, sitting too straight, his eyes darting at every movement in the grass—a grouse taking flight, a jackrabbit bolting. Crow brought up the rear, letting his mind drift, watching the light change on the distant ridges.

The wind was in their faces. That was good. It kept their scent behind them and brought the news of the world to them.

Around mid-morning, Stone pulled up. He didn't raise a hand; he just stopped, and the others stopped with him. He pointed with his chin toward a low rise a mile to the north.

Crow tasted the air. It was there—the heavy, musk-dust smell of buffalo. Not many, but enough.

"In the hollow," Stone said softly.

They dismounted and led the horses, keeping to the low ground. The silence deepened. The land seemed to hold its breath. The only sounds were the soft thud of hooves on sod and the creak of leather.

When they reached the base of the rise, they checked their weapons. Stone strung his bow, testing the tension. It was a short bow, backed with sinew, powerful enough to drive an arrow through a rib cage. Crow checked his percussion rifle, an old trade gun that fired true if you asked it politely. Fox had a bow as well, new and pale, the wood not yet darkened by grease and sun.

“Remember,” Stone said to Fox. “Don’t chase the herd. Pick one. Ride to it. Put the arrow behind the rib. One shot.”

“I know,” Fox whispered. His hands were shaking slightly.

“And watch the badger holes,” Crow added. “The ground here is rotten with them.”

They remounted. Stone looked at them once, nodded, and kicked his roan into a trot. They crested the rise.

The herd was there—maybe thirty animals, grazing in a grassy bowl. They were dark brown shapes against the yellow grass, massive and hump-backed. A few calves played near the edge. A large bull stood sentinel, his head swinging slowly from side to side.

For a second, nothing happened. The men and the animals stared at each other across two hundred yards of open ground.

Then the bull snorted, a sharp, explosive sound, and the herd moved. They didn’t start slow; they went from standing to running in a heartbeat, a sudden liquid pouring of dark muscle down the valley.

“Hoka!” Stone shouted, and the roan surged forward.

The chase was a blur of wind and dust. The horses flattened their ears and ran, their hooves drumming a frantic rhythm. The buffalo were deceptively fast, their heavy shoulders pumping, tails high.

Crow felt the old thrill rise in his chest, a tightening of the skin. He pushed the bay hard, flanking the herd on the right to turn them back toward the center. Dust rose in choking clouds, gritty and tasting of sage.

Stone was already in the thick of it. He rode fearlessly close to the stampeding animals, his leg brushing against their shaggy flanks. Crow saw him draw, the bow bending into a crescent, and loose. A cow stumbled, went to its knees, and rolled, kicking up a spray of dirt. Stone didn’t look back; he was already nocking another arrow, moving on to the next.

Crow saw a young bull peeling off to the left. He reined the bay around, cutting the angle. The bull saw him and lowered its head, hooking a horn at the horse’s legs. The bay danced sideways—it knew this game—and Crow

leveled the rifle. He waited for the rhythm of the gallop to sync with his heartbeat, then squeezed the trigger. The gun bucked against his shoulder, a cloud of white smoke blinding him for a moment. When the air cleared, the bull was down, thrashing.

He looked for Fox.

The boy was in trouble. He had ridden deep into the dust cloud, chasing a large cow. The paint gelding was panicked, eyes rolling, fighting the bit. It shied violently at a darker patch of grass—a shadow, or a hole—and nearly went down.

Fox lost his seat. He slid sideways, clinging to the mane, one leg dragging perilously close to the pounding hooves.

“Pull up!” Crow shouted, though he knew the boy couldn’t hear him.

Fox didn’t pull up. He hauled himself back into the saddle with a desperate, scrabbling strength. He had lost his bow. He was riding empty-handed in the middle of a stampede.

The cow he had been chasing turned. It was an old animal, mean and cornered. It stopped and swung its heavy head, charging the horse.

The paint screamed and spun. This time, instead of fighting it, Fox let the horse go. He kicked it, hard, and the paint bolted away from the cow, finding a speed it hadn’t shown before. Fox leaned low over the neck, guiding it not away from the herd, but around it.

He was reaching for the knife at his belt.

“The fool,” Crow said aloud. “The brave little fool.”

Fox brought the paint alongside the cow again. The horse was terrified, lathered in sweat, but it responded to the boy’s knees. Fox leaned out, way out, until he was hanging off the side of the horse, and drove the knife downward into the cow’s neck, just behind the skull.

It wasn’t a clean kill. It was messy and dangerous and stupid. But the cow staggered. Its front legs buckled. It plowed into the earth, sliding for ten yards before coming to a stop.

Fox pulled the paint up, circling the fallen animal. He was gasping for air, his face streaked with dust and war paint.

The rest of the herd was gone, disappearing over the next ridge in a thunder of fading hoofbeats.

Silence rushed back into the valley, heavier than before.

Stone rode over to where Fox sat on his trembling horse. He looked at the dead cow. He looked at the knife still buried in its neck. He looked at Fox.

"You lost your bow," Stone said.

Fox wiped his nose with the back of his hand. "I killed the cow."

"You almost killed the horse," Stone said. "And yourself."

"But I killed the cow," Fox insisted, though his voice wavered.

Stone sat there for a long moment. Then he reached out and pulled the knife from the cow's neck. He wiped it on his leggings and handed it back to the boy with the handle first.

"It was a good ride," Stone said.

Fox grinned. It was a wide, white-toothed grin that cracked the dust on his face.

They had four animals down. It was good work. The sun was high now, hot and flat. They dismounted and began the work of skinning. It was hard labor, blood on the hands, flies buzzing, the smell of iron and gut.

An hour later, the sound of dragging poles announced the arrival of the women. Sage and Rain rode into the valley on two old pack ponies, pulling travois behind them.

Sage slid off her pony before it had fully stopped. She walked over to the cow Fox had killed, inspecting it with a critical eye.

"Neck shot," she grunted. "Ruined the hide."

"I killed it with a knife," Fox said, puffing his chest out.

Sage looked at him. "Why? Did you forget how to shoot?"

"I... dropped my bow."

"Hmph." She pulled a skinning knife from her belt. "Well. Meat is meat. But next time, try not to butcher it before it's dead."

Rain went to Crow. She handed him a water skin. He drank deeply, the water cool and sweet.

"You did well," she said, looking at the bull he had shot.

"The gun did well," Crow said. "I just held it." He wiped his forehead. "Fox rode like a Comanche today. Crazy and lucky."

"He is young," Rain said. "Luck is the only thing that keeps the young alive."

They worked through the afternoon, quartering the meat, stripping the fat, loading the travois. The blood soaked into the dry ground, and the valley that had been empty was now a place of harvest.

As they were finishing, tying the last bundles of meat onto the poles, a movement on the ridge caught Crow's eye.

He squinted against the sun.

Standing on the crest, silhouetted against the bright sky, was the donkey.

It stood motionless, its long ears pricked forward, looking down into the valley. It was miles from camp. It had no reason to be there. It had not been invited.

"How?" Fox asked, staring up at it. "How did it follow us?"

"It has a nose," Stone said, tightening a strap. "And nothing better to do."

The donkey watched them. It did not come down. It simply stood there, a grey witness to their labor, judging the quality of their knots and the efficiency of their cuts.

"It's waiting for us to leave," Crow said. "It wants to see if we left any scraps."

"It's a ghost," Fox muttered. "I'm telling you. It's a spirit in a donkey skin."

"It's just an ass," Sage said, climbing back onto her pony. "Like the rest of you. Let's go. The flies are getting bad."

They mounted up and turned the horses toward home, the travois scraping softly over the grass. Crow looked back one last time.

The donkey was still there. As the humans moved away, it lowered its head and began to graze, alone on the ridge, owning the world.

The ride back was slower, the travois heavy with meat. The horses knew they were heading home and did not need to be guided. They picked their way across the plain with their heads low, following the same invisible paths they had made a hundred times before.

The sun was falling toward the western edge of the world when they came down into the draw. The camp emerged from the land like something growing out of it—the lodges dark against the orange sky, smoke rising thin and straight in the still air. Dogs ran out to meet them, barking and circling, and children appeared from behind the lodges to stare at the loaded travois.

Fox rode ahead to announce the kill, sitting tall on his paint, his chest out and his chin up. Crow watched him go and smiled.

“He’ll be telling that story for years,” Rain said. She had pulled her pony alongside Crow’s bay. “The knife kill.”

“He earned it,” Crow said. “Even if he didn’t earn it the way he wanted to.”

“That’s how most things are earned,” Rain said.

They dismounted near the center of camp, and the work began again—unloading, sorting, hanging. The women took over, their hands quick and sure. Sage directed the others with sharp words and sharper gestures, and within an hour the meat was hung on racks, the fat was rendered into pots, and the hides were staked out for scraping.

Crow sat apart, near the dying fire, watching the activity without joining it. His back ached from the ride, and his hands were stiff from the skinning. He was getting old. He knew it, and he didn’t mind knowing it, but he didn’t like being reminded.

Stone came and sat beside him. He didn’t say anything. He just sat, looking at the fire, his face half in shadow.

They were quiet for a while. The sounds of the camp washed over them—voices, laughter, the scrape of knives on hide. A dog fought another dog for a scrap of gristle and lost. Somewhere a child was crying, and somewhere else a woman was singing, and the two sounds braided together into something that felt like home.

“Good hunt,” Crow said finally.

Stone nodded.

“The herd was small, though.”

Stone nodded again.

“Smaller than last year. And last year was smaller than the year before.” Crow picked up a stick and poked at the coals. “I’ve been thinking about it.”

“You’re always thinking about something.”

“This is different.” Crow watched the sparks rise and die. “When I was Fox’s age, the herds went on forever. You could ride for a day and still be in the middle of them. Now we ride for two days to find thirty animals. And we ride farther from the good water because we’re hiding now.” He paused. “Since the Brazos.”

The words hung in the air. Since the Brazos. Since the patrol. Since Hawk and Walks Far.

Stone said nothing. His face was still, but Crow could see the tightness around his eyes—the same tightness that had been there for eight months now.

“The Penateka are trading with the Texians now,” Crow continued. “Two-Kettles heard it from a comanchero last moon. They’re taking cattle in exchange for promises. Land promises.”

“The Penateka have always been too close to the whites.”

“Maybe. But they’re not stupid. If they’re making deals, it’s because they see something coming.” Crow set the stick down. “The same thing that came for us. That patrol wasn’t lost, Stone. They knew where they were. They saw Indians and decided to shoot. No parley. No warning. Just guns.”

Stone turned his head and looked at Crow directly. It was unusual—Stone rarely looked at anyone directly—and it made Crow uncomfortable.

“What do you want me to say?” Stone asked. His voice was low, almost rough. “That the world is changing? I know it’s changing. I’ve known it for twenty years. But knowing doesn’t stop it.”

“I didn’t say it did.”

“Then why talk about it?”

Crow didn’t answer right away. He watched the fire, the coals pulsing like a slow heartbeat. In the distance, the donkey was braying—a long, mournful sound that echoed across the draw.

“Because I’m afraid,” Crow said finally. “Not for me. I’m old. But for Fox. For the children.” He paused. “Hawk was supposed to see what comes after we’re gone. He was supposed to carry it. Now he’s in the ground by the Brazos, and Fox is the one who has to carry it, and I’m afraid of what that means.”

Stone was quiet for a long time. When he spoke, his voice was softer than before.

“My grandmother told me a story once,” he said. “About a man who saw a flood coming. He told everyone in the village, but no one believed him. So he built a raft, alone, and when the water came, he floated away while the others drowned.” Stone paused. “I asked her what happened to the man. She said he lived, but he was never happy again. Because he had saved himself and lost everyone else.”

“What’s the point of that story?”

“I don’t know,” Stone said. “I’ve been trying to figure it out for forty years.”

They sat in silence. The fire burned low. The stars were coming out now, scattered across the sky like seeds thrown by a careless hand.

Rain appeared with two bowls of stew—buffalo meat, wild onion, something green that Crow couldn’t identify. She handed one to each of them and sat down on Crow’s other side.

“You two look like you’re planning a war,” she said.

“We’re planning nothing,” Crow said. “We’re just sitting.”

“You’re brooding. There’s a difference.” She leaned against his shoulder. Her body was warm. “Fox is still telling his story. He’s added a second cow now, and the knife has gotten longer.”

“By morning it will be a sword,” Crow said. “And by next week he’ll have killed the whole herd with his teeth.”

Rain laughed. It was a soft sound, almost private. “Let him have it. He needs something to be proud of.”

“He has plenty to be proud of. He just doesn’t know it yet.”

They ate in silence. The stew was good—rich and hot, with just enough salt. Crow could feel the warmth spreading through his chest, pushing back the chill of the evening.

When they finished, Rain took the bowls and stood up. She looked down at the two men, her face unreadable in the firelight.

“Don’t stay out here all night,” she said. “The cold is coming.”

She walked away toward the lodge. Crow watched her go, the way she moved, the straightness of her back. She had aged well. They both had, he supposed, considering everything.

“She’s worried about you,” Stone said.

“She’s always worried about me. It’s her favorite hobby.”

“She’s not wrong to worry.”

Crow looked at Stone. His face was like carved wood in the dying light—all planes and shadows, revealing nothing.

“What do you mean?”

Stone didn’t answer. He stood up, slowly, his joints creaking. He brushed the dust from his leggings.

“Get some sleep,” he said. “Tomorrow we cut the meat. The day after, we smoke it. The world will still be changing when we’re done.”

He walked away toward his own lodge, his silhouette merging with the darkness.

Crow sat alone by the fire. The coals were grey now, barely glowing. The camp had gone quiet, the sounds of celebration fading into sleep. Somewhere a baby fussed and was soothed. Somewhere a horse stamped.

He thought about what Stone had said — the flood, the man on the raft, the forty years of not understanding. He thought about Rain, waiting in the lodge, and the silence there that wasn't silence at all but a conversation they had been having for thirty years.

The donkey brayed again, far off in the darkness.

Crow stood up. His back ached. He walked toward the lodge, toward the light flickering through the hide walls. Behind him, the fire died to ash, and the stars wheeled overhead, indifferent to the small lives below.

The night was cold. But there was meat on the racks and a warm place to sleep, and that would have to be enough.

CHAPTER THREE

Fox woke with the taste of glory still in his mouth.

He lay on his back in the dim lodge, staring at the smoke hole where the pale morning light was just beginning to seep through. Yesterday he had killed a buffalo with a knife. He had leaned out from his galloping horse, the world blurring around him, and driven the blade into the beast's neck. He had felt the shock of it travel up his arm, felt the animal's life shudder and stop beneath the steel.

He was a man now. A warrior. The camp would know it.

He dressed quickly and stepped outside, expecting—he wasn't sure what. Nods of respect, maybe. A different quality of silence when he passed. Something.

What he found was Sage, standing over a pile of buffalo quarters, holding a skinning knife out toward him.

"You're late," she said. "The flies are already here."

The meat processing had begun at first light. The racks were heavy with dark red muscle, and the smell of it filled the draw—iron and fat and something sweeter underneath, the first edge of rot that would come if they didn't work fast enough. Women moved between the racks with knives and scrapers, slicing meat into thin strips for drying, trimming fat into pots for rendering.

It was hard, ugly work. Fox's work, apparently.

"I killed—" he started.

"I know what you killed," Sage said. "I saw the hide. You ruined it. Now you can help fix it." She thrust the knife at him again. "Start with the backstrap. Cut thin. If you cut thick, the flies lay eggs inside. Then in the winter, when we boil the meat, the maggots float to the top." She smiled, showing her teeth. "I will make sure you get the first bowl."

Fox took the knife. He looked around for an ally—Crow, maybe, or Stone—but Crow was nowhere to be seen and Stone was at the far end of the camp, working on something with his back turned. No rescue was coming.

He found a spot near one of the racks and began to cut. The meat was slippery and cold, and blood ran down his wrists and dripped from his elbows. The flies came almost immediately—big, black, buzzing things that landed on his hands and his face and crawled toward the corners of his eyes. He swatted at them, and Sage clicked her tongue.

“Don’t stop cutting to fight flies. You’ll never win. Just work faster than they do.”

Fox worked. The sun climbed. The smell got worse.

By mid-morning, his back ached and his hands were cramped into claws. The glory of the knife kill seemed very far away. Rain passed by with an armload of intestines—they would be cleaned and used for storing pemmican—and she gave him a small, sympathetic smile, but she didn’t stop to help.

“This is women’s work,” Fox muttered, not quite under his breath.

Sage heard him. She always heard everything.

“This is survival work,” she said. “The kill takes an hour. The work takes a week. Any fool can ride a horse into a herd. It takes patience to turn meat into winter.” She scraped a hide with short, vicious strokes. “Your grandmother did this work. Her grandmother did this work. If you think you’re too good for it, you can eat grass like your horse.”

Fox said nothing. He cut thinner.

The sun was straight overhead when he finally broke.

He had been watching the horizon for the last hour, the vast empty stretch of plain that rolled away to the south. Out there, somewhere, was space. Room to breathe. A place where no one was telling him to cut thinner or scrape harder or hold the pot steady while the fat rendered.

He set down his knife and walked toward the horse line.

Stone was there, brushing down his roan. He didn’t look up as Fox approached, but his hands slowed slightly on the horse’s flank.

"I thought I'd ride out," Fox said. "Check on the herd. See if any strays split off yesterday."

Stone said nothing for a long moment. He ran his hand down the roan's leg, checking for heat or swelling.

"The herd went north," Stone said finally. "You want to ride south."

Fox felt his face flush. "I might circle around. Come at them from the other side."

Stone straightened. He looked at Fox directly, his dark eyes flat and unreadable. Fox waited for the refusal, the lecture, the order to get back to the meat racks.

"Take water," Stone said. "And be back before dark."

Fox blinked. "I—yes. I will."

He saddled the paint gelding quickly, before Stone could change his mind. The horse was still nervous from yesterday, ears swiveling at every sound, but it held steady as Fox mounted. He could feel Stone's eyes on his back as he rode out of the draw and up onto the high ground.

He didn't look back.

The plains opened around him like a held breath finally released.

Fox pushed the paint into an easy lope, feeling the wind on his face and the rhythm of the horse beneath him. This was what he needed. Not the blood and flies and endless cutting, but this—the world stretching out in every direction, the grass hissing against the horse's legs, the sky so big it made him dizzy to look at it.

He was a hunter. A rider. A man who had killed with a knife. He needed room to be that man.

He rode south for an hour, then east, making a wide loop that took him nowhere in particular. He wasn't really looking for strays. Stone had known that. Fox had known Stone knew. But the old man had let him go anyway, and Fox was grateful for it, even if he didn't understand why.

The sun was past its peak when he spotted the cart.

It was a small, rickety thing, pulled by a single mule that looked even more miserable than Crow's donkey. A canvas tarp covered the bed, stained and patched in a dozen places. And walking beside it, leading the mule by a frayed rope, was a man Fox recognized.

Refugio.

The comanchero was thinner than Fox remembered, his clothes more ragged, his beard longer and streaked with grey. But it was him—the same narrow face, the same quick dark eyes that seemed to be laughing at something even when his mouth was still.

Fox reined up. His hand went to the knife at his belt without thinking.

"Ho, little warrior," Refugio said. He didn't stop walking, and the mule didn't stop plodding, so Fox had to turn the paint and fall in alongside them. "I know you, yes? From the camp in the draw. The one with the old men and the angry women." His eyes flickered to Fox's face, reading something there. "I heard about the patrol. The Brazos. I am sorry for your father."

Fox's hand tightened on the reins. He hadn't expected that—hadn't expected anyone outside the camp to know, or to care. "How did you hear?"

"The plains talk, little warrior. The wind carries stories. The comancheros carry more." Refugio shrugged. "The soldiers brag in the forts. They think they are heroes."

Fox felt something hot and sick rise in his chest. "They murdered him. Him and Hawk both. They didn't even—"

"I know." Refugio's voice was flat now, the false cheer gone. "I know what they do. I have seen it before. I will see it again." He walked in silence for a moment. "You want revenge, yes? I can see it in your face. You want to find those soldiers and open their bellies."

"Yes," Fox said. The word came out before he could stop it.

"Good. Keep it. But don't spend it yet—anger is currency, and you only get to spend it once." Refugio's smile returned, thinner now. "Now. I know you also because you sold us a donkey."

"You sold *us* a donkey," Fox corrected, his voice still hard.

"Ah, the donkey." Refugio's face split into a grin, showing gaps where teeth had been. "A fine animal. Strong. Patient. How is he?"

"He bit my horse."

"He is spirited. This is a feature, not a flaw." Refugio glanced at Fox's paint, at the healing mark on its neck. "Your horse should learn to bite back."

Fox didn't know what to say to that. He had imagined this encounter differently—had imagined being older, harder, more imposing. In his imagination, he would tell the comanchero exactly what he thought of that devil donkey, and the man would cower, or at least look impressed.

Instead, Refugio was smiling at him like he was a child who had said something amusing.

"I killed a buffalo yesterday," Fox said. "With a knife."

"With a knife?" Refugio raised his eyebrows. "That is something. That is a story." He looked Fox up and down. "You do not look injured."

"I wasn't injured. I rode alongside it and drove the blade into its neck."

"Ah." Refugio nodded slowly. "And where is this knife now?"

Fox's hand went to his belt. The knife was there, cleaned and sharpened, the same knife Stone had handed back to him after pulling it from the buffalo's spine. "Here."

"Good. You should keep it close. There is trouble coming from the east, little warrior. A man with a good knife may need it soon."

Fox felt something shift in his chest. "What trouble?"

Refugio shrugged, but the gesture was too loose, too practiced. "Who can say? The Texians make trouble the way other men breathe. The soldiers march and march. They don't even know where they're going half the time." He spat into the dust. "I saw something, two days ago. Out past the salt flats. A man walking."

"A man walking isn't trouble."

"This one was." Refugio's eyes went distant for a moment, his smile fading. "He was not walking like a man walks. He was walking like a dead man who forgot to fall down. A scarecrow, you understand? Stuffed with straw and barely held together." He shook his head. "I did not stop to talk to him. I am a trader, not a priest. But he was coming this way. From the east."

Fox looked toward the horizon. The heat shimmered over the grass, making the distance waver and dance. There was nothing out there. Just emptiness.

"Maybe he died," Fox said.

"Maybe." Refugio shrugged again. "Or maybe he is still walking. The dead are stubborn sometimes. They don't know when to stop." He reached under the tarp of his cart and pulled out a battered pistol, the metal pitted with rust. "You want to buy a gun, little warrior? For the trouble that is coming?"

Fox looked at the pistol. It looked like it would blow up in his hand if he tried to fire it.

"No."

"Smart boy. It is a terrible gun. I would not shoot it myself." Refugio tucked it back under the tarp. "What about whiskey? I have whiskey that will make you see your ancestors."

"No."

"Also smart. It is terrible whiskey." Refugio grinned again, and for a moment he looked almost kind. "Go home, little warrior. Go back to your old men and your angry women and your biting donkey. The plains are no place to be alone. Not now. Not with scarecrows walking and soldiers marching and the world ending for someone every day."

He clicked his tongue at the mule, and the cart creaked forward, heading west. Fox sat on his horse and watched him go.

The plains felt different now. Bigger. Emptier. The wind that had felt like freedom an hour ago now felt like something else—like the breath of something vast and indifferent, something that didn't care whether Fox lived or died or ever made it home.

He turned the paint and started back toward the camp.

He rode slowly, in no hurry to return.

The glory of the knife kill was gone now, replaced by something heavier. He kept thinking about what Refugio had said. A scarecrow. A dead man walking. He had seen the comanchero's eyes when he said it, the way the smile had slipped for just a moment. Refugio was a liar and a cheat and probably a coward, but he had been afraid of something out there. Fox was sure of it.

The sun was low when he came down into the draw. The camp was quiet, the meat processing done for the day. Smoke rose from the cook fires, and the smell of roasting fat drifted on the cooling air. It should have felt like home. It did feel like home. But something was different.

Fox unsaddled the paint and rubbed it down, taking his time. Stone was nowhere to be seen. Sage was stirring a pot over the fire, and she didn't look up as he passed. Rain was sitting outside Crow's lodge, mending a tear in a hide shirt.

He walked to the edge of the camp and stood there, looking east.

The horizon was empty. Just grass and sky and the last red light of the sun staining the clouds. No scarecrow. No dead man walking. Nothing but the wind moving through the sage.

But Fox stood there anyway, watching, until the light was gone and the stars began to appear. He couldn't have said what he was looking for. He only knew that the world felt larger than it had this morning, and he felt smaller in it.

When he finally turned back toward his lodge, Crow was sitting by the fire, watching him.

"Did you find your strays?" the old man asked. His voice was mild, but his eyes were sharp.

"No," Fox said.

"Did you find anything?"

Fox hesitated. He thought about telling Crow what Refugio had said—the trouble from the east, the scarecrow, the dead man walking. But standing here in the firelight, with the smell of meat and smoke and the sounds of the camp settling into sleep, it all seemed far away. Like a story someone had told him. Like a dream he was already forgetting.

“No,” he said. “Nothing.”

Crow looked at him for a long moment. Then he nodded, slowly, and turned back to the fire.

“Get some sleep,” he said. “Tomorrow there’s more work.”

Fox went to his lodge. He lay down on his blankets and stared at the dark.

He didn’t sleep for a long time. And when he finally did, he dreamed of a figure on the horizon—a scarecrow stuffed with straw, walking toward him across the endless grass, getting closer with every step, and where its face should have been there was only dark.

CHAPTER FOUR

Fox saw him first.

He had been watching the horizon since dawn, unable to stop himself. The meat racks needed tending, and Sage had already snapped at him twice for standing idle, but his eyes kept drifting east, toward the place where the sky met the grass in a shimmering line. He told himself he was looking for nothing. He told himself Refugio was a liar and a drunk and the scarecrow was just a story to scare boys.

But he kept looking anyway.

The figure appeared around mid-morning, when the sun was high enough to burn the dew off the grass but not yet hot enough to make the air dance. At first Fox thought it was a trick of the light—a shadow, maybe, or a coyote moving through the sage. But it didn't move like a coyote. It moved like a man. Barely.

"Something's coming," Fox said.

Crow was sitting near the fire, scraping a hide with slow, methodical strokes. He looked up, following Fox's gaze.

"Where?"

"East. On the flat."

Crow set down the scraper and stood. His knees popped, loud in the morning quiet. He shaded his eyes with one hand and stared at the horizon for a long moment.

"Get Stone," he said.

Fox ran.

By the time Stone reached the edge of the camp, the figure was close enough to see clearly. It was a man—or what was left of one. He walked with a lurching, uneven gait, like a puppet whose strings had been cut and restrung badly. His clothes hung off him in tatters. His hair was long and matted and fell across his face like a curtain.

He was still half a mile out, but they could see he was struggling to make it.

“He’s dying,” Fox said.

“He’s been dying for a while,” Crow said. “He just hasn’t finished yet.”

Stone said nothing. He watched the figure with the same flat expression he wore when studying a wounded animal—assessing, calculating, deciding. Then he started walking.

“Stay here,” he said over his shoulder.

He didn’t run. Stone never ran. But he covered the ground faster than seemed possible for a man his age, his long legs eating up the distance in steady, swinging strides. Crow and Fox watched him go.

The figure saw Stone coming. It stopped, swayed, and then crumpled to its knees. By the time Stone reached it, it was on all fours, head hanging, body shaking with the effort of drawing breath.

Stone knelt beside the man. They were too far away to hear what was said—if anything was said at all. But they saw Stone put his hand on the man’s shoulder. They saw the man’s head come up, just slightly, and then fall again.

Stone lifted him. It wasn’t easy—the man was tall, taller than Stone—but Stone got him up and over his shoulder and started walking back toward the camp. The man’s arms hung limp, swaying with each step.

“Get Rain,” Crow said to Fox. “And Sage. Tell them to bring water and blankets.”

Fox ran again.

They laid him in Crow’s lodge, on a pile of buffalo robes near the fire. Rain knelt beside him, pressing a wet cloth to his cracked lips. Sage stood at the entrance, her arms crossed, her face unreadable.

The man was in bad shape. His skin was burned dark by the sun and then burned again, layer upon layer, until it looked like leather stretched over bone. His lips were split and bleeding. His feet, when they pulled off his

ruined moccasins, were raw and blistered, the soles worn through to red meat.

“How far did he walk?” Fox asked from the entrance. He wasn’t allowed inside, but no one had told him to leave.

“Far,” Rain said quietly. She dipped the cloth in water and pressed it to the man’s forehead. “Very far.”

“Is he Comanche?”

“No.”

“Kiowa?”

Sage made a sharp sound with her tongue. “Look at his shirt, boy. What’s left of it. Look at the pattern.”

Fox looked. The shirt was little more than rags now, but he could see traces of design in the remaining fabric—geometric shapes, a style of beadwork he didn’t recognize.

“I don’t know it,” he admitted.

“Cherokee,” Sage said. “From the east. Past the big river.” She looked at the man’s face, at the shape of his bones, the cast of his features. “A long way from home.”

Crow appeared at the entrance, his bulk blocking the light. “Will he live?”

Rain didn’t answer right away. She was peeling back the man’s shirt, revealing the rack of his ribs, the sunken hollow of his stomach. He looked like something that had been left in the desert to dry.

As she worked the ruined fabric away from his skin, something fell from a hidden fold near his chest—a small piece of cloth, faded and stained. Rain picked it up. It was a ribbon, the color of old roses, frayed at the edges but carefully preserved. She looked at it for a moment, then set it gently beside the man’s head, within reach of his hand.

“Maybe,” she said finally. “If we can get water into him. If his body remembers how to live.” She looked up at Crow. “It will be close.”

Crow nodded. He looked at the man for a long moment, then turned and walked away.

The day passed slowly. The camp went about its work, but the rhythm was off. People spoke in low voices, glancing toward Crow's lodge. The children were kept away. Even the dogs seemed to sense something was wrong—they lay in the shade with their ears flat, watching.

Stone sat outside the lodge, not moving, not speaking. He had been there since he carried the man in. He didn't eat. He didn't drink. He just sat, his eyes fixed on something no one else could see.

Crow sat beside him for a while, but he couldn't match Stone's stillness. He got up, walked to the horse line, walked back. Checked on the meat racks. Spoke to Sage about nothing. Came back and sat down again.

"Who is he?" Crow asked finally.

Stone didn't answer.

"A Cherokee, Sage says. From past the big river." Crow picked up a stick and drew a line in the dirt. "That's a long way to walk. Months. Why would a man walk that far?"

Stone still didn't answer. But his jaw tightened, just slightly, and Crow knew he was thinking the same thing.

A man didn't walk that far unless he was running from something. Or toward something. And a man who arrived looking like death itself—a scarecrow, Fox had called him, repeating the comanchero's word—had seen things worth running from.

The afternoon stretched on. The sun moved across the sky. Inside the lodge, Rain worked in silence, dripping water between the man's lips, bathing his wounds with wet cloth, singing softly in a language she rarely used.

He woke at dusk.

Rain was there when his eyes opened. She saw the confusion first—the wild, animal look of a man who didn't know where he was. Then the fear. Then,

slowly, something else. Understanding, maybe. Or just exhaustion too deep to fight anymore.

“Water,” he said. His voice was a ruin, scraped raw by thirst and disuse.

She held the skin to his lips and let him drink. He drank too fast and choked, and she pulled it away, waited, and let him drink again.

“Slowly,” she said. “There’s time.”

He finished drinking and lay back, his chest rising and falling in shallow, uneven breaths. His eyes moved around the lodge, taking in the hide walls, the smoke hole, the fire. He looked at Rain.

“Where?” he asked.

“The Llano. The Staked Plains.” She set the water skin aside. “You’re in a Comanche camp. You’re safe.”

His eyes shifted at the word Comanche. Not fear, exactly. More like recognition of an old story, a distant name that had once meant something.

“I’m Rain,” she said. “What’s your name?”

He was quiet for a long moment. When he spoke, his voice was stronger, though still rough.

“They call me Ridge,” he said. His voice was slow, each word an effort. “My mother called me Kananoheda. The one who walks where others cannot.” He tried to smile, but it came out as a grimace. “She was too kind.”

They gathered in the lodge as the darkness deepened. Crow sat near the fire, his face half in shadow. Stone sat behind him, back against the lodge poles, his presence a solid weight in the dim space. Rain stayed near the injured man, ready with water. Sage stood by the entrance, keeping the curious away.

Fox was allowed inside this time. No one said why, but Crow had gestured for him to enter, and he had sat down near the back, trying to make himself small.

Ridge was propped up on the buffalo robes, his back against a rolled blanket. He looked like a corpse that had decided to keep talking—all bones and hollows and eyes that seemed too large for his face. But his voice was steady now, stronger with each sip of water.

“You want to know why I’m here,” Ridge said. He looked at the fire.

“Yes,” Crow said.

Ridge nodded slowly. He looked at the fire, at the flames dancing in the darkness, and when he spoke again, his voice had changed. It was flatter, more distant, like he was reciting something he had memorized long ago.

“I was born in the mountains,” he said. “In the place your people call the land of the dawn. The Cherokee have lived there since the beginning. Since the world was young.” He paused. “We had towns. Schools. A newspaper that printed our words in our own writing. We wore their clothes and spoke their language and prayed to their god.”

He looked at Crow. “Do you understand? We did everything they asked. We became what they said we should become.”

Crow said nothing. He waited.

“It wasn’t enough.” Ridge’s voice hardened. “It was never going to be enough. They wanted the land. Gold, they said. They found gold in our mountains, and after that, nothing we had done mattered. Not the schools. Not the treaties. Not the promises.”

“Who?” Fox asked from the back. “Who wanted the land?”

“Georgia. The state of Georgia. The soldiers. The President.” Ridge made a sound that might have been a laugh. “All of them. They passed a law. They said we had to leave. They said we had to walk to a place past the big river—a place none of us had ever seen—and make a new home there.”

“And you walked?” Crow asked.

“No. Not at first.” Ridge’s eyes went distant. “Some of us fought. Some of us hid. Some of us tried to go to the white man’s courts, tried to use their own laws against them. We won. The white chiefs in the stone house said

we had the right to stay.” He shook his head. “The great soldier chief said he did not care. He would do what he wanted anyway.”

The fire crackled. Somewhere outside, a horse stamped and snorted.

“They came in the summer,” Ridge continued. “Soldiers. They went from house to house, farm to farm. They gave us nothing. No time to pack, no time to sell, no time to bury our dead. They marched us to camps—stockades, like pens for cattle—and they held us there while the sickness spread.”

“Sickness?” Rain asked softly.

“Fever. Flux. The children died first. Then the old ones.” Ridge’s voice had gone flat again, mechanical. “We buried them in pits because there was no time for proper graves. And then, when the leaves turned, they marched us west.”

He stopped. His breathing was ragged, and Rain moved closer with the water, but he waved her away.

“How many?” Stone asked. It was the first time he had spoken. His voice was low, almost gentle.

Ridge looked at him. “Fifteen thousand started the walk. Maybe more. They didn’t count us carefully.” He paused. “Four thousand died. Maybe more. They didn’t count the dead carefully either.”

The silence in the lodge was absolute. Even the fire seemed to burn quieter.

“My wife died on the trail,” Ridge said. “My daughter. My mother. I buried them in places I will never find again, in soil that is not ours, under skies they never knew.” His voice cracked, and for a moment the flat recitation gave way to something raw and broken. “I carried my daughter for three days after she stopped breathing. I couldn’t—I didn’t know how to—”

He stopped. He pressed his hands over his face and his shoulders shook, but no sound came out. Rain reached out and put her hand on his arm, and he let her, and they stayed that way for a long time.

When he spoke again, his voice was quiet.

“We called it Nunna daul Isunyi. The trail where we cried.” He lowered his hands. His eyes were dry, but something in them had changed. “I walked it to the end. To the place they said was ours now. I stayed there for one winter. And then I realized that I need to go back.”

“Why?” Crow asked. “Why go back?”

Ridge looked at him. “Because they are still there. The men who did this. The soldiers. The President. They are alive, and my daughter is dead, and I will not let that stand.”

The words hung in the air like smoke.

“You want to kill them,” Stone said.

“Yes.”

“One man. Against an army. Against a government.”

“Yes.”

Stone was quiet for a long moment. When he spoke again, his voice was rough, as if the words were being pulled out of him against his will.

“My brother died eight months ago. Walks Far. A patrol found him and two others near the Brazos. They didn’t ask questions. They just shot.” Stone’s hands were still in his lap, but his knuckles had gone white. “I wasn’t there. I was here, mending a bridle, while they put him in the ground.”

Ridge looked at Stone. Something passed between them—recognition, maybe. The understanding of men who carried the same weight.

“Did you find them?” Ridge asked. “The soldiers?”

“No. We moved the camp. We hid.” Stone’s voice was flat. “We did nothing.”

“I’m sorry,” Ridge said.

“Don’t be. It’s not finished yet.” Stone nodded slowly. He didn’t say it was impossible. He didn’t say it was foolish. He just nodded, as if Ridge had said something that made perfect sense.

Crow leaned forward. “You walked all this way—nearly died on the plains—to kill the men who took your land?”

“Not my land,” Ridge said. “My daughter. My wife. My mother.” He met Crow’s eyes. “They can keep the land. The land is just dirt. I want their blood.”

Crow was quiet for a moment. Then he asked the question that had been forming since Ridge first spoke.

“Why here? Why come to us?”

Ridge looked at him. “Because I can’t do it alone. As Stone said one man against the President. Against the army. I would die before I got close.” He paused. “The tribes near us—the Choctaw, the Creek, the Chickasaw—they walked the same trail we did. They’re broken. Scattered. Watched. They won’t fight. They can’t.”

“And you thought we would?”

“I thought you might.” Ridge’s eyes moved to Stone, then back to Crow. “In Indian Territory, the comancheros come through. They trade, they talk, they carry news. They told me about the Comanche—that you were still fighting. That you had never signed treaties. That you answered blood with blood.” He paused. “One of them told me about a band that had lost men to a patrol near the Brazos. He said you had moved into the draws to hide, but you hadn’t forgotten.”

The lodge was silent. Crow could feel Stone’s stillness beside him.

“You came looking for us,” Crow said.

“I came looking for men who might understand.” Ridge’s voice was fading, exhaustion pulling at him. “I had a horse when I left the Territory. A good one. It died five days ago—stepped in a prairie dog hole, broke its leg. I was too deep into the plains to turn back. So I walked on.”

“Five days,” Stone said. “Without a horse. Without water.”

“I had water for two days. Then it ran out.” Ridge closed his eyes. “I thought I would die out there. I almost did. But I kept walking, because the only thing worse than dying on the plains would be dying without seeing Jackson face-to-face.”

His voice was fading. Rain moved to pull a blanket over him, but Ridge's eyes opened again, fixed on the lodge entrance. A shape had appeared there—long ears, a gray muzzle, an expression of profound disapproval.

The donkey stood in the doorway, staring at him.

Ridge stared back. He had seen donkeys before, had owned one in another life, but he had never seen one look at him quite like this—with the weary, long-suffering judgment of an elder watching a fool explain his mistakes.

"Friend of yours?" Ridge asked Rain.

"He belongs to the camp. He belongs to himself, really." Rain glanced at the donkey. "He doesn't like strangers."

"He doesn't like anyone," Sage said from behind the animal. "Move, you."

The donkey didn't move. It held Ridge's gaze for another long moment, flicked one ear as if marking something down for future reference, and then turned and walked away with the slow dignity of a creature who had seen everything and expected nothing.

"He'll warm up to you," Rain said.

Ridge closed his eyes. "I doubt it."

Later, after Ridge had fallen into an exhausted sleep and the others had filed out of the lodge, Crow and Stone sat by the fire outside. The night was cold, and the stars were sharp and bright, scattered across the sky like broken glass.

Neither of them spoke for a long time.

Finally, Crow said, "He came looking for us."

Stone poked at the fire with a stick. Sparks rose and vanished into the dark.

"Yes."

"He wants us to go with him. To kill the President. The Secretary of War. Jackson." Crow let the words sit in the air, hearing how they sounded. "It's madness."

“Yes.”

They sat in silence. The camp was quiet around them, the lodges dark, the people sleeping. Only the horses moved, shifting and stamping at the edge of the firelight.

“But he’s going to try,” Crow said. “With us or without us.”

“Without us, he dies before he gets close. He said so himself.”

“And with us?”

Stone was quiet for a long moment. “Maybe we all die. Maybe we don’t.” He set down the stick. “But we’d die doing something. Not hiding in a draw, waiting for the next patrol to find us.”

He looked at Crow, his face unreadable in the dim light.

“He’s already dead,” Stone said. “He died on that trail with his daughter. What’s walking now is just the part that won’t lie down.” He paused. “I’ve seen it before. Men who lose everything. They don’t want to live. They just want to finish.”

Crow thought about that. He thought about Hawk, dead eight months now, buried by the Brazos in soil that should have been his to hunt and live on for another fifty years. He thought about the soldiers who had done it—who were probably still alive, still wearing their blue coats, still bragging in some fort about the Indians they had killed. He thought about what it would feel like to find them.

“He said they played by the rules,” Crow said slowly. “The Cherokee. They did everything the white men asked, and it didn’t matter.”

“No.”

“And we haven’t done any of that. We haven’t built their schools or prayed to their god or signed their treaties.”

Stone said nothing.

“So when they come for us,” Crow continued, “and they will come—you know they will—we won’t even have the lie to hide behind. We won’t be able to say we tried.” He picked up a stick and broke it in half. “Hawk would

have been a good fighter. He was fast. He listened. He would have made them pay something before they took him down.”

“He didn’t get the chance,” Stone said.

“No. He was hunting. Just hunting. And now he’s dead, and the men who killed him are drinking whiskey somewhere, and we’re sitting here in the dark talking about how the world is changing.” Crow threw the broken stick into the fire. “I’m tired of talking, Stone.”

Stone looked at him. In thirty years, Crow had never seen quite that expression on his friend’s face—something between grief and hunger.

“So am I,” Stone said.

The fire burned low. The cold crept in.

“What are you thinking?” Stone asked.

Crow didn’t answer right away. He looked up at the stars, at the vast wheel of light turning slowly overhead. He thought about the distance—the distance the Cherokee man had walked, the distance the soldiers had marched, the distance between where they were and where the world was heading.

“I’m thinking,” he said finally, “that the world is smaller than it used to be. And getting smaller every day.”

Stone grunted. He already knew.

They sat there until the fire died to embers, and the cold drove them finally to their lodges. But neither of them slept well that night. And when the sun rose, pale and thin on the eastern horizon, they were both already awake, watching it come, thinking about the man who had walked out of it and the story he had brought with him.

CHAPTER FIVE

A week passed before Ridge could stand without swaying.

For the first few days he slept, waking only to drink the water Rain pressed to his lips. By the fourth day he could sit up, eat a little broth, and watch the camp through the open flap of the lodge with a stillness that gave nothing back. By the end of the week he walked.

He moved like a man learning his own body again—careful, deliberate, testing each step before committing to it. The sun was high and the camp was busy with the small tasks of living: women scraping hides, children chasing dogs, horses stamping at flies near the creek. Ridge stood at the edge of it all, watching.

He did not fit here. Crow could see it from across the camp, where he sat mending a torn bridle strap. Ridge stood wrong—too stiff, too still, like a man waiting to be struck. His eyes moved too much. Among the Cherokee he had probably seemed calm, measured. Here, among people who read the wind and the grass and the smallest flicker of movement, he looked like a rabbit in a clearing.

Sage saw it too. She was grinding dried meat near the fire, her stone pestle rising and falling in a steady rhythm, but her eyes kept drifting to the stranger. Her face showed nothing, but Crow knew what she was thinking. She had called Ridge a ghost the night before, when she thought no one was listening. A dead man walking. She wasn't wrong.

Fox was watching Ridge as well. The boy had found reasons to be nearby all morning—fetching water he didn't need, checking horses that didn't need checking. He circled the Cherokee like a hawk circling something it couldn't quite identify. Crow had seen that look before. It was hunger dressed up as curiosity.

Stone saw it too. He was working on arrow shafts near the horse line, his hands busy, his eyes on Fox. He said nothing, but his jaw was tight.

Ridge walked slowly toward the woodpile at the edge of camp. He picked up a few sticks, testing their weight. Then he bent and began gathering more,

moving with that same careful deliberation. He was trying to be useful. Trying to earn his place.

Sage's pestle stopped mid-stroke. She watched Ridge carry the wood toward the fire, then set it down at a distance that was either respectful or uncertain.

"You should be resting," she said. Her voice was flat.

"I've rested enough." Ridge's voice was stronger than it had been, but still rough. "I wanted to help."

"We don't need help carrying wood. The children do that."

Ridge looked at her. He looked at her a moment longer than he needed to, then nodded slowly and stepped back.

"I meant no offense."

"You gave none." Sage picked up the pestle and began grinding again, harder than before. "But a man who can barely stand should not be carrying burdens. Sit. Eat. Get strong. Then we'll see what you can carry."

Ridge sat. He didn't argue. He watched the camp move around him, and Crow watched him watching, and the morning stretched on toward noon.

The sun was past its peak when Fox finally approached.

Ridge was sitting near the creek, in a patch of shade where the willows bent low over the water. He had a stick in his hand and was drawing something in the mud—long lines, curves, shapes that meant nothing to anyone passing by. Fox came up behind him and stood there, not speaking, waiting to be noticed.

Ridge didn't look up. "You've been following me all day."

"I wasn't following."

"You were circling. Like a coyote." Ridge's stick moved through the mud, scratching a long curving line. "If you have questions, ask them."

Fox sat down on the bank, a few feet away. He looked at the shapes in the mud. "What is that?"

“A map.” Ridge drew another line, then tapped the stick at a point near his feet. “This is where we are. The Llano.” He drew a series of small marks. “Here are the mountains—the ones you call the backbone of the world. And here—” he scratched a wide, sinuous curve, “—is the big river. The one that runs to the sea.”

“The Mississippi.”

“You know it?”

“I’ve heard of it. The traders talk about it.” Fox leaned forward, studying the mud. “I’ve never seen it.”

“It’s wide. Wider than you can imagine.” Ridge’s stick moved east of the river, drawing a cluster of marks. “Here are the mountains again—different mountains. Smaller. Green. And here—” he drew a small square, “—is the stone village. Washington. That’s where the President lives. That’s where I’m going.”

Fox was quiet for a moment. Then: “I want to come with you.”

Ridge didn’t look up. “This isn’t a raid, boy. This isn’t counting coup or coming back with stories. I’m going to kill three men and then I’m going to die. That’s the shape of it.”

“I know what death looks like.” Fox’s voice was harder now. “My father died eight months ago. A patrol killed him near the Brazos—shot him while he was hunting. Two-Kettles watched it happen. I wrapped my father in a blanket and put him in the ground.” He paused. “So don’t tell me what I understand.”

Ridge was quiet for a long moment. He looked at Fox the way a man looks at his own reflection in bad water.

“Walks Far was your father.”

“Stone’s brother. My father. Same man.”

Ridge nodded slowly. He picked up the stick again and looked at the map—the long road east, the river, the mountains, the stone village.

“This is death walking slow,” he said quietly. “You understand that?”

“Yes.”

Ridge didn’t answer. He just sat there, looking at the map, and after a while Fox stood up and walked back toward the camp. Ridge stayed where he was, alone by the water, drawing lines in the mud that the creek would wash away by morning.

That evening, they gathered by the fire.

It wasn’t planned—no one had called a council or announced a meeting. But as the sun went down and the shadows lengthened across the draw, they found themselves drifting toward the flames: Crow and Rain, Stone and Ridge, Fox hovering at the edge like he couldn’t decide if he belonged. Even Sage was there, standing back from the circle, her arms crossed and her face hard.

Ridge was stronger now. He sat with his back straight and his hands resting on his knees, and when he spoke his voice carried the weight of a man who had thought about these words for a long time.

“You know why I came,” he said. “I told you about the trail. I told you about my daughter, my wife, my mother. But I didn’t tell you everything.”

Crow watched him. “Tell us now.”

Ridge nodded. “Before the soldiers came—before the march, before the camps—we tried everything. We went to their courts. We learned their laws. We dressed like them, spoke like them, prayed to their god.” He paused. “We thought if we played by their rules, they would have to honor the game.”

“And?” Stone’s voice was low.

“They didn’t.” Ridge’s jaw tightened. “Georgia passed laws saying they could take our land. We said: this is wrong. We took it to the highest court in their nation—nine men in black robes who sit in a stone building and decide what is just. We argued our case. We showed them the treaties. We proved that Georgia had no right.”

“What did they say?”

“They said we were correct. The Cherokee are a nation. Georgia has no authority over us.” Ridge smiled, but there was no warmth in it. “We won.”

Crow frowned. “Then how—”

“Jackson.” The name came out like a curse. “The President. Andrew Jackson. When he heard the ruling, he said: ‘The judge has made his decision. Now let him enforce it.’ And then he sent the soldiers to take our land anyway.”

The fire crackled. No one spoke.

“You understand what I’m telling you,” Ridge said. “We played their game. We won their game. And they changed the rules. They ignored their own laws, their own courts, their own promises. They marched us out of our homes at gunpoint because they wanted our land and they had the guns to take it.”

Stone was staring at the flames, his face unreadable. But Crow saw the stillness in his shoulders, the tension in his hands.

“Their own laws,” Stone said finally. “They broke their own laws.”

“Yes.”

“And no one stopped them.”

“No one could. The court has no soldiers. The President does.”

Crow thought about that. He thought about all the treaties the Comanche had never signed, all the promises they had never made, all the schools they had never built. The Cherokee had done everything right and it hadn’t mattered. What chance did anyone else have?

“This man,” Crow said slowly. “Jackson. He’s the one who signed the order?”

“He signed the Indian Removal Act. He sent the soldiers. He ignored the court.” Ridge’s eyes were hard. “He’s retired now. Living in a big house in Tennessee, surrounded by slaves, telling stories about his glory days. He thinks he’s safe. He thinks it’s over.”

“But it’s not.”

“No.” Ridge looked around the circle—at Crow, at Stone, at Fox, at the women standing in the shadows. “It won’t be over until he’s dead. Him, and Van Buren, and Poinsett. The President who sent the troops. The Secretary who planned the march. The man who signed the law.” He paused. “Three men. That’s all. Three men who thought they could murder a nation and walk away.”

The fire burned low. The stars were coming out, scattered across the sky like sparks from a distant blaze.

“How far is it?” Crow asked. “To where these men are?”

“Washington is two moons’ travel. Maybe more. Tennessee is on the way.” Ridge looked at the fire. “It’s a long road. But I walked it once. I can walk it again.”

“Not alone,” Stone said.

Ridge looked at him.

“You said it yourself. One man against an army is death. One man can’t get close.” Stone’s voice was flat, but something burned beneath it. “But five men—five men who know how to move, how to wait, how to kill—that’s different.”

“You’re offering to come.”

“I’m saying I’m tired of hiding.” Stone stood up. He was tall in the firelight, his shadow stretching back into the darkness. “My brother died near the Brazos. Shot by soldiers who didn’t even know his name. I’ve been sitting in this draw for eight months, waiting for something. I think this is it.”

Crow felt Rain’s eyes on him. He didn’t look at her.

“I’ll go,” he said. The words came out before he could stop them. “I’ll go with you.”

Sage made a sharp sound—something between a gasp and a curse. She stepped forward, her face contorted.

“You’re fools,” she said. “All of you. You’re going to ride a thousand miles to kill three men you’ve never met, for a Cherokee you found half-dead in

the grass. And for what? Revenge? Justice?" She spat into the fire. "There's no justice. There's only survival. And you're throwing that away."

"Mother—" Stone started.

"Don't." Her voice cracked like a whip. "I lost Walks Far. I will not lose you too. I will not lose Fox." She turned on Ridge, her eyes burning. "You came here to die. Fine. Die. But don't drag my family into your grave."

Ridge met her gaze. He didn't flinch.

"You're right," he said quietly. "I came here to die. But I came here hoping I wouldn't have to die alone, and I found men who have their own reasons to go. If your family chooses to come with me, that's their choice. Not mine."

"They don't know what they're choosing."

"Yes, we do." It was Fox who spoke. He stepped into the circle, his young face set and hard. "We know exactly what we're choosing. We're choosing to stop waiting. To stop hiding. To do something instead of sitting here counting the days until the next patrol finds us."

Sage stared at him. For a moment she looked like she might strike him. Then her face crumpled, just for an instant, before she pulled it back together.

"You're a boy," she whispered.

"I'm what's left of my father," Fox said. "And I'm going."

The fire popped and hissed. No one else spoke.

After a long moment, Sage turned and walked away into the darkness. They heard her footsteps fade, heard the flap of a lodge close. Then there was only the fire and the night.

Later, when the camp was dark and quiet, Sage found Rain by the water.

Rain was sitting on the bank, looking at the stars reflected in the slow-moving creek. She didn't seem surprised when Sage sat down beside her.

"You're not going to stop them." Rain's voice was flat, certain.

“No.” Sage’s voice was tired. “They’ve made up their minds. Men are like that. Once the blood gets hot, there’s no cooling it.”

“Then why did you come to me?”

Sage was quiet for a moment. “Because you’re the only one who might talk sense to Crow. He listens to you.”

Rain smiled, very faintly. “Crow listens to Crow. He just lets me think otherwise.”

“Then make him hear you. Tell him this is madness. Tell him he’s too old for this, that the road will kill him before he ever reaches Washington. Tell him—” Sage’s voice broke. “Tell him I can’t bury another son.”

Rain looked at her. In the starlight, Sage’s face was lined and hollow, years older than it had been a week ago.

“I can’t tell him that,” Rain said gently. “Because I’m going with them.”

Sage stared at her. “What?”

“Someone has to keep them alive. Cook the food, tend the wounds, watch for fever.” Rain looked back at the stars. “I wasn’t going to let him go alone. I wasn’t going to sit here for two seasons wondering if he was dead in a ditch somewhere. If Crow dies, I want to be there when it happens. Not hearing about it from a trader three moons later.”

Sage’s mouth opened, then closed. She shook her head slowly.

“You’re all mad,” she said. “Every one of you.”

“Maybe.” Rain stood up and brushed the dirt from her dress. “But I’ve spent thirty years learning how he breathes when he sleeps. I’m not starting over now.”

She walked back toward the camp, leaving Sage alone by the water.

Stone didn’t sleep that night.

He sat by the cold remains of the fire, sharpening his knife with slow, deliberate strokes. The sound was soft in the darkness—steel against stone, steel against stone—a rhythm as old as hunting itself.

Across the camp, Crow was awake too. Stone could see him in the doorway of his lodge, a darker shape against the dark, watching. Neither of them spoke. There was nothing left to say.

Stone tested the edge of the knife against his thumb. A thin line of red welled up, black in the starlight. Sharp enough.

He moved to his bow. Checked the string. Checked the curve of the wood. Pulled it to half-draw, feeling the tension, listening for any creak or weakness. The bow was old but strong. It would hold.

The arrows next. Twenty of them, laid out on a piece of hide. He picked up each one, sighting down the shaft, feeling the weight, testing the fletching. Three were warped. He set them aside. The rest would fly true.

When he was done, he sat for a long time in the darkness, the weapons arranged around him like the pieces of a puzzle he had finally solved. The stars wheeled overhead. The donkey stood at the edge of camp, its ears pricked toward the east, listening to something only it could hear.

Stone didn't know what was coming. He didn't know if they would make it to Washington, or Tennessee, or anywhere at all. He didn't know if he would ever see this camp again, or his mother, or the slow green creek where he had learned to swim as a boy.

But he knew he was done waiting. Done hiding. Done sitting in the dark while the world closed in around them.

The knife was sharp. The bow was strong. The arrows would fly true.

In the east, the first pale light of dawn was beginning to show above the horizon.

Stone stood up, and the decision that had been forming for three days finally settled into his bones. Not as words—Stone had never trusted words—but as weight. As certainty. As the feeling of a thing that cannot be undone.

CHAPTER SIX

The camp woke slowly, the way it always did.

Crow lay still for a moment, listening to the sounds he had heard ten thousand times before: the soft crackle of someone stirring the fire, horses shifting near the creek, a child's voice calling out and being hushed. Ordinary sounds. The sounds of a world that did not know it was about to change.

He turned his head. Rain was already gone, her blankets folded neatly beside him. He could smell smoke and meat cooking. He lay there a moment longer, looking at the hide walls of the lodge, the familiar stains and patches, the place where the light came through near the top. Then he rose.

Outside, the sky was gray with early dawn. The fire was burning, and Rain was there, moving between the flames and a pile of supplies she had been gathering. She did not look up when Crow emerged, but he saw the corner of her mouth twitch. She had known he was watching.

He walked to the fire and sat down. She handed him a piece of meat without a word. He ate it, watching the camp come alive around them.

Stone was already at the horse line, checking hooves and teeth with the methodical patience of a man who had done this work since childhood. Fox was with him, moving faster, talking more, his hands busy with ropes and blankets. Stone answered him in single words, if at all.

Ridge stood at the edge of camp, looking east. He was stronger now—a week of food and rest had put some weight back on his frame—but there was still something hollow about him. He stood with his head tilted slightly east, as if listening to something far off.

Two-Kettles emerged from his lodge and stood blinking in the gray light. He was older than Stone, younger than Crow, with a scar along his jaw from a fight with Texans five summers back. He looked at the activity around the fire, at the supplies being gathered, at Ridge standing alone at the edge of things. Then he walked over to Crow.

“So it's today,” he said.

“It’s today.”

Two-Kettles nodded slowly. He squatted down beside the fire, his eyes on the flames.

“I should be going with you,” he said quietly. “I was there when Walks Far died. I watched it happen. I should be there when we answer for it.”

“Someone has to stay,” Crow said. “Someone has to keep the camp safe while we’re gone.”

“Sage can keep the camp safe. She doesn’t need me for that.”

“She needs someone who can fight. If a patrol comes—”

“If a patrol comes, I’ll die here instead of dying there.” Two-Kettles shook his head. “It’s not the same.”

Crow was quiet for a moment. Then he said, “When we come back, you can tell me I was wrong to leave you behind. I’ll listen.”

Two-Kettles looked at him. Two-Kettles held his gaze, and that was enough.

“Come back, then,” Two-Kettles said. “That’s all I ask.”

He stood and walked away toward the horse line, where Stone was still working. Crow watched him go.

By mid-morning, the work was nearly done.

The supplies were divided into bundles: dried meat and pemmican, blankets, water skins, ammunition for the rifles, tools for mending tack and sharpening blades. Rain had organized most of it, her hands quick and practiced. The others brought her what she asked for and stayed out of her way.

Stone led the mule out from the far end of the horse line. It was a tall animal, gray-brown, with long ears and intelligent eyes. It walked with the steady patience of a creature that knew its own worth and saw no need to prove it.

The donkey saw the mule coming and went stiff.

It had been standing near the woodpile, half-asleep, its head drooping in the morning sun. Now its ears came forward, its nostrils flared, and it let out a sound that was somewhere between a snort and a warning.

The mule ignored it. Stone led it toward the pile of supplies, and the donkey moved to intercept—not quickly, but with a stiff-legged deliberation that made its intentions clear.

“Ho,” Stone said, putting out a hand. “Enough.”

The donkey stopped, but its ears stayed flat. The mule turned its head and regarded the donkey with the calm disdain of an elder watching a child throw a tantrum.

Fox laughed. “They don’t like each other.”

“They’ll learn,” Stone said. He tied the mule to a post and began loading the first bundle onto its back. The donkey watched every movement, its eyes narrow with suspicion.

“Or they won’t,” Crow said. “Either way, they’re both coming.”

He walked to the horse line, where Ridge was standing with his hand on the neck of a bay mare. She was a good horse—young, strong, with clean lines and a calm eye. One of the better animals in the camp’s small herd.

“She’s yours,” Crow said.

Ridge looked at him. “I can’t—”

“You can. You need a horse. She needs a rider.” Crow shrugged. “It’s simple.”

Ridge was quiet for a moment. His hand moved slowly along the mare’s neck, feeling the warmth of her, the life in her.

“Thank you,” he said finally.

“Don’t thank me. Just keep up.”

Crow walked away before Ridge could say anything else. There was nothing more to discuss. The man needed a horse; they had given him one. That was the end of it.

Rain appeared with her pack as the sun reached its height.

She walked out of the lodge carrying a bundle on her back and a rolled blanket under her arm. Her medicine bag hung at her hip, and her knife was at her belt.

Fox saw her first. He stopped in the middle of tying a rope and stared.

“You’re—”

“I’m coming.” Rain set her pack down near the other supplies. “Someone has to keep you all alive long enough to do what you’re going to do.”

Fox looked at Crow. “Did you know?”

“She’s my wife. We talked.”

“But the road is dangerous. You said so yourself.”

“The road is dangerous for all of us.” Rain picked up a water skin and tested its weight. “I’ve been on dangerous roads before.”

Stone grunted. Ridge, watching from near the horses, nodded slightly.

Fox opened his mouth to argue, then closed it. He looked at Rain, at her pack, at the knife on her belt.

“We should have more water skins,” he said. “I’ll get more.”

He walked away quickly, the flush visible on his neck. Good. He would learn.

The sun was sliding toward the west when Sage finally came.

She had been absent all morning, staying in her lodge while the others worked. Crow had seen her watching through the gap in the hide, but she had not come out. Now, as the shadows lengthened and the horses stood ready, she emerged.

She walked slowly across the camp, her back straight and her face set. She stopped in front of Stone.

They looked at each other for a long moment. Mother and son. The last of her blood, now that Walks Far was gone.

“You’re determined,” she said.

“Yes.”

“You won’t listen to reason.”

“There’s no reason that changes anything.”

Sage nodded slowly. She reached up and touched his face—a quick gesture, almost rough, as if she were checking for fever.

“Then go,” she said. “Do what you have to do. But come back.” Her voice cracked, just slightly. “You’re what I have left.”

Stone took her hand and held it for a moment. His face showed nothing, but he held her hand a moment longer than he needed to.

“I’ll come back,” he said. “Or I won’t. Either way, you’ll know.”

“That’s not comfort.”

“It’s all I have.”

She pulled her hand away. For a moment she looked like she might say more. Then she turned to Fox.

“You,” she said. “Come here.”

Fox stepped forward, uncertain. Sage looked at him hard.

“Your father was brave,” she said. “He was also careful. He didn’t take risks he didn’t have to take. You understand?”

“Yes, grandmother.”

“No. You don’t. But maybe you will.” She put her hand on his shoulder and squeezed once, hard. “Don’t be the first one through the door. Don’t be the one who has to prove something. Let the others go ahead. Watch. Learn. Then act.”

Fox nodded. His jaw was tight.

Sage released him and turned to Ridge. Her eyes were cold.

“You,” she said. “Cherokee.”

Ridge met her gaze. “Yes.”

“You brought this to us. This mission, this death-walk, whatever you want to call it. You’re the reason they’re leaving.”

“I know.”

“Then know this too.” Sage stepped closer, her voice dropping to something low and hard. “If my son dies because of you—if my grandson dies because of you—I will find a way to make you suffer for it. Even if I have to follow you into the spirit world to do it.”

Ridge didn’t flinch. “If they die because of me, I’ll deserve whatever you give me.”

Sage stared at him for a long moment. Then, slowly, she nodded.

“Maybe you’re not as stupid as you look.”

She turned away without another word and walked toward Rain. The two women stood apart from the others, speaking quietly. Crow couldn’t hear what they said, but he saw Rain nod, saw Sage’s hand rest briefly on Rain’s arm. Then Sage walked back toward her lodge and did not look back.

They left at dawn.

The sky was pale gray shading to pink in the east, and the grass was wet with dew. The horses stamped and blew, eager to move after a night of waiting. The mule stood patient and ready. The donkey had to be dragged the first fifty yards before it finally accepted the inevitable and began walking on its own.

Crow rode at the front with Ridge. Stone came behind them, then Fox, then Rain leading the pack animals. They moved in single file, following the faint trail that led east out of the draw and onto the open plain.

The camp fell away behind them. Crow could hear the sounds fading—the dogs, the children, the crackle of the morning fire. He did not look back. Not yet.

They rode for an hour, maybe more. The sun came up and burned the dew off the grass, and the plain stretched out ahead of them, endless and gold and empty. The wind was gentle and smelled of sage.

Ridge pointed ahead. "There. The rise."

Crow saw it—a low swell in the land, just high enough to see back the way they had come. He nodded.

They rode to the top of the rise and stopped.

Below them, small in the distance, the camp was still visible. The lodges were tiny brown shapes against the green of the creek bottom. A thread of smoke rose from the morning fire. Crow could see a pair of figures standing at the edge of the camp, watching them. Sage and Two-Kettles? It was too far to tell.

"We should go," Fox said. His voice was tight.

"Not yet." Stone turned his horse so he was facing the camp. "One more thing."

He raised his hand. Not a wave—more like a salute. A gesture of farewell.

Crow did the same. Then Ridge, then Fox, then Rain. Five riders on a low rise, their hands raised against the morning sky, saying goodbye to everything they knew.

The figures below each raised a hand in return. Held it there. Then lowered it and turned away.

"Against the sun," Rain said quietly.

Crow looked east, into the light. He didn't reply.

"Now we go," he said.

They turned their horses east and rode down off the rise, and the camp disappeared behind them, and the long road opened up ahead.

The donkey brayed once, loud and complaining, as if to register its formal objection to the entire enterprise.

Nobody answered it. There was nothing to say. They rode on.

Part II: Chapters 7-11 (The Journey)

CHAPTER SEVEN

They rode east for three days before they saw another living soul.

The plains stretched out around them like a sea of grass, endless and gold, broken only by the occasional draw or creek bed where cottonwoods clustered against the sky. They moved in single file most of the time—Crow at the front, then Ridge, then Fox and Stone, with Rain bringing up the rear leading the pack animals. The donkey had stopped braying after the first morning, settling into a sullen silence that Crow found almost worse. A complaining donkey was predictable. A quiet one was planning something.

The mule, for its part, maintained the steady patience of a creature that had made its peace with existence. It walked when the others walked, stopped when they stopped, and regarded the donkey with the tolerant disdain of an elder forced to share quarters with a difficult child. Twice on that first day the donkey tried to bite the mule's flank. Twice the mule shifted just enough to avoid the teeth and kept walking. By the second day, the donkey had given up on biting and settled for glaring.

"They'll sort it out," Stone said on the third morning, watching the animals drink from a shallow creek. "Or they won't."

"The mule doesn't care," Fox said. "Look at him. He doesn't even notice."

"He notices." Stone spat into the dust. "He just doesn't think it's worth the trouble."

They made camp that night in a shallow draw, sheltered from the wind by a low ridge of sandstone. Rain built a fire while the others tended the horses. The routine was already forming—each person finding their place in the work, moving around each other without needing to speak.

Fox took the first watch, as he had the night before. He was eager for it, Crow knew. Eager to prove he could be trusted with the dark hours. Crow let him have it. The boy would learn soon enough that watching was mostly waiting, and waiting was its own kind of work.

On the fourth day they crossed the first river.

It wasn't much—a muddy ribbon cutting through the plain, maybe thirty feet wide and waist-deep at the center. The water was brown and sluggish, moving slowly toward the south. Crow had crossed rivers like this a hundred times. They all had, except perhaps Ridge.

"The Red is bigger," Ridge said, studying the far bank. "Two days east, maybe three. This is just the first."

"Can you swim?" Crow asked.

Ridge's mouth twitched. "I learned on rivers bigger than this. Before."

Before. The word hung in the air, heavy with everything it didn't say.

They crossed in pairs, the horses picking their way through the current while the riders held the reins high. Stone went first with Fox, testing the footing, finding the path where the bottom was firmest. Crow followed with Ridge. Rain came last, leading the pack animals.

The mule entered the water without hesitation, its long legs carrying it steadily toward the far bank. The donkey stopped at the water's edge.

Rain tugged at the lead rope. "Come on."

The donkey didn't move. It stood with its front hooves at the very edge of the river, staring at the water as if it were poison.

"It's just water," Rain said. "You've seen water before."

The donkey flicked an ear but didn't move.

From the far bank, Stone called out: "Pull harder!"

"I'm pulling." Rain wrapped the rope around her hand and leaned back. The donkey leaned the other way. For a long moment they were frozen there—woman and animal, locked in a battle of wills.

Fox started to laugh. He stopped when Stone looked at him.

"He doesn't want to go," Rain said.

“He doesn’t get a choice.” Stone waded back into the river, water swirling around his thighs. He grabbed the donkey’s halter and pulled while Rain pushed from behind.

The donkey sat down.

It was so unexpected that Stone lost his grip and stumbled backward into the water. He went down to one knee, soaking himself to the chest, and came up with murder in his eyes. The donkey watched him with an expression of profound satisfaction.

“I’m going to eat that animal,” Stone said.

“No you’re not.” Rain was trying not to smile. “Get up. Let me try something.”

She waded to the donkey’s side and stood there for a moment, not pulling, not pushing. Just standing. She put her hand on the animal’s neck and leaned close, and Crow couldn’t hear what she said—if she said anything at all.

The donkey’s ears came forward. It looked at her, then at the river, then at her again.

Then it stood up and walked into the water.

It crossed without stopping, without complaint, and climbed the far bank where it stood dripping and unrepentant, as if the whole performance had been someone else’s idea.

“What did you say to him?” Fox asked.

Rain shrugged. “I told him the mule was already across.”

Stone wrung water from his shirt and said nothing. But Crow saw his mouth twitch, just once, before he turned away.

The land changed as they moved east.

The open plains gave way to rolling hills, and the hills grew trees—first scattered oaks and pecans, then thicker stands of timber that closed in

around the trail. The grass was still there, but it shared the ground now with underbrush and shadow.

They saw deer every morning, and rabbits in the evenings. Fox brought down a buck on the sixth day, a clean shot through the heart that dropped the animal where it stood. Stone nodded when he saw it—a small gesture, barely visible, but Fox straightened like he'd been given a medal.

“Good shot,” Ridge said.

“I know.” Fox was already moving toward the carcass, knife in hand. Then he caught himself and added, quieter: “Thank you.”

They made camp early that night to butcher the deer and smoke what they couldn't eat. Rain worked the meat while the others gathered wood, and by nightfall they had enough dried venison to last a week.

“We should push faster,” Ridge said, staring into the fire. “Every day we delay—”

“Every day we delay, the horses rest,” Crow said. “And we rest. And we arrive able to do what we came to do.”

Ridge looked at him. The firelight carved deep shadows into his face, making him look older than he was. Older than any of them.

“You're right,” he said finally. “I know you're right. It's just—” He shook his head. “Every morning I wake up and they're still alive. Van Buren. Poinsett. Jackson. Every morning they eat breakfast and walk in the sun and breathe the same air my daughter breathed. And I think: not yet. Not yet. Not yet.”

No one spoke. The fire crackled and popped.

“It will come,” Stone said. His voice was low, rough-edged. “The day will come. And when it does, you'll be ready. We'll be ready.”

Ridge looked at him for a long moment. Then he nodded and looked away.

On the eighth day, they saw the farm.

It appeared without warning—a cleared field at the edge of the timber, a cabin of rough-hewn logs, a barn with a sagging roof. Smoke rose from the chimney. A dog barked somewhere behind the house.

They had come too close before they saw it. The trees had hidden it until they were almost in the open, and now they sat on their horses at the edge of the clearing, exposed.

“Back,” Crow said quietly. “Slowly.”

They turned the horses, moving into the shadows of the trees. But they had been seen.

The cabin door opened and a man stepped out, carrying a rifle. He was tall and thin, with a beard that grew wild down his chest and eyes that squinted against the morning light. He saw them in the trees and raised the rifle to his shoulder.

“Hold it right there!”

They stopped. Crow’s hand moved toward his own rifle, but Stone caught his eye and shook his head slightly.

“We’re just passing through,” Ridge called out. His voice was calm, reasonable. “We don’t want any trouble.”

“What kind of passing through puts five Indians on my land?” The man’s voice was sharp with fear, and fear made men dangerous. “I know what you are. I know what you’re doing out here.”

“We’re hunting,” Ridge said. “That’s all. Hunting, and traveling east.”

“East.” The man spat. “East to where? To bring more of you back? To scout my farm so you can come back with a war party?”

“We have no interest in your farm.” Ridge kept his voice steady. “We have no interest in you. We want only to pass.”

The man’s eyes moved across them—counting, calculating. Five riders. Two pack animals. One woman. He didn’t lower the rifle.

“I ought to shoot you where you stand,” he said. “I’d be doing the territory a favor.”

Fox's hand moved toward his bow. Crow saw it and said, quietly: "No."

Fox's hand stopped. His jaw was tight, his eyes fixed on the man with the rifle.

"You could try," Stone said. His voice was flat, almost bored. "You might get one of us. Maybe two if you're lucky. Then the rest of us would kill you, and your dog, and anyone else in that cabin. Is that what you want?"

The man's face went pale. His rifle wavered.

"We don't want that," Crow said. "You don't want that. We're going to turn around now and go back the way we came. We'll circle around your land. You'll never see us again."

He nudged his horse backward. The others followed. The man watched them go, rifle still raised, hands trembling.

They rode into the trees, following a wide arc around the farm. No one spoke until they were a mile away and the smoke from the chimney had disappeared behind the hills.

"He would have killed us," Fox said. His voice was tight with anger. "He would have shot us and left us for the wolves."

"Yes," Crow said.

"And we just—left. We ran away."

"We went around." Crow looked at him. "That's not the same thing."

"It felt the same."

"It wasn't." Stone brought his horse alongside Fox's. "That man was scared. Scared men shoot first and think later. If we had pushed, someone would have died—maybe him, maybe one of us. Either way, we lose time, we lose surprise, and the mission gets harder."

"But—"

"But nothing." Stone's voice was hard now. "We're not here to fight farmers. We're not here to prove anything. We're here to kill three men in the east. Everything else is a distraction."

Fox looked away. His hands were clenched on the reins.

"He'll tell people," Ridge said quietly. "Five Indians traveling east. Two pack animals. The word will spread."

"Maybe," Crow said. "Maybe not. Men like that don't trust strangers. He might not talk to anyone for weeks."

"And if he does?"

"Then we move faster. Stay off the main trails. Do what we came to do before the word catches up with us."

They rode on. The sun climbed higher, burning off the morning mist. Behind them, somewhere in the trees, a man with a rifle was probably still standing in his doorway, watching the shadows, waiting for the attack that wasn't coming.

Crow wondered what he would tell his wife. What he would tell his children, if he had any.

He wondered if any of them would ever know how close they had come to dying on an ordinary morning, for no reason at all.

That night they camped without a fire.

The cold crept in after sunset, and they huddled in their blankets, eating dried venison and drinking water from skins that tasted of leather. The stars came out, thick and bright, and the wind whispered through the trees above them.

Rain sat beside Crow, close enough that their shoulders touched. She hadn't spoken much since the farm. None of them had.

"That will happen again," she said quietly. "Won't it."

"Probably."

"And each time, we'll go around. Until we can't."

Crow didn't answer. He looked at the sky, at the stars his father had taught him to read, the patterns that meant home and direction and time. They

looked the same here as they did on the Llano. The same as they would look in Washington, or Tennessee, or anywhere.

“The world is getting smaller,” he said finally. “There are farms where there weren’t farms. Fences where there weren’t fences. Every year, less room to go around.”

“I know.” Rain took his hand. “That’s why we’re doing it.”

Crow looked at her. In the starlight, her face was calm and certain. She had always been the steady one, the one who saw things clearly when he could only feel them.

“Are you sorry?” he asked. “That you came?”

“No.” She squeezed his hand. “I would have been sorry if I’d stayed.”

They sat together in the darkness, watching the stars wheel slowly overhead. Somewhere in the trees, the donkey stamped and snorted, settling in for the night.

Tomorrow they would ride on.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The rain began on the tenth day.

It came without warning—a gray wall sweeping across the hills from the north, swallowing the trees and the trail and everything else. One moment they were riding through pale morning light; the next they were drenched, the horses stamping and tossing their heads as the cold water ran down their necks.

They pushed on for an hour, maybe two. The trail turned to mud, then to a sucking clay that grabbed at the horses' hooves and made every step a labor. The donkey complained loudly. Even the mule, patient as stone, began to slow.

"We need shelter," Ridge shouted over the rain. He was riding beside Crow now, his face streaming water. "This won't stop soon."

Crow looked at Rain. She was hunched in her saddle, blanket pulled tight, shivering. She met his eyes and nodded slightly. She could go on, the nod said. But she shouldn't have to.

"Find us something," Crow said.

Ridge pointed east, toward a smudge of darker gray against the horizon. "Smoke. Someone's chimney."

They rode toward it.

The farm appeared slowly through the rain—a small cabin of weathered wood, a barn that leaned slightly to one side, a garden patch gone to mud. Smoke rose from the chimney and was beaten down by the rain before it could climb.

They stopped at the edge of the tree line, watching.

"One building," Stone said quietly. "No horses in the yard. No dogs."

"Could be a trap," Fox said.

"Could be a widow," Rain said. "Could be someone who just wants to be left alone."

Crow studied the cabin. A face appeared briefly at the window—pale, indistinct—then vanished.

“I’ll go,” Ridge said.

“We’ll all go,” Crow said. “But slowly. And keep your hands where they can be seen.”

They rode out of the trees and across the muddy yard. The cabin door opened before they reached it.

A woman stood in the doorway. She was perhaps fifty, perhaps older—it was hard to tell. Her hair was gray and pulled back tight, her face weathered from a lifetime outdoors. She wore a man’s shirt and a long skirt, and she held no weapon.

She looked at them for a long moment. Five riders. Four men, one woman. Indians, clearly. Armed.

“You’re wet,” she said.

“Yes,” Ridge said. “We’re looking for shelter. Just until the rain stops. We can pay.”

The woman’s eyes moved across them again. They stopped on Rain, and something in her face softened slightly.

“Barn’s dry,” she said. “More or less. There’s hay for your animals.” She paused. “I’ve got soup on the fire. It’s not much, but it’s hot.”

Crow felt something loosen in his chest. He had been ready for a rifle, for shouting, for another farmer who saw only the color of their skin and the weapons at their sides.

“Thank you,” he said.

The woman shrugged. “World’s hard enough without making it harder.” She stepped back into the cabin. “Put your horses up. I’ll bring the soup out.”

The barn was old but solid, the roof patched in places but holding against the rain. They unsaddled the horses and rubbed them down with handfuls

of straw. The donkey found a corner and stood there, dripping and miserable, while the mule investigated the hay with professional interest.

Fox was restless, pacing near the door. "She could be getting a gun. She could be sending for help."

"She's alone," Stone said. He was sitting on a bale, wringing water from his shirt. "No horse, no dog. Who would she send?"

"She could—"

"She's making us soup." Stone looked at Fox with something like patience. "Sit down."

Fox sat. But his hand stayed near his knife.

The barn door creaked open and the woman came in, carrying a pot wrapped in cloth. Behind her, Rain appeared, carrying bowls and spoons.

Crow looked at Rain in surprise. She had gone to help without being asked.

"Your wife's got sense," the woman said, setting the pot down on an upturned crate. "Came to the door, asked if she could help carry things. Didn't wait for permission."

"She does that," Crow said.

The woman ladled soup into bowls—thick and brown, with chunks of potato and what looked like rabbit. She handed them out without ceremony, then stood back and watched them eat.

"You're going east," she said, as if she'd read it off their faces.

Ridge looked up. "How do you know?"

"Everyone goes now. No one stays." She crossed her arms. "My husband went west three years ago. Said he'd send for me when he found land. Never did."

"I'm sorry," Rain said.

"Don't be. He was a hard man. I'm better alone." The woman's eyes moved to the window, to the gray curtain of rain beyond. "The Chickasaw used

to camp near here, before. Down by the creek. They'd come through every spring, trade for corn. My mother taught me some of their words."

She looked at Ridge. "You're not Chickasaw. Cherokee, maybe?"

Ridge nodded slowly. "Yes."

"Thought so. You've got the look." She was quiet for a moment. "They're gone now. The Chickasaw. Moved west, like all the others. Government made them go."

No one spoke. The rain drummed on the roof.

"I used to think it was wrong," the woman said. "What they did. Moving people off land they'd lived on forever. Seemed wrong to me." She shrugged. "Still does, I suppose. But no one asked my opinion."

Rain set down her bowl and stood. She walked to the woman and took her hand.

"Thank you," Rain said. "For the food. For not asking questions."

The woman looked at her for a long moment. Crow couldn't read what passed between them, but he felt it. Two women, both far from where they'd started, both carrying things they didn't speak of.

"You're welcome," the woman said. She squeezed Rain's hand once, then let go. "Stay as long as you need. I'll be in the cabin if you want more soup."

She left. The rain kept falling.

They stayed until mid-afternoon, when the rain finally began to thin. The woman—she never gave her name, and they never asked—came out once more to check on them, bringing a sack of dried apples and refusing payment.

"I've got more than I need," she said. "Take them."

As they saddled the horses, Rain hung back. Crow saw her press something into the woman's hand—a small bundle of herbs from her medicine bag.

"For the cough," Rain said quietly. "Brew it in hot water. It helps."

The woman looked at the herbs, then at Rain. Her eyes were wet, though it might have been the rain.

“You be careful out there,” she said. “East is harder than it looks.”

They rode out of the yard and into the dripping woods. Crow looked back once. The woman was standing in her doorway, watching them go.

She raised her hand. Rain raised hers.

Then the trees closed in, and she was gone.

On the twelfth day they found the way station.

It sat at a crossroads, a sprawling building of chinked logs with a stable attached to one side. Smoke rose from the chimney, and the smell of cooking meat drifted on the wind. They needed supplies—salt, ammunition, information—and Ridge said he knew how to get them without drawing too much attention.

“I’ll go in alone,” he said. “Buy what we need. Listen to the talk.”

“And if someone recognizes you?” Stone asked.

“No one here knows my face. And Cherokee pass through these crossroads all the time, heading west.” Ridge smoothed his wet hair back. “I’m just another Indian. They won’t look twice.”

They didn’t like it, but they let him go. The others made camp in a thicket half a mile from the crossroads, hidden from the road, and waited.

Ridge was gone for three hours.

When he came back, he was carrying a sack of supplies and a jug of whiskey. His face was strange—closed off, distant, like a man who had seen something he wasn’t ready to talk about.

“What happened?” Crow asked.

Ridge sat down by the cold fire they hadn’t lit. He uncorked the jug and took a long drink.

“I met a soldier,” he said. “A former soldier. From the removal.”

The camp went still. Fox stopped cleaning his knife. Stone straightened. Rain moved closer.

“He was drunk,” Ridge continued. “Sitting by the fire, drinking himself to death. He saw me come in and he knew. He knew what I was. He called me over.”

“And you went?” Fox asked.

“I went.” Ridge took another drink. “He wanted to talk. He wanted to confess.”

He told them what the soldier had said. The house-to-house searches. The bayonets. The woman near New Echota with the baby, how the sergeant had hit her with a rifle butt to stop her screaming. How she had died on the trail.

“He said he sees her at night,” Ridge said. “The woman. He said the ghosts don’t talk back. They just look at him.”

Fox’s face was hard. “Did you kill him?”

“No.”

“Why not? He was there. He did it. He—”

“He was a tool.” Ridge’s voice was flat, cold. “A broken hammer. You don’t punish the hammer for hitting the nail. You punish the hand that swings it.”

He looked at Fox, and Ridge’s eyes were steady, flat. The rage had been burned away long ago, leaving only purpose.

“That man is already in hell,” Ridge said. “I left him there. He’ll die in a ditch somewhere, choking on his own vomit, and no one will remember his name. That’s enough for him. It’s not enough for Jackson.”

Fox opened his mouth to argue, then closed it. He looked at Stone.

Stone nodded slowly. “We save the bullets for the men who matter.”

Ridge drank again, then corked the jug and set it aside. He leaned back against his saddle and closed his eyes.

“I could have killed him,” he said quietly. “Six months ago, I would have.” He was quiet for a moment. “Something changed on the walk. The heat burned off. What’s left is clear.”

No one spoke. The wind moved through the trees, carrying the smell of rain and woodsmoke and something else—the road ahead, maybe. The cities. The men who were waiting without knowing they were waiting.

“Get some sleep,” Crow said. “We ride at dawn.”

Crow woke in the dead of night to the sound of the donkey braying.

It was a harsh, urgent sound—not the usual complaint, but something sharper. An alarm.

He was on his feet instantly, knife in hand. Stone was already moving, silent as smoke, toward the edge of the thicket. Fox scrambled up behind him, fumbling for his bow.

“Quiet,” Stone breathed.

They crouched in the darkness, listening. The donkey brayed again, then went silent, its ears pricked toward the road.

Stone crept forward to a gap in the brush. He stayed there for a long moment, motionless, watching.

“Riders,” he whispered. “Three of them. Coming from the crossroads.”

Crow’s heart hammered. Had they been seen? Had someone at the way station talked?

The hoofbeats grew louder, then louder still. Crow could hear voices now—rough, slurred. Drunk.

“Check the stable,” one voice said. “That trader had good horses.”

“He’ll hear us.”

“He’s asleep. And drunk. Come on.”

The hoofbeats slowed. Stopped. They were at the way station now, not here. Not looking for them.

Horse thieves. Just horse thieves.

Stone eased back from the brush. "They're hitting the way station," he said quietly. "Trying to steal from the stable."

"Not our problem," Ridge murmured. He was awake now, watching from his blankets.

"It is if they raise an alarm," Crow said. "If the keeper thinks Indians stole his horses—"

"He'd bring every man in ten miles down on us," Stone finished.

They looked at each other in the darkness. Fox's hand was tight on his bow.

"We don't kill them," Crow said. "We scare them off."

Stone nodded. He found a thick branch on the ground and hefted it. Then he crept toward the road, moving from shadow to shadow, until he was close enough to see the way station's stable.

Crow watched him go. The donkey stood rigid, ears forward, watching too.

A moment passed. Two.

Then the branch hit the stable wall with a crack like a gunshot.

"Hey!" Stone bellowed, roughening his voice to a growl. "Who's out there? I've got a gun!"

Chaos at the stable. Shouting, cursing, the scramble of boots in mud. Then hoofbeats, fast and receding, as the thieves fled into the night.

A light appeared in the way station window. The keeper's voice, distant and angry, shouting questions into the dark. But there was no one there to answer him. Just shadows and rain.

Stone came back through the brush, silent and satisfied.

"Gone," he said.

He walked to the donkey, who was still standing at attention, ears pricked, looking enormously pleased with itself. Stone reached out and scratched the animal behind the ears.

“Good donkey,” he said softly. “You earned your keep tonight.”

The donkey snorted and shook its head, as if to say it had never been in doubt.

Fox laughed quietly in the darkness. “Maybe we won’t eat him after all.”

“Not yet,” Stone said. “Maybe not ever.” He looked at the animal with something approaching respect. “He knew. Before any of us did. He knew.”

The donkey went back to nosing at the grass, indifferent to the praise.

Crow settled back onto his blankets. His heart was still beating fast, but the danger had passed. They were safe. They were hidden. And the donkey—the stubborn, complaining, impossible donkey—had saved them.

He closed his eyes.

Tomorrow they would ride on. The Mississippi was ahead, and beyond it, the cities of the east. The men who had to die.

But tonight, they were alive. All of them. Even the donkey.

CHAPTER NINE

They smelled the river before they saw it.

It came on the wind from the east—a heavy, wet smell, thick with mud and rotting vegetation and something else underneath, something ancient and slow. Crow had never been this far east, but he knew that smell. It was the smell of water that had been traveling for a thousand miles, picking up the secrets of the land as it went.

“Close now,” Ridge said. He was riding beside Crow, his eyes fixed on the horizon. “Maybe half a day.”

They had been traveling for three days since the way station, moving through country that grew greener and more crowded with each passing mile. The open plains had given way to rolling hills, and the hills had grown trees—first scattered oaks, then thick stands of hickory and sweet gum that closed in around the trail like walls. There were farms everywhere now, carved out of the forest in rough squares, and roads that crossed and recrossed the land like scars.

They had learned to move carefully. Ridge went ahead when they approached settlements, scouting the safest routes. The others stayed back, hidden in the trees, waiting for his signal. It was slow work, but it kept them safe.

The donkey had stopped complaining somewhere along the way. It walked now with a kind of grim determination, as if it had finally accepted that this journey was happening whether it approved or not. The mule, as always, simply walked—patient, steady, unbothered by anything.

Stone had taken to watching the donkey with something that might have been respect. He never said anything about it, but Crow noticed. They all noticed.

The river appeared in the late afternoon.

They came out of a stand of cypress trees, and there it was—a vast brown snake of water, wider than anything Crow had ever seen. It stretched from

horizon to horizon, slow and heavy and impossibly huge. The far bank was a smudge of green in the distance, barely visible through the haze.

Fox pulled up his horse and stared. His mouth was slightly open.

“That’s the Mississippi?” he asked.

“That’s the Mississippi,” Ridge said.

“How do we cross it?”

“We don’t. Not by ourselves.” Ridge pointed downstream, toward a cluster of buildings on the near bank. “There’s a ferry landing. I can see the cables.”

Crow studied the landing. It was a rough collection of structures—a large barn, a smaller house, a dock that jutted out into the brown water. A flat-bottomed boat was tied to the dock, big enough to carry horses and cargo. A few figures moved around the buildings, too far away to see clearly.

“They’ll see us,” Stone said.

“They’ll see Ridge,” Crow said. “The rest of us stay back until he gives the word.”

Ridge nodded. He dismounted and handed his reins to Rain. “Wait here. If I’m not back in an hour, go around. Find another crossing.”

“There isn’t another crossing for fifty miles,” Rain said quietly.

Ridge straightened his shirt and ran his fingers through his hair, trying to make himself look less like a man who had been sleeping in the woods for three weeks. “I’ll be back.”

He walked toward the landing, his stride easy and unhurried. Crow watched him go. The Cherokee moved differently when he was approaching white men—his shoulders relaxed, his face went neutral. He became a man who was no threat to anyone.

It was a skill Crow didn’t have. None of them had it. They would always look like what they were.

Ridge was gone for nearly an hour.

They waited in the trees, the horses growing restless, the donkey standing with its ears pricked toward the landing. Twice Fox started to say something, and twice Stone silenced him with a look.

When Ridge finally appeared, he was walking with a man—a thick-bodied figure in a stained shirt, carrying a long pole over his shoulder. They stopped at the edge of the trees, and the man peered into the shadows.

“These your people?” the man asked. His voice was rough, wary.

“My companions,” Ridge said. “As I told you.”

The man spat into the dirt. He was maybe fifty, with a face that had been weathered by sun and wind until it looked like old leather. His eyes were small and sharp, and they moved constantly, counting horses, counting people, calculating.

“Five riders,” he said. “Seven horses counting the pack animals. That’s forty dollars.”

“You said thirty.”

“That was before I knew there was five of you. And before I knew some of you was—” He paused, choosing his words carefully. “—of the Indian persuasion.”

“The money spends the same,” Ridge said.

“Maybe. But the trouble don’t.” The man shifted his weight. “I run a clean operation here. I don’t need problems with the law, and I don’t need problems with the other passengers.”

“Other passengers?”

“Family heading east. Settlers. They been waiting since yesterday.” The man’s eyes moved to the trees again. “They see a bunch of Indians getting on the ferry, they might get nervous. Nervous people do stupid things.”

Ridge reached into his shirt and pulled out a small leather pouch. He counted out coins, slowly, letting the man see each one.

“Forty dollars,” Ridge said. “And another five if you put us on first, before the family. We’ll be on the other side before they wake up.”

The man looked at the coins. He looked at the trees. He looked at the river. "Dawn," he said finally. "Be at the dock before first light. Any trouble, you swim."

He took the coins and walked back toward the landing without another word.

They made camp in the trees, far enough from the river that their fire wouldn't be seen. Rain cooked the last of the deer meat they had been carrying, and they ate in silence, watching the stars come out through the gaps in the canopy.

Crow found himself looking at the river. He could see it through the trees—a dark ribbon in the darkness, wider than the night sky seemed to allow. Somewhere out there, the current was carrying everything it touched toward the sea. Leaves, branches, the bodies of animals that had drowned. All of it moving, slowly, toward some end that none of them would ever see.

"You're quiet," Rain said. She had come to sit beside him, her shoulder touching his.

"I'm thinking about the other side."

"The other side of the river?"

"The other side of everything." Crow picked up a stick and drew a line in the dirt. "Once we cross, we can't come back. Not the same way. The crossing changes things."

Rain was quiet for a moment. "We knew that when we left."

"Knowing it and feeling it are different things." He looked at her. "Are you sorry? That you came?"

"I was sorry the moment I packed my bag. I've been sorry every mile since." She leaned against him, her weight warm and familiar. "But I would be sorrier if I had stayed."

They sat together, watching the river. Somewhere in the camp, Fox was arguing with Stone about something—the proper way to stake a horse,

probably, or the best route for tomorrow. Their voices rose and fell, sharp and then quiet, the old rhythm of men who had been traveling together too long.

Ridge was sitting apart from the others, near the edge of the firelight. He had his back against a tree, his eyes fixed on something in his hands. Crow watched him for a moment, trying to see what it was.

A ribbon. Small and faded, the color of old roses.

Ridge held it between his fingers, turning it slowly, as if reading something written in the fabric. His face was still.

He sat like that for a long time. Then he pressed the ribbon to his lips, briefly, and tucked it back inside his shirt. He didn't look at anyone. He didn't need to.

Crow turned away. Some things were not meant to be watched.

They woke before dawn.

The air was cold and damp, heavy with river fog. The horses stamped and blew, their breath making clouds in the grey light. The donkey stood near the mule, for once not complaining, its ears swiveling toward the sound of the water.

They saddled in silence and rode toward the landing.

The ferryman was waiting for them at the dock. He had a lantern in one hand and a long pole in the other, and he watched them approach with the same calculating look he had worn the day before.

"On the boat," he said. "Horses in the middle. People on the sides. Don't move around once we're moving, and don't spook the animals. Current's strong this time of year."

The ferry was a flat wooden platform, maybe thirty feet long and half as wide. Thick cables ran from the dock to somewhere on the far shore, hidden in the fog. The ferryman would pull them across on those cables, hand-cranked, fighting the current the whole way.

Stone led his horse onto the boat first. The animal balked at the edge, its hooves ringing on the wet wood, but Stone spoke to it quietly and it stepped aboard. Fox followed, then Crow, then Rain with the pack animals.

The mule walked onto the ferry as if it had been doing this its whole life. It found a spot near the center and stood there, solid as a rock, waiting.

The donkey stopped at the edge of the dock.

“Come on,” Rain said, tugging at the lead rope. “We don’t have time for this.”

The donkey looked at the boat. It looked at the water. It looked at the mule, already standing calmly in the center of the ferry.

Then it stepped onto the boat, delicately, one hoof at a time, as if it were walking on glass.

“Miracles do happen,” Stone muttered.

Ridge was the last one aboard. He untied the mooring line and tossed it to the ferryman, who caught it without looking.

“Hold on,” the ferryman said. “It’s rough in the middle.”

He pushed off from the dock with his pole, and the ferry began to move.

The crossing took most of an hour.

At first it was easy—the ferry slid across the water, the cables creaking overhead, the current pushing against the side of the boat but not hard enough to matter. The horses stood quietly, their heads down, trusting the humans to know what they were doing.

Then they reached the middle of the river, and everything changed.

The current here was different. It was alive—a muscular, rolling force that grabbed the ferry and tried to twist it sideways. The cables groaned. The boat tilted, just slightly, and the horses began to shift their weight.

“Easy,” Stone said. He was standing near his roan, one hand on its neck. “Easy.”

Fox's paint gelding was not easy. It was dancing now, its eyes rolling white, its hooves clattering on the wet wood. Fox held the reins tight, trying to keep the animal still, but the horse was past listening.

"Get him under control," the ferryman shouted. He was working the crank with both hands, muscles standing out on his forearms. "If he goes over, you all go over!"

"I'm trying!" Fox hauled on the reins. The paint reared, just a little, its front hooves lifting off the deck.

The mule didn't move. It stood exactly where it had been standing since they boarded, its weight settled, its eyes calm. When the paint bumped against it, the mule shifted slightly to absorb the impact and then stood still again.

It was like watching a mountain ignore a landslide.

"Hold onto the mule!" Crow shouted to Fox. "Tie him to the mule!"

Fox looked at him like he was insane. But he grabbed the paint's lead rope and looped it around the mule's pack saddle, pulling the two animals together. The paint fought for a moment, then seemed to feel the mule's steadiness, and went still.

The ferry lurched again. A wave of brown water sloshed over the side, soaking everyone's boots. The ferryman cursed and pulled harder on the crank.

They were past the middle now, moving into calmer water. The current eased. The cables stopped groaning. The horses began to relax.

And then the log hit them.

It came out of nowhere—a massive piece of driftwood, waterlogged and nearly invisible in the brown water. It struck the side of the ferry with a sound like a cannon shot, and the whole boat shuddered and tipped.

The paint screamed and reared. This time it pulled free of the mule, the rope snapping, and it lunged sideways—straight into Fox.

Fox went over the side.

He didn't fall so much as tumble, his arms flailing, his body twisting in the air. He hit the water with a flat, ugly splash and disappeared beneath the surface.

"Fox!" Rain screamed.

The current had him. Crow could see him surface twenty feet downstream, his arms thrashing, his head barely above the brown water. He was being pulled away from the ferry, toward the middle of the river, toward the place where the current was strongest.

Stone was already moving. He grabbed a coil of rope from the deck and threw it, but the rope fell short. Fox was too far away. He was getting farther every second.

"He can't swim," Stone said. His voice was flat, dead. "He never learned."

Crow looked at the water. It was brown and fast and cold, and Fox was drowning in it, and there was nothing any of them could do.

Then the donkey jumped.

It didn't hesitate. It didn't balk or bray or show any of the stubborn reluctance that had defined its entire existence. It simply walked to the edge of the ferry, looked at the water, and jumped in.

"What the—" the ferryman started.

The donkey was swimming. Its head was up, its ears forward, its legs churning beneath the surface. It was moving against the current, angling toward the place where Fox had gone under.

Fox surfaced again, choking, his arms slapping at the water. He saw the donkey coming and his eyes went wide.

"Grab him!" Crow shouted. "Grab the mane!"

Fox reached out. His fingers closed on the donkey's neck, and he held on.

The donkey kept swimming. It was fighting the current now, its whole body straining, but it didn't stop. It turned toward the far shore—not back to the ferry, which was too far away, but toward the bank that was closer, the bank they had been heading toward anyway.

Crow watched them go. The donkey's head, the boy's head, two dark shapes against the brown water, getting smaller as the current carried them downstream. He couldn't tell if they were going to make it. He couldn't tell anything.

The ferryman was still working the crank, pulling them toward the far shore. Stone stood at the edge of the ferry, his hand on his knife, as if he could fight the river itself.

Rain had her hand over her mouth. She wasn't making a sound.

They reached the far bank and the ferryman tied off the cables. "Get off," he said. "Get off and go find your boy."

They didn't need to be told twice.

They found Fox and the donkey a quarter mile downstream.

Fox was lying on the muddy bank, coughing up river water. The donkey was standing next to him, soaking wet, looking profoundly irritated about the whole situation.

Stone reached them first. He grabbed Fox by the shoulders and hauled him upright, looking into his face.

"Are you hurt?"

Fox shook his head. He was shaking all over, his teeth chattering, but he was alive.

"What happened to the paint?"

"Still on the ferry," Crow said. He had come up behind Stone, leading his own horse. "Rain's got him."

Fox looked at the donkey. The animal looked back at him with an expression that seemed to say: Yes, I saved your life. No, I don't expect gratitude. Yes, you still owe me.

"He jumped in," Fox said. His voice was hoarse from the river water. "He just—he jumped in. I didn't even call him."

“Donkeys swim better than horses,” Stone said. “Their bodies are different. They float easier.”

“I don’t care why he did it.” Fox reached out and put his hand on the donkey’s neck. The animal didn’t pull away. “He saved me. That stupid, stubborn, worthless animal saved my life.”

The donkey snorted. It might have been agreement. It might have been dismissal. With donkeys, it was hard to tell.

Rain arrived with the other horses, the mule walking steadily beside her. She slid off her mount and ran to Fox, checking him for injuries with quick, practiced hands.

“Nothing broken,” she said. “You swallowed half the river, but you’ll live.”

“Thanks to him.” Fox was still looking at the donkey. “I spent the whole trip wanting to shoot him, and he—”

“He’s a donkey,” Stone said. “He doesn’t know what you wanted. He just knows what he did.” He turned and started walking toward the horses. “We need to move. The ferryman will talk. People will come looking.”

They gathered their animals and their gear. Fox tried to mount his paint, but his legs were shaking too badly. Stone lifted him into the saddle without a word.

As they rode away from the river, Crow looked back once. The Mississippi was still there, vast and brown and indifferent, carrying its cargo of leaves and branches and secrets toward the sea. They had crossed it. They were on the other side now.

There was no going back.

They rode until dark, putting miles between themselves and the ferry landing. The land on this side of the river was different—flatter, more settled, crisscrossed with roads and dotted with farms. They had to move carefully, staying in the trees, avoiding the main trails.

Fox rode in silence. The shaking had stopped, but something else had taken its place—a quietness that Crow had never seen in the boy before. He kept

looking at the donkey, which was walking beside the mule as if nothing had happened.

When they finally made camp, in a dense thicket where the firelight wouldn't be seen, Fox went straight to the donkey. He stood in front of the animal for a long moment, just looking at it.

Then he pulled a piece of dried meat from his pack and held it out.

The donkey looked at the meat. It looked at Fox. It seemed to be considering whether this was some kind of trick.

"Take it," Fox said. "You earned it."

The donkey took the meat. It chewed slowly, watching Fox the whole time.

"I was wrong about you," Fox said quietly. "I thought you were just a nuisance. Something we should have left behind." He paused. "I was wrong."

The donkey finished the meat and snorted. It didn't seem impressed by the apology. But it also didn't walk away.

Crow watched from across the camp, Rain beside him. Stone was checking the horses, his back to them, but Crow could tell he was listening.

"The boy is learning," Rain said softly.

"He almost died learning."

Rain said nothing. She leaned against him. "The river is behind us now. What's ahead?"

Crow looked east, toward the darkness beyond the firelight. Somewhere out there was Washington. Somewhere out there were the men they had come to kill. The distance seemed smaller now than it had that morning, when the river had still been in front of them.

"Everything," he said. "Everything is ahead."

The fire crackled and popped. The donkey stood with the mule, both animals calm, both animals resting. Fox was finally asleep, exhausted from his ordeal. Stone had finished with the horses and was sitting by the fire, staring into the flames.

Ridge was apart from the others again, his hand pressed against his chest where the ribbon was hidden. He wasn't sleeping. Crow didn't think he slept much anymore.

Crow closed his eyes. Tomorrow they would ride again. Tonight, for a few hours at least, they could rest.

The donkey brayed once, softly, as if reminding them all that it was still there.

Nobody told it to be quiet. Nobody complained.

After today, the donkey had earned its voice.

CHAPTER TEN

The world on the other side of the river was not the same world they had left behind.

Crow noticed it first in the roads. They were everywhere now—not just trails worn into the grass by horses and deer, but actual roads, cut and graded and sometimes even covered with crushed stone. They crisscrossed the land like veins, connecting farms to towns to other farms, carrying wagons and riders and people on foot who walked with the hurried purpose of those who had somewhere to be.

The Comanche stayed off the roads. They moved through the forests that still grew between the cleared fields, following deer paths and creek beds, staying in the shadows. Ridge went ahead to scout, returning with reports of settlements and crossings and the safest routes around them.

“There’s a town ahead,” he said on the third day after the river. They were camped in a ravine, hidden from the road by a thick stand of oak. “Larger than the others. Maybe two hundred people.”

“Can we go around?” Stone asked.

“We can. But it will cost us two days.” Ridge squatted by the cold fire, drawing lines in the dirt. “The road curves north here, around a swamp. If we follow it, we have to cross open ground for nearly a mile. If we go around the town to the south, we hit a river—smaller than the Mississippi, but deep. No ferry.”

Crow studied the map in the dirt. “What’s in the town?”

“Supplies. News. A place to buy food that isn’t squirrel.” Ridge looked up. “And information. People talk in towns. They talk about what’s happening in Washington, what the army is doing, where the patrols are.” He paused. “We’re going to need that information before we get much closer.”

“You want to go in,” Crow said.

“I have to go in. I’m the only one who can.” Ridge brushed the dirt from his hands. “The question is whether I go alone.”

Rain had been listening from the edge of the camp, mending a tear in one of the pack straps. She set down her work and walked over.

"I'll go with you," she said.

The men looked at her. Stone's face was unreadable. Fox's mouth opened, then closed. Crow said nothing, but something tightened in his chest.

"It's dangerous," Ridge said.

"Everything is dangerous. We've been dangerous since we left the camp." Rain stood with her arms crossed, her chin up. "You said yourself—you're the only one who can walk into that town without being shot. But a man alone draws attention. A man with a woman draws less."

"She's right," Stone said quietly. Everyone looked at him. He shrugged. "A couple traveling is invisible. A lone Indian walking into a white town is a target."

Ridge looked at Rain for a long moment. Then he looked at Crow.

"It's her choice," Crow said. The words felt heavy in his mouth. "It's always been her choice."

Rain walked to him and put her hand on his arm. "I'll be careful."

"I know you will."

"And I'll come back."

"I know that too." He covered her hand with his. "Just don't let him get you killed. I'd have to avenge you, and I'm too old for that."

Rain almost smiled. "I'll keep that in mind."

They spent the rest of the day preparing.

Ridge found clothes for Rain in one of the packs—a plain cotton dress that had belonged to the sympathetic widow, traded for some of their dried meat. It was too big, but Rain cinched it with a belt and rolled the sleeves. She braided her hair differently, wrapping it in a style she had seen white women wear.

When she was finished, she looked like someone else. Not completely—her face was still her face, her eyes still her eyes—but different enough. She looked like a woman who might be Cherokee, or maybe Spanish, or maybe just dark-skinned in the way that some people were. She looked like she belonged on a road in this country.

“How do I look?” she asked.

“Like a stranger,” Crow said.

“Good.” She turned to Ridge. “What do I need to know?”

They talked for an hour, Ridge explaining the rules of the white world. Don’t speak unless spoken to. Keep your eyes down. Let the man do the talking. If someone asks where you’re from, say Kentucky. If someone asks where you’re going, say you’re visiting family in Virginia. Never give more information than you have to.

“And if something goes wrong?” Rain asked.

“Walk away. Don’t run—running draws attention. Just walk, calmly, toward the edge of town. I’ll find you.”

“And if you don’t?”

Ridge was quiet for a moment. “Then get back to the others and keep going. Washington is east. You’ll find it.”

Rain nodded. She didn’t argue. She understood what they all understood—that the mission was bigger than any of them, bigger than any one life.

They left at dawn.

Crow watched them go from the edge of the ravine—Ridge walking slightly ahead, Rain a half-step behind, both of them moving with the easy pace of travelers who had nowhere particular to be. They looked natural. They looked like a hundred other couples on a hundred other roads.

He watched until they disappeared around a bend in the trail. Then he went back to the camp and sat down to wait.

The day passed slowly. Stone sharpened his knife until the blade could split a hair. Fox paced the length of the ravine, then paced it again. The donkey stood near the mule, both animals dozing in the shade, unbothered by the tension that filled the camp like smoke.

"They'll be fine," Stone said, though no one had asked.

"I know," Crow said.

"Ridge knows what he's doing."

"I know that too."

Stone went back to sharpening. Fox went back to pacing. Crow sat and watched the shadows move across the ground, measuring time by the angle of the sun.

Rain had never seen so many buildings in one place.

The town appeared gradually as they walked—first a few scattered farmhouses, then more houses closer together, then actual streets lined with structures of wood and brick. There was a church with a white steeple, a general store with goods piled in the windows, a blacksmith's shop where the sound of hammering rang out like distant thunder.

And people. So many people.

They walked past them on the street, rode past in wagons, stood in doorways talking and laughing. White faces, mostly, but some darker ones too—people who might have been slaves, or freedmen, or something in between. Everyone seemed to be moving, doing, going somewhere.

Rain kept her eyes down, as Ridge had instructed, but she couldn't help glancing up at times. The scale of it was overwhelming. Back home, the whole camp could have fit inside the general store. The church alone was bigger than any structure she had ever seen.

"Don't stare," Ridge murmured.

"I'm not staring."

"You're staring. Look at the ground. Look at me. Don't look at the buildings."

She forced her eyes down. It was harder than she had expected. Everything was so strange, so different. The smells alone were overwhelming—woodsmoke and horse manure and something sweet she couldn't identify, mixed with the stench of too many people living too close together.

"How do they stand it?" she whispered.

"They don't notice it. This is just how the world is, to them."

"It's wrong."

"Maybe. But it's what we have to move through." Ridge touched her elbow, guiding her toward the general store. "Stay close. Don't speak unless someone speaks to you directly. And remember—we're visiting family in Virginia."

The store was dim and crowded with goods. Barrels of flour and sugar lined the walls. Tools hung from the ceiling. Bolts of cloth were stacked on tables, and behind the counter stood a man with a red face and suspicious eyes.

"Help you?" he asked.

"Just passing through," Ridge said. His voice was different—flatter, more clipped, with an accent Rain didn't recognize. "Need some salt, if you have it. And coffee."

The man studied them. His eyes moved from Ridge to Rain, lingering on her face.

"Where you from?"

"Kentucky. Heading to Virginia to see my wife's people."

"Long way to travel."

"It is. That's why we need the coffee."

The man grunted. He turned and began measuring salt into a paper sack. Rain stood very still, her heart beating too fast, certain that everyone in the store was looking at her.

They weren't. A woman in the corner was examining fabric. A man near the door was loading supplies into a crate. No one cared about two travelers buying salt.

"Twelve cents," the storekeeper said, setting the items on the counter.

Ridge paid. He thanked the man and picked up the supplies. Rain followed him out of the store, and it wasn't until they were back on the street that she realized she had been holding her breath.

"You did well," Ridge said quietly.

"I didn't do anything."

"Exactly."

They walked further into town. Ridge stopped to talk to a man outside the blacksmith's shop, asking about the roads ahead. Rain stood nearby, listening without appearing to listen.

"...patrols been thick lately," the man was saying. He was old, with a beard stained yellow by tobacco. "Ever since that trouble up in Pennsylvania. Runaways, they say. Army's out looking for them."

"Runaways?"

"Slaves. Or Indians. Or both, depending on who you ask." The man spat. "Government's got everybody worked up about something. Always do, this time of year. Election coming."

"Much trouble on the road to Washington?"

The man looked at Ridge with new interest. "You heading to Washington?"

"Passing through that way. My wife's family is in Virginia, near the capital."

"Mmm." The man scratched his beard. "Should be fine, long as you stick to the main roads. The patrols are mostly looking in the backcountry. Looking for camps, hideouts, that sort of thing." He paused. "You ain't in any trouble, are you?"

"No trouble. Just trying to get where we're going."

“Aren’t we all.” The man turned and went back to watching the blacksmith work. The conversation was over.

Ridge touched Rain’s arm and they walked on.

They found a place to sit near the edge of town—a low wall outside a building that might have been a courthouse. Rain was tired, her feet sore from the unfamiliar shoes, her head aching from the noise and the crowds.

“What did you learn?” she asked quietly.

“Patrols are looking in the backcountry. We stay near the roads, we should be fine.” Ridge looked out at the street, at the people passing. “There’s news from Washington. The government is stirred up about something—runaway slaves, Indian trouble, something. The army is active.”

“Does that make it harder?”

“It makes it different. More eyes watching, more questions being asked. But also more confusion. Easier to slip through when everyone is looking somewhere else.”

Rain watched a woman walk past, carrying a child on her hip. The woman was young, not much older than Rain had been when she had Hawk. The child was sleeping, its face peaceful, oblivious to everything.

“They don’t know,” Rain said.

“Know what?”

“What’s coming. What we’re going to do.” She paused. “They just live their lives. They buy salt and talk about the weather and carry their children. They don’t know that their President is going to die.”

Ridge was quiet for a moment. “No. They don’t know.”

“Does that bother you?”

“What do you mean?”

“That we’re going to change their world, and they don’t even know it’s coming.”

Ridge looked at her. His face was still. He looked past her, past the town, past everything.

“Their world changed mine,” he said. “They didn’t ask permission. They didn’t warn us. They just came, with their soldiers and their laws and their papers, and they took everything.” He paused. “I don’t feel bad about returning the favor.”

Rain nodded slowly. She understood. She had always understood. But seeing this place, these people, made it feel different somehow. More real. More heavy.

“We should go,” Ridge said. “The others will be worried.”

They stood and walked back through the town, past the church and the store and the blacksmith’s shop. People glanced at them and looked away, seeing nothing worth remembering. Two travelers passing through, heading to Virginia, unremarkable in every way.

The sun was low when they returned to the ravine.

Crow was standing at the edge of the trees, watching for them. When he saw Rain emerge from the shadows, something in his face loosened—relief, or maybe just the release of a tension he hadn’t admitted to holding.

“You’re back,” he said.

“We’re back.” Rain walked to him and put her arms around him. He held her, not speaking, just holding.

“Any trouble?” Stone asked.

“No trouble.” Ridge sat down by the cold fire. “The roads to Washington are clear, mostly. Patrols are active but looking in the wrong places. We should be fine if we stay smart.”

“And the town?”

“Loud. Crowded. Full of people who don’t notice anything that isn’t directly in front of them.” Ridge pulled out the salt and coffee and set them on the ground. “But useful. We know more now than we did this morning.”

Fox was staring at Rain with an expression of wonder. "You walked into a white town. Just walked in."

"I walked in. I walked out." Rain was still in Crow's arms, her head against his chest. "It wasn't difficult. They see what they expect to see."

"What do they expect to see?"

"A woman. A wife." She pulled back and looked at Fox. "Someone who belongs to someone else. That's all they need to know."

Fox shook his head slowly. "I couldn't do it. I'd want to—" He made a gesture with his hand, something violent.

"I know," Rain said. "That's why you stayed here."

She walked to the edge of the camp, pulling off the dress as she went, changing back into her own clothes. Crow watched her go. She was the same person who had left that morning, but something was different. She had seen the enemy's world from the inside. She had walked among them, invisible, and walked out again.

It changed a person, seeing that. Knowing you could do it.

That night, after the others were asleep, Rain sat with Crow by the fire.

"Tell me," he said.

She was quiet for a long moment. Then she began to talk—about the buildings and the people, the smells and the sounds, the woman with the child and the man with the yellow beard. She talked about the store and the suspicious eyes of the keeper, about the way everyone moved so fast, as if time was something they could run out of.

"It's not what I expected," she said finally.

"What did you expect?"

"I don't know. Something... bigger. More frightening." She shook her head. "But it's just people. Strange people, living in strange ways, but still just people. They eat and sleep and carry their children, same as us."

"Does that make it harder?"

Rain thought about it. “No,” she said. “It makes it different. But not harder.”
“How?”

“Because now I know.” She looked at him, her eyes reflecting the firelight. “They’re not demons. They’re not spirits or monsters or anything we couldn’t understand. They’re just people who took something that wasn’t theirs, and now they’re going to pay for it.” She paused. “That’s easier, in a way. It’s easier to kill a person than a monster.”

Crow nodded slowly.

“You’re a wise woman,” he said.

“I’m a tired woman.” She leaned against him. “Tomorrow we keep going?”

“Tomorrow we keep going. Washington is still ahead.”

“How far?”

Crow looked east, toward the darkness beyond the fire. “Ridge says a week, maybe less. Depending on the roads.”

“A week.” Rain closed her eyes. “Then we’ll be there. In the heart of it.”

“Yes.”

“Are you ready?”

Crow thought about the question. Was he ready? He had been ready when they left the camp. He had been ready when they crossed the river. But every mile they traveled, every day that passed, the reality of what they were doing settled deeper into his bones. This wasn’t a story anymore. This wasn’t something that might happen. This was happening, right now, and they were the ones making it happen.

“I don’t know,” he said honestly. “But I don’t think readiness matters. We’re going whether we’re ready or not.”

Rain laughed softly. “That sounds like something Stone would say.”

“Maybe I’m becoming Stone in my old age.”

“God forbid.” She settled against him, her breathing slowing. “Wake me when it’s time to move.”

“I will.”

She slept. Crow sat and watched the fire burn down to coals, then to ash, then to nothing. The night was quiet around them, the forest holding its breath. Somewhere in the distance, an owl called out, and something small died in the darkness.

The donkey shifted near the mule, both animals standing hip to hip, sharing warmth. They had stopped fighting days ago.

Crow closed his eyes. Tomorrow they would ride again. The east was waiting.

Washington was ahead.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

They smelled Washington before they saw it too, but it was a different smell than the Mississippi—smoke and sewage and the sharp tang of coal, mixed with something almost sweet that Rain said was rotting garbage.

“That’s the capital?” Fox asked. He was staring at the haze on the horizon, the brown smudge that hung over the land like a stain.

“That’s it,” Ridge said.

They had been traveling for three days since the town where Rain played the wife. The roads had grown thicker, the settlements closer together, until it seemed like they were never truly alone. They moved at night now, sleeping in thickets during the day, emerging only when the roads emptied and the farms went dark.

The land itself had changed. Gone were the forests and open spaces. Here everything was divided—fenced fields, orchards in neat rows, roads that ran straight as knife cuts toward the city. Even the trees looked tamed, planted in lines along property boundaries, serving purposes instead of just growing.

“We need to stop,” Crow said. “Find a place to camp before we get any closer.”

Ridge nodded. He pointed toward a low hill to the north, crowned with a tangle of brush and scrub oak. “There. High enough to see anyone coming, thick enough to hide in.”

They turned off the road and picked their way through a harvested corn-field, the stubble crackling under the horses’ hooves. The donkey followed the mule without complaint now—that battle had been settled somewhere around the Mississippi, and they walked together like old partners, the mule’s patience having worn down the donkey’s objections.

The hill was better than it looked from the road. A shallow ravine cut through one side, hidden by the brush, and a seep spring at the bottom gave them water. They picketed the horses in the ravine and made a cold camp, no fire, blankets spread on the damp ground.

“How far?” Stone asked.

Ridge studied the haze on the horizon. “Five miles. Maybe six. Close enough to walk in before dawn and walk out before dark.”

“When do you go?”

“Tomorrow.” Ridge sat down on a fallen log, his eyes still fixed on the distant city. “I need to see it first. Learn the streets. Find where they live.”

“We could all go,” Fox said. “Like Rain did. Walk in together.”

“No.” Ridge’s voice was flat. “Five Indians walking into Washington would be noticed. One man, dressed well, speaking proper English—that’s invisible. That’s how we do this.”

“And if something goes wrong?”

“Then you wait three days. If I’m not back, you go home.” Ridge looked at Fox, and something in his face softened slightly. “This isn’t the time for bravery. This is the time for patience.”

Fox opened his mouth to argue, but Stone caught his eye and shook his head. The boy subsided, though his jaw stayed tight.

Rain was unpacking the supplies, laying out dried meat and the last of the coffee they had bought in that town. She worked in silence, her movements efficient, her face unreadable.

“What are you thinking?” Crow asked her quietly.

“I’m thinking about that woman with the child.” She didn’t look up. “The one in the town. How she walked past us like we were nothing. Like we weren’t even there.”

“We weren’t there. Not to her.”

“No. We were invisible.” Rain set down the meat and looked toward the haze on the horizon. “That’s how we get in, isn’t it? By being invisible. By being so ordinary that no one sees us.”

“That’s how Ridge gets in. We wait here.”

“I know.” She picked up the meat again. “I just keep thinking about that woman. About what her life will be like after. Whether she’ll even notice.”

Crow didn’t answer. There was no answer to give.

Ridge left before dawn.

He had changed his clothes the night before, pulling from his pack a suit that looked like it had belonged to a prosperous farmer or a small-town lawyer. The jacket was dark wool, slightly worn at the elbows but respectable. The shirt beneath it was clean, white, buttoned to the throat. He had shaved with Stone’s knife and combed his hair back with water from the spring.

When he walked out of the ravine, he looked like someone else. Not a Cherokee who had survived the Trail. Not an Indian at all, really, unless you knew what to look for. He looked like a man who might work for the government, or sell goods, or represent some company in some distant city.

“Three days,” he said to Crow. “If I’m not back—”

“You’ll be back.”

Ridge almost smiled. “Yes. I’ll be back.”

He walked toward the road without looking behind him. The others watched until he was out of sight, a dark figure against the gray morning light, and then they went back to their cold camp to wait.

The first day passed slowly.

Stone cleaned his weapons. Fox paced the perimeter of their camp, checking sight lines, looking for approaches. Rain mended a tear in one of the pack straps, then another, then sat looking at the horizon with her hands in her lap.

Crow watched them all. It was what he did—had always done, even before this journey began. The observer. The one who noticed things others missed.

What he noticed now was the tension. It was different from the tension of the trail, the constant alertness for farmers and patrols and hostile strangers. This was something deeper. They were close now. Close enough to see the smoke of the city they had come to strike. Close enough that the mission had stopped being a story and had become a reality.

“What do you think he’s seeing?” Fox asked. He had stopped pacing and was staring at the haze on the horizon.

“Streets,” Stone said. “Buildings. People.”

“The White House?”

“Maybe.”

“You think he’ll see Van Buren? Just—walking around?”

Stone looked at the boy. His face was patient. “I think Ridge knows what he’s doing. I think we let him do it.”

Fox nodded, but his hands were restless, moving from knife to bow to nothing.

“Sit down,” Crow said. “You’re wearing a hole in the ground.”

Fox sat. But he kept looking at the horizon.

Ridge walked into Washington at midmorning, when the streets were busy enough that one more man would disappear into the crowd.

The city was larger than he remembered. He had been here once before, fifteen years ago, when the Cherokee had sent a delegation to argue their case before Congress. They had stayed at a boarding house near the Capitol, had walked these same streets in their finest clothes, had believed that justice was possible if they could only find the right words.

That had been before Jackson. Before the Indian Removal Act. Before the soldiers came.

Ridge pushed the memory aside. He was not here to remember. He was here to learn.

The streets were mud and cobblestone, a mix that seemed to change from block to block. Wagons rolled past, loaded with goods. Men in dark suits hurried in and out of buildings. Women in long dresses walked in pairs, their heads bent together in conversation. Everyone was moving, doing, going somewhere.

No one looked at him.

He walked toward the center of the city, following the flow of traffic. The buildings grew larger, more imposing—banks and offices and government buildings, their facades bright with whitewash or dark with soot. Signs advertised lawyers and merchants and newspapers. A hotel on one corner had a line of carriages waiting outside.

And there, at the end of a wide avenue, stood the White House.

Ridge stopped walking. He stood on the corner and looked at it for a long moment, as if seeing it for the first time.

It was smaller than he remembered. Or maybe he had grown larger, in some way—larger in his grief, in his purpose, in the cold certainty that had carried him across a thousand miles. The building that had seemed so grand fifteen years ago now looked almost ordinary. Just a house. A big house, painted white, with columns and windows and a lawn that stretched down to an iron fence.

A man lived in that house. A man who had signed the papers that killed four thousand people.

Ridge resumed walking. He passed the White House without slowing, glancing at it from the corner of his eye like any other pedestrian. Two soldiers stood at the main gate, their uniforms bright, their rifles at their shoulders. They looked bored.

He noted their positions. Noted the distance from the fence to the door. Noted the servants coming and going through a side entrance, carrying baskets and bundles. Noted everything.

Then he walked on.

The War Department was a squat brick building two blocks east of the White House.

Ridge found a bench across the street and sat down, pulling a newspaper from his jacket. It was a week old—he had bought it at a general store on the road—but it served its purpose. A man reading a newspaper was invisible. A man staring at a government building was suspicious.

He sat for an hour, pretending to read, watching the door.

People came and went. Clerks, mostly, carrying papers and ledgers. A few military officers in bright uniforms, their boots clicking on the stone steps. Servants and messengers and men who looked like they belonged nowhere and everywhere at once.

At eleven o'clock, a carriage pulled up to the entrance. A man stepped out—tall, angular, dressed in black, with a face that looked like it had been carved from granite. He walked up the steps without looking at anyone, and the soldiers at the door snapped to attention.

Ridge folded his newspaper and watched.

Poinsett. It had to be. The Secretary of War. The man who had overseen the removal, who had bragged that forty thousand Indians had been pushed west during his tenure. Ridge recognized him from the drawings in the newspapers, from the descriptions he had heard over the years.

The man who had signed the orders. The man who had sent the soldiers.

He watched Poinsett disappear through the door. Then he stood, tucked the newspaper under his arm, and walked away.

By afternoon, Ridge had learned the rhythms of the city.

Van Buren left the White House most mornings around ten, usually in a carriage, sometimes on foot with a small group of aides. He attended meetings at the Capitol, took luncheon at a hotel two blocks away, returned to the White House by late afternoon. His schedule was public knowledge—the newspapers printed it, in fact, announcing when and where the President would appear.

Poinsett was more difficult. The Secretary of War kept irregular hours, arriving early some days, late others. He lived in a townhouse on the north side of the city, a quiet street lined with similar houses. Ridge walked past it twice, noting the single guard at the door, the windows on the upper floors, the alley that ran behind the row.

The city itself was poorly guarded. Ridge had expected soldiers on every corner, checkpoints at every road. Instead he found... nothing. A few guards at the government buildings. A watchman here and there. The city went about its business as if it had nothing to fear.

Ridge bought lunch at a public house—bread and cheese and weak beer—and sat near a group of men who looked like clerks. They talked about the weather, about a horse race at some track outside the city, about a senator who had made a fool of himself at a party. Normal things. Ordinary things.

They didn't talk about Indians. They didn't talk about the removal, or the Trail, or the four thousand dead. Why would they? That was old news. That was last year. The world had moved on.

Ridge finished his lunch and left.

He spent the afternoon walking the streets around the White House.

The grounds were open. People walked across the lawn, petitioned at the gate, stood on the avenue and pointed at the building like it was a monument. The soldiers at the gate watched but didn't interfere. This was a public place. The people owned it.

Ridge tested the boundaries. He walked to the fence and stood there for a moment, looking at the house. One of the soldiers glanced at him, then looked away. No one told him to move. No one asked his business.

He walked around the perimeter. The fence was iron, maybe eight feet tall, with spikes at the top. Easy enough to climb, if a man was determined. The grounds beyond were open—lawn, gardens, a few trees. No cover. Anyone crossing that space would be seen.

But the side entrance was different. A low gate led to a service yard, and servants passed through it regularly, carrying laundry and firewood and the

hundred other things a household required. The soldiers at the front gate couldn't see the side entrance. Neither could the guards at the main door.

Ridge made a note.

He walked to the back of the building, where the grounds sloped down toward a swampy area that smelled of standing water. The fence here was lower, and there were no guards at all. A man could approach from this direction in the dark, climb the fence, cross the grounds to the house itself.

He made another note.

Then he walked away, back toward the main avenue, back toward the crowds and the noise and the ordinary business of the city. He had seen enough.

He found Poinsett's townhouse again as the sun was setting.

The street was quiet now—most of the residents had gone inside for dinner. A lamp burned in the front window of the townhouse, and through the curtains Ridge could see the shadow of someone moving.

He walked past slowly, his hands in his pockets, his eyes forward. Just a man on his way somewhere. Just a man walking home.

The guard at the door was gone. Perhaps he only stood there during the day, or perhaps Poinsett had dismissed him for the evening. The door was closed but not barred—Ridge could see from the latch.

The alley behind the row was dark and narrow, barely wide enough for a cart. Ridge entered it from the far end, walking slowly, letting his eyes adjust. The backs of the houses were less elegant than the fronts—small yards, outhouses, stacks of firewood and coal.

Poinsett's house had a back door. It was locked, but the window beside it was cracked open, probably for ventilation. A man could reach through that window, unlatch the door, step inside.

Ridge didn't touch anything. He just looked. Measured. Planned.

Then he turned and walked back to the main street, back toward the edge of the city, back toward the camp where the others were waiting.

He returned after midnight.

The others were awake—they had been awake since sunset, unable to sleep, unable to do anything but wait. When Ridge emerged from the darkness, they rose as one, their faces pale in the moonlight.

“Well?” Stone asked.

Ridge sat down on the fallen log. He looked tired—more tired than Crow had ever seen him. But his eyes were bright with something that might have been satisfaction.

“I know how to do it,” he said.

They gathered around him in the darkness, leaning close, listening.

“Van Buren leaves the White House most mornings around ten. He goes to the Capitol, or to a hotel for luncheon, and returns in the afternoon. The guards at the White House are ceremonial—two at the main gate, two at the door. The side entrance has no guards at all.”

“You’re going to walk in through the side?” Fox asked.

“No. The servants use that entrance. A stranger would be noticed.” Ridge drew a line in the dirt with his finger, the way he had drawn maps in the camp. “But at night, it’s different. The guards sleep, or drink, or go home. The fence at the back is low and unpatrolled. A man could climb it, cross the grounds, enter through a window.”

“Which window?” Stone asked.

“The President’s study is on the ground floor, facing the back lawn. I saw him through the window this afternoon—sitting at his desk, reading papers. The curtains were open.” Ridge looked up. “He stays late sometimes. Reading. Signing documents. Alone.”

The silence was heavy. Crow could feel his heart beating in his chest.

“And Poinsett?” Rain asked.

“Poinsett lives in a townhouse on the north side. One guard at the front during the day, none at night. The back door can be unlocked from outside—there’s a window beside it, cracked open for air. His bedroom is on the second floor, front of the house.”

“You saw all this in one day?” Fox was staring at Ridge with something like awe.

“I’ve been thinking about this for a long time. I knew what to look for.” Ridge brushed the dirt from his hands. “The city isn’t ready for us. They don’t guard their leaders because they don’t believe anyone would come. The idea of Indians walking into Washington, into the White House, into the Secretary of War’s bedroom—it doesn’t exist in their minds. It’s impossible. So they don’t prepare for it.”

“But it’s not impossible,” Stone said.

“No.” Ridge’s voice was quiet but certain. “It’s not impossible at all.”

He looked at each of them in turn—Stone, Fox, Rain, Crow. His face was calm, almost peaceful.

“We need one more day. I’ll go back tomorrow, confirm the schedules, find the escape routes. Then we plan. Then we act.”

“How soon?” Crow asked.

Ridge was silent for a moment. The wind moved through the brush, rustling the dead leaves.

“Two nights from now,” he said. “The moon will be dark. The city will be asleep.”

He lay back on his blanket and closed his eyes. Within minutes, his breathing had slowed to the rhythm of sleep.

The others sat in the darkness, looking at each other, looking at the haze on the horizon where the city waited.

Two nights.

It was really happening.

Crow couldn't sleep.

He lay beside Rain, listening to her breathe, watching the stars through the branches above. The air was cold but not bitter, carrying that strange city smell that seemed to seep through everything.

Two nights. In two nights, they would walk into the capital of the nation that had tried to destroy them. They would find the men who had signed the orders, sent the soldiers, killed the thousands. They would end those men, quietly, in the dark, and then they would disappear.

It sounded simple when Ridge said it. Clinical, almost. A plan with steps, like building a house or breaking a horse.

But Crow knew it wasn't simple. Nothing was ever simple.

He thought about Van Buren sitting at his desk, reading papers in the lamplight. Did he know? Did he think about the Trail, about the dead, about the children who had died in their mothers' arms? Or was it just policy to him—a decision made and forgotten, filed away with a thousand other decisions?

He thought about Poinsett in his townhouse, eating dinner, reading a book, going to bed without a guard at his door. The man who had bragged about moving forty thousand people. The man who had counted them like cattle.

What would it feel like, Crow wondered, to stand over that man in the dark? To be the last thing he saw?

He didn't know. He might never know. Ridge would handle the killing—that was clear. Stone would help, and maybe Fox, though the boy would need to be controlled.

And Crow? Crow would watch. That was what he did. What he had always done.

But maybe this time, watching wouldn't be enough.

Rain stirred beside him, and he turned to look at her. Her eyes were open.

"You're not sleeping," she said quietly.

"Neither are you."

“No.” She shifted closer, her hand finding his. “I keep thinking about what happens after.”

“After we do it?”

“After we go home. After the world knows.” Her voice was soft in the darkness. “Everything will be different. They’ll come looking. They’ll want revenge.”

“They were already coming. They were already taking.”

“I know. But it will be faster, after this. More certain.” She paused. “We’re trading our future for this moment. Are we sure it’s worth it?”

Crow was quiet for a long time. He watched the stars, the same stars that had watched over his people since the beginning of time. The same stars that had watched them lose everything.

“Nothing is certain,” he said finally. “But if we don’t act, we die anyway. Slowly, quietly, one piece at a time.” He squeezed her hand. “This way, at least we die having done something.”

Rain was silent. Then she turned and pressed her face against his shoulder, and he held her, and they lay there together in the darkness, not sleeping, waiting for the dawn.

The donkey shifted in the ravine below, its ears pricking toward some sound in the night. But there was nothing—just the wind, and the city in the distance, and the weight of what was coming pressing down on them all.

Part III: Chapters 12-14 (Washington DC)

CHAPTER TWELVE

Ridge woke before the others, as he often did.

The sky was still dark, but the darkness had thinned at the eastern edge, gray bleeding into the black like water into ink. He lay still for a moment, listening. The horses shifted in the ravine below. A bird called somewhere in the distance—a whippoorwill, late in its season, confused by the warmth.

He rose quietly and walked to the edge of their camp, where the brush opened onto a view of the road below. Nothing moved. The haze over the city had faded in the night, and he could see the faint glow of lamps on the horizon, the first stirrings of a place that never truly slept.

Today he would go back. One more time, to confirm what he had seen, to fill in the gaps in his knowledge. And then—

He pushed the thought aside. There would be time for that later.

Rain was awake when he returned. She sat with her blanket wrapped around her shoulders, her eyes on the horizon.

"You're going back today," she said quietly.

"Yes."

"I'm coming with you."

Ridge looked at her. Her face was calm, her jaw set in a way he recognized from the first days of the journey.

"It's more dangerous now," he said. "We've been in the city. Someone might remember."

"One man is more memorable than two. A man and his wife—" She almost smiled. "That's ordinary. That's invisible."

He considered it. She was right, in her way. A couple drew less attention than a solitary figure. And she had proven herself in the town by the river, moving through crowds as if she belonged there.

"The dress from before," he said. "Can you wear it again?"

“I’ve been keeping it clean.”

He nodded. “We leave in an hour. We’ll walk in together, walk out together. Nothing more.”

Rain rose and went to find her things. Ridge watched her go, then turned back to the horizon, where the glow of the city was brightening with the coming dawn.

They reached the outskirts of Washington by midmorning.

The road was busier than before—wagons and carriages, men on horseback, groups of workers heading toward the city or away from it. Ridge and Rain walked among them without speaking, their pace unhurried, their faces blank.

Rain wore the blue dress she had worn in the river town, her hair pinned up beneath a bonnet she had fashioned from scraps of cloth. She walked with her hand through Ridge’s arm, her eyes cast down, the picture of a modest wife following her husband to market.

Ridge had dressed more carefully this time. The same dark suit, but with a different shirt, a different hat. His face was freshly shaved, his hair combed back with water. He looked like a man of business, a man with appointments to keep.

They passed through the edge of the city without incident. The guards at the road—such as they were—barely glanced at them. A man and his wife. Nothing to see.

The streets were familiar now. Ridge navigated them from memory, turning down the same avenues he had walked two days before, passing the same buildings, the same shops. The city had its rhythms, and he had learned them.

They walked past the War Department first. The building looked the same—squat, brick, unremarkable. A few clerks hurried up the steps, their arms full of papers. No sign of Poinsett.

Ridge noted the time. They would come back later, confirm the Secretary's schedule.

They turned toward the White House.

The avenue was wide here, lined with trees that had shed most of their leaves. The ground was covered with them—brown and gold and red, wet from the morning dew, slippery underfoot. Rain walked carefully, her hand tightening on Ridge's arm when she stumbled.

"Steady," he murmured.

"I see it," she said.

The White House stood at the end of the avenue, white and clean against the gray sky. The fence, the lawn, the columns—all as Ridge remembered. Two soldiers at the main gate, their uniforms bright, their rifles at their shoulders.

They walked past slowly, like any other couple admiring the President's home. Ridge pointed at the building, said something about the architecture. Rain nodded, smiled, played her part.

But her eyes were moving. Counting guards. Measuring distances. Noting the side entrance, the service yard, the servants passing through with their bundles and baskets.

They walked around the perimeter, following the fence. Ridge pointed out the gardens, the lawn, the trees. Rain asked questions in a voice just loud enough to be heard—innocent questions, the kind a wife might ask.

At the back of the grounds, where the fence was lower and the land sloped toward the swampy area, they paused. Ridge pretended to study the view while Rain adjusted her bonnet.

"No guards," she said quietly.

"None that I can see."

"The fence is low."

"Low enough." Ridge turned, offering her his arm again. "We should go. We've been here long enough."

They walked back toward the main avenue, past the soldiers at the gate, past the carriages and pedestrians. Just a couple, taking a morning stroll.

The encounter happened near the War Department.

They were walking north, heading toward the streets that would take them out of the city. The morning crowds had thickened, and they moved through them slowly, careful not to hurry.

A man stepped out of a doorway directly into their path.

He was middle-aged, balding, wearing the dark suit of a government clerk. He carried a stack of papers under one arm and a cup of something steaming in his free hand. He nearly collided with Ridge, stopped short, and looked up.

“Pardon me,” he said. Then his eyes narrowed. “Wait. I know you.”

Ridge’s heart stopped. But his face remained calm, polite, slightly confused.

“I’m sorry?”

“Your face.” The clerk was studying him now, his head tilted slightly. “I’ve seen you before. Years ago, wasn’t it? The Cherokee delegation. You were one of the speakers.”

Ridge felt Rain’s hand tighten on his arm. He kept his voice steady.

“I’m afraid you’re mistaken, sir. I was too young for any delegations fifteen years ago.”

The clerk frowned. “No, I’m certain... The way you carry yourself. The face.” He shook his head slowly. “You look just like one of those Cherokee men. The ones who came to argue their case.”

“My father,” Ridge said. The lie came easily, as if it had been waiting. “People say I resemble him. He died some years back.”

The clerk’s expression shifted—from suspicion to something like embarrassment. “I’m sorry to hear that. I didn’t mean to—” He paused, still studying Ridge’s face. “The resemblance is remarkable.”

“So I’m told.”

There was a long moment when neither of them moved. The crowds flowed around them, oblivious. Rain stood perfectly still, her hand on Ridge's arm, her face a mask of patient waiting.

Then the clerk stepped aside. "Forgive me. I've taken up your time."

"No harm done," Ridge said. He nodded politely and walked past, not too quickly, Rain matching his pace.

They didn't speak again until they were three blocks away, around a corner, out of sight.

"He knew," Rain said.

"He suspected." Ridge's voice was calm, but his jaw was tight. "There's a difference."

"If he tells someone—"

"He won't. He's not certain enough. And even if he were—" Ridge shook his head. "He saw a man who looked like someone he once met a decade and a half ago. In a city this size, that's nothing."

Rain was silent for a moment. Then she said, "We should go. Now."

"Yes."

They walked faster after that, but not too fast. Invisible. Ordinary. A couple heading home after a morning in the city.

By the time they reached the road out of Washington, Ridge's heart had slowed. The clerk's face was already fading from memory, replaced by the details of what he had seen. The guards, the fence, the approach from the back.

Tomorrow night, none of it would matter. The clerk would tell his story to no one, or he would tell it to everyone, and either way it would be too late.

They walked in silence, the city receding behind them, the hill where the others waited growing larger on the horizon.

They reached the camp in late afternoon.

The others were waiting—Stone cleaning his knife, Fox pacing the perimeter, Crow sitting on the fallen log with his eyes on the road below. They rose when Ridge and Rain emerged from the brush, their faces tense with questions.

“Well?” Stone asked.

Ridge sat down on the log. Rain began unpacking the few supplies they had carried with them—bread and cheese bought at a stall in the city, to maintain their appearance.

“It’s as I thought,” Ridge said. “The White House is poorly guarded. Two soldiers at the main gate, two at the front door. The side entrance has no guards. The back fence is low and unpatrolled.”

“And Poinsett?”

“We passed the War Department this morning. He wasn’t there yet—probably arrives late. But his townhouse is as I described. One guard at the front during the day, none at night. The back door can be reached from the alley.”

Stone nodded slowly. His face was calm, his hands still.

“When?” Fox asked.

Ridge looked at the sky. The sun was past its peak, sliding toward the western horizon. Tomorrow it would set, and the night would come, and—

“Tomorrow night,” he said. “The moon will be dark. We move at midnight.”

The silence was heavy. Crow could feel it pressing down on them all, the weight of what was coming made real by Ridge’s words.

“How do we do it?” Stone asked.

Ridge picked up a stick and began drawing in the dirt. The others gathered around him, leaning close.

“Two targets,” he said. “Van Buren at the White House. Poinsett at his townhouse. We hit them at the same time—one o’clock in the morning, when the city is deepest asleep.”

He drew a rough map: the White House, the townhouse, the roads between them. Then he drew two more marks—one half a mile from the city, one half a mile beyond that.

“Rain and I will take Van Buren.” He pointed at the White House. “We’ll approach from the back, where the fence is low. We climb over together, cross the grounds, enter through the study window. Rain comes inside with me.”

Fox looked at Rain, then back at Ridge. “Both of you? Inside?”

“She’s my backup. If there’s a guard—if I have to deal with someone before I can reach Van Buren—Rain takes the shot. Van Buren dies either way.”

Rain nodded. Her face was still, composed. “I can do it.”

“What about getting out?” Fox asked.

“We leave the way we came. Together. The grounds are dark, the fence is low. Once we’re over, we run for Crow’s position.”

“And if you’re seen? If someone raises an alarm?”

“Then we run. Straight back to the fence, over it, toward Crow’s position.” Ridge pointed at the first mark on his map. “No misdirection. No doubling back. Speed matters more than cunning once we’re discovered.”

Stone was studying the map. “And Poinsett?”

“Yours.” Ridge looked at him. “The townhouse is simpler than the White House. One target, no guards at night, easy approach from the alley. You go in through the back door—the window beside it is usually open. His bedroom is on the second floor.”

Stone’s face didn’t change, but something shifted in his posture. He sat up straighter, his shoulders squaring.

“Solo?” he asked.

“Solo.”

There was a moment of silence. Then Stone said, quietly, “Thank you.”

Ridge nodded. He didn't ask why Stone wanted Poinsett, why the Secretary of War mattered more to him than the President. Some things didn't need to be spoken.

"Crow," Ridge continued, "you'll be here." He pointed at the first mark, half a mile from the city. "The watch point. You can see the road from there, see anyone coming. If Stone or I have pursuers—if someone follows us out of the city—you stop them."

"How many?" Crow asked.

"Probably one, if any. A guard who saw something, a servant who raised an alarm. They won't send the whole army after shadows in the dark. Not at first." Ridge met Crow's eyes. "One pursuer, you kill. More than one, you fall back to Fox's position and we all run."

Crow nodded slowly. "And if no one follows?"

"Then you join us at Fox's position, and we ride west before dawn."

Ridge turned to Fox. The boy's face was tight, his jaw clenched, but he was listening.

"You stay with the animals," Ridge said. "Half a mile past Crow's position. Keep them ready—saddled, packed, facing the road out. If everything goes well, we meet you there and disappear. If something goes wrong—if someone gets past Crow—you're the last defense."

Fox opened his mouth, and Ridge held up a hand.

"I know you want to be in the city. I know you want to be part of the killing. But this is more important." Ridge's voice was calm, patient. "If the animals scatter, if we lose the horses, none of us survive the ride home. You're not just guarding horses. You're guarding our escape."

The boy was silent for a long moment. His hands were clenched at his sides, but then relaxed.

Then he nodded. "I understand."

"Good." Ridge looked around at all of them—Stone, Fox, Rain, Crow. "We leave tomorrow at sunset. We walk to the city together, then separate. Stone

goes north to Poinsett's. Rain and I go south to the White House. Crow takes his position. Fox stays with the animals."

He brushed the map away with his hand, erasing the lines in the dirt.

"Questions?"

Stone spoke first. "Weapons?"

"Knives. Arrows. Nothing loud." Ridge looked at Rain. "Your short bow—you can conceal it?"

"Under my shawl. It's dark enough, no one will see."

"Inside a house, close quarters—you're comfortable with that?"

Rain's expression didn't change. "I've killed before. Not men. But killing is killing."

"Good." Ridge turned to Stone. "You have your knife if there's a guard at the back door—"

"I'll be quiet." Stone's voice was flat, certain.

Ridge studied his face for a moment, then nodded. "Any other questions?"

Silence.

"Then we rest. Tomorrow will be long. The night after will be longer."

He lay back on his blanket and closed his eyes. The others dispersed slowly—Rain to check her weapons, Fox to the horses, Crow to his watching place at the edge of the camp.

Stone remained, still looking at the place where the map had been.

He left after dark.

The others were asleep—or pretending to be—when Stone rose from his blanket and moved quietly toward the edge of the camp. Crow watched him go, said nothing.

The night was cold and clear, the stars bright overhead. Stone walked down the hill and onto the road, his steps quiet, his breathing even. He carried nothing but his knife, tucked into his belt, and the clothes on his back.

The city was visible on the horizon—a glow of lamplight, a haze of smoke, the faint suggestion of buildings against the sky. Stone walked toward it, not hurrying. He had all night.

The road was empty at this hour. A few farms showed lights in their windows, but no one stirred outside. The world was asleep, and Stone moved through it like a ghost.

He reached the outskirts of the city within an hour.

The streets were different at night. Quieter, darker, the buildings looming like shadows against the sky. A few lamps burned in windows, and here and there a figure moved—a watchman, a drunk, a servant on some late errand—but they paid him no attention.

Stone walked north, following the route Ridge had described. Past the government buildings, dark and silent now. Past the shops and hotels, their doors closed, their signs creaking in the wind. Past the streets where the wealthy lived, their townhouses neat and prosperous behind iron fences.

Poinsett's street was quiet.

Stone found it without difficulty—the third street north of the War Department, the fifth house from the corner. A narrow townhouse, three stories tall, with a single lamp burning in an upper window.

He didn't approach. Not yet. Instead he stood in the shadow of a building across the street and watched.

The front door was closed. No guard that he could see—Ridge had been right about that. The lamp in the upper window flickered once, then went dark. Someone going to bed.

Stone waited. Minutes passed. Nothing moved.

He walked to the end of the street and turned into the alley that ran behind the row of townhouses. It was narrow here, barely wide enough for a cart,

and the darkness was almost complete. He moved slowly, counting houses, his hand trailing along the rough brick walls.

Five houses. The back of Poinsett's townhouse.

There was a small yard, a privy, a stack of firewood against the fence. The back door was set in a shallow alcove, and beside it—just as Ridge had said—a window, its curtain open, its frame slightly ajar.

Stone stood in the darkness and looked at the house. At the window. At the door that led inside.

Tomorrow night he would stand here again. Tomorrow night he would reach through that window, unlatch the door, climb the stairs to the second floor. Tomorrow night he would find Poinsett in his bed.

He pushed the thought aside. Not yet. Tonight was for learning.

He studied the approach—the distance from the alley to the fence, from the fence to the door. He noted the obstacles: a loose board in the fence, a water trough that would need to be stepped around. He listened for sounds—a dog, a servant, anything that might betray him tomorrow.

Nothing. The house was silent.

Stone stood there for a long time, breathing slowly, letting the darkness settle around him. Then he turned and walked back the way he had come, through the alley, through the quiet streets, out of the city and onto the road.

The others were still asleep when he returned. He lay down on his blanket without speaking and closed his eyes.

Tomorrow night.

No one slept well.

Crow lay awake, listening to the sounds of the camp—Rain's soft breathing, Fox's restless turning, Stone's silence. Ridge was still, but Crow could tell he wasn't sleeping. The stillness was too complete, too controlled.

The night stretched out around them, long and cold and quiet. Somewhere in the distance an owl called, its voice echoing through the empty air.

Crow thought about the watch point Ridge had described. Half a mile from the city, with a view of the road. He would wait there in the darkness, alone, watching for pursuers. If someone came—

He knew what he would do. He had done it before, long ago, in another life. The memory was distant now, faded like an old scar, but the knowledge remained. How to wait. How to strike. How to disappear.

He thought about Rain. Her face in the lamplight, her voice in the darkness. The feel of her hand in his. After tomorrow, the weight of their actions would begin to settle on them, never to be shed.

It was time to sleep, feeling the darkness, and the waiting, and the slow passage of time toward dawn.

Fox sat at the edge of the camp, his back against a tree, his eyes on the road below.

He understood why Ridge had given him this role. He was young, untested, likely to make a mistake in the heat of the moment. Better to keep him away from the killing, away from the danger. Better to give him a job he could do—watching the horses, guarding the escape.

He understood. But understanding didn't help.

His father had died at the Brazos. The soldiers hadn't even spoken first—just opened fire on a hunting party that posed no threat. Fox had been back at camp when Two-Kettles brought the news. He remembered his uncle Stone's face, the way it had gone hard and still, like something carved from rock.

He wanted to be the one to stand over someone responsible. He wanted to watch the light go out of their eyes. He wanted—

What? Revenge? Justice? He wasn't sure anymore. The words had blurred together over the long months of travel. But Ridge had shown him the connection—the men who sent the soldiers, who ordered the patrols, who

decided that Indians were problems to be solved. The hand that swung the hammer.

But he would not be there. He would be half a mile away, holding the reins of horses, listening for sounds in the night.

Ridge was right. Fox knew that. But it still burned.

He sat in the darkness and watched the road, and the hours passed, and the sky began to lighten in the east.

Rain woke before dawn.

She lay still for a moment, feeling Crow's warmth beside her, listening to the sounds of the camp. Then she rose quietly and walked to the place where she had hidden her weapons.

The short bow was wrapped in cloth, tucked beneath a pile of supplies. She unwrapped it carefully, checking the string, the curve of the wood. It was a simple weapon—nothing like the long bows the men used for hunting—but it was accurate at close range, and it was quiet.

The arrows were stored beside it. Five of them, fletched with crow feathers. She had made them herself, in the first weeks of the journey, sitting by the fire while the others slept.

She drew the bow, feeling the familiar tension in her arms. Aimed at a spot on a tree twenty feet away. Held for a moment. Released.

The arrow flew true, striking the bark with a soft thunk.

Rain retrieved it, checked the point, returned it to its bundle. Then she wrapped everything again and hid it in its place.

Tonight she would carry it under her shawl. Tonight she would stand at the fence and watch Ridge cross the lawn.

She pushed the thought aside. There would be time for that later.

She walked back to her blanket and lay down beside Crow. His eyes opened.

"You were practicing," he said quietly.

“Yes.”

“Are you ready?”

Rain was silent for a long moment. Ready. What did that word mean, when you were about to do something that could never be undone?

“I’m ready to do what needs to be done,” she said finally. “The rest will take care of itself.”

Crow didn’t answer. He reached out and took her hand, and they lay there together as the sky brightened, waiting for the day that would lead them to the night.

The hours passed slowly.

They ate a cold breakfast—dried meat, the last of the bread from the city. They checked their weapons, their supplies, their escape routes. They spoke little, each lost in their own thoughts.

Ridge sat apart from the others, his eyes on the horizon. He had done this before—led men into danger, made plans that could go wrong in a hundred ways. But this was different. This was the end of something, or the beginning.

Stone sharpened his knife, the slow rasp of metal on stone filling the silence. His face was calm, but his hands were steady, deliberate. He had walked the route last night. It had been long time since he had felt like a warrior, and it felt good.

Fox tended the horses, checking their hooves, their bridles, their packs. He moved among them quietly, his voice soft, his touch gentle. The animals knew him now, trusted him. When the time came, they would run without hesitation.

Crow sat at his watching place, scanning the road below. Nothing moved. The world was quiet, waiting.

Rain sat with her hands in her lap, her bow hidden beneath her shawl, her arrows wrapped and ready. She thought about the woman in the town—the one with the child, the one who had walked past them without seeing. She

wondered if that woman would hear about this, in the days to come. If she would understand what had happened, and why.

The world would move on, as it always did. Van Buren's death would be a shock, a scandal, a mystery. And then it would fade, replaced by other shocks, other scandals, other mysteries. The dead would still be dead. The Trail would still have happened.

Rain looked at the others, at Ridge and Stone and Fox and Crow. They had come a thousand miles for this moment.

The sun set slowly, painting the sky in shades of red and gold.

They gathered at the edge of the camp, their weapons ready, their packs secured. The horses were saddled and waiting, Fox holding their reins.

Ridge looked at each of them in turn. His face was calm, his voice steady.

"We know what we're doing," he said. "We know why we're doing it. No words need to be wasted."

He turned to Stone. "You remember the route?"

"I remember."

"And the approach?"

"Through the alley. The window by the back door. Second floor, front of the house."

Ridge nodded. "Good." He turned to Crow. "The watch point is half a mile from the city, on the small rise overlooking the road. You'll see anyone coming from that position."

"I know the place."

"If someone follows us—one man—you stop him. More than one, you fall back and we run."

"I understand."

Ridge turned to Fox. "Keep the animals ready. If we're not back by dawn, leave. Head west. Don't wait."

Fox's jaw tightened, but he nodded. "I understand."

Finally Ridge turned to Rain. She stood beside him, her shawl wrapped around her shoulders, her face calm in the fading light.

"Ready?" he asked.

"Ready."

He looked at all of them one last time. Then he turned and walked down the hill toward the road.

Rain followed. Then Stone, moving north when the road forked. Then Crow, stopping at the small rise that overlooked the city.

Fox watched them go, holding the reins of the horses, his heart pounding in his chest.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The moon was dark, as Ridge had promised.

They left the camp in silence, moving through the brush like shadows. Fox stayed behind with the horses, his face pale in the starlight, his hands steady on the reins. He said nothing as they passed, but Crow saw his eyes following them until the darkness swallowed them whole.

The boy had wanted to argue. Crow had seen it in his face when Ridge gave the assignments—the tightening of his jaw, the way his hands had clenched at his sides. But Fox had said nothing, had accepted his role with a nod that was almost convincing. He was learning. The hard way, maybe, but learning.

Crow took his position first—a shallow depression behind a fallen oak, half a mile from the city's edge. From here he could see the road, a pale ribbon in the darkness, and the distant glow of Washington's lamps. He settled into the earth, bow across his knees, and rifle by his side, hoping to need neither.

The others moved on without him. Stone broke off toward the north, where Poinsett's townhouse waited in its quiet street. Ridge and Rain continued toward the center, toward the White House, toward the man who had signed the orders.

Crow watched them go. Then he was alone with the night and the waiting and the slow counting of his heartbeats.

He had done this before—waited in darkness for something to happen, knowing that when it did, everything would change. The night before his son was born, he had sat outside the lodge while Rain labored inside, listening to her cries, unable to do anything but wait. The night before the patrol killed Hawk, he had sat by the fire and watched his son sleep, not knowing it was the last time.

Waiting was the hardest part. It always had been.

Ridge and Rain approached the White House from the south, where the grounds sloped down toward the swampy lowland. The fence here was

lower than elsewhere—barely six feet, with no spikes at the top. Ridge had walked this route twice in daylight, memorizing every shadow, every angle of approach.

They moved without speaking. Rain's bow was strung and ready, hidden beneath the dark shawl she had wrapped around her shoulders. Her knife was at her belt, and three arrows rode in a quiver against her hip. She had dressed in the widow's black dress again, but tonight it served a different purpose—in the darkness, she was nearly invisible.

The night air was cool and damp, carrying the smell of the swamp and something else—coal smoke, sewage, the accumulated stench of a city that never quite cleaned itself. Rain breathed shallowly, trying not to taste it.

The fence was easy. Ridge went over first, dropping silently to the grass on the other side. Rain followed, her movements quick and sure. They crouched in the shadow of an ornamental hedge and listened.

Nothing. The grounds were empty. The guards at the front of the house were too far away to see or hear them. Somewhere in the distance, a dog barked once and fell silent.

Ridge touched Rain's arm and pointed. The study window was dark, but he had watched Van Buren work late the night before, seen the lamp burning past midnight. Tonight the President had retired early. That was fine. They knew where his bedroom was.

They crossed the lawn in short bursts, moving from shadow to shadow. The grass was damp with dew, muffling their footsteps. The house loomed above them, its white walls pale against the dark sky. It looked smaller than Rain had expected—just a house, really, despite everything it represented. A house where a cruel man slept, not knowing that death had come for him too.

The study window was latched from inside, but Ridge had expected that. He drew his knife and slipped the blade between the sashes, working it upward until the latch lifted. The window swung open with barely a sound.

He climbed through first, then reached back to help Rain. They stood in the darkness of the study, listening. The house was quiet. Somewhere above

them, a clock ticked, marking the seconds with mechanical precision. The room smelled of paper and ink and old tobacco.

Ridge had studied the layout. The President's bedroom was on the second floor, at the end of a long hallway. They would have to pass through the main entrance hall to reach the stairs.

He moved to the door and eased it open. The hallway beyond was dark, lit only by a single lamp burning low at the far end. He stepped through, Rain close behind him.

They were halfway to the stairs when the guard appeared.

He came around the corner without warning—a young man in uniform, carrying a lamp in one hand and a pistol in the other. He saw them and froze, his mouth opening to shout.

Ridge was faster.

He crossed the distance in three steps, his knife finding the guard's throat before the shout could form. The guard made a wet, gurgling sound and dropped. The lamp fell with him, shattering on the floor, oil spreading in a dark pool that caught the light and held it.

Rain was already moving. She stepped over the body and headed for the stairs, her bow in her hands now, an arrow nocked. Ridge followed, leaving the dead guard behind. The guard had been young—barely more than a boy, really. Rain had seen his face in the lamplight, the surprise in his eyes. She pushed the image away. There was no room for it now.

The stairs creaked under their weight. They moved quickly, no longer concerned with perfect silence—speed mattered now. The President's bedroom was at the end of the hall, the door closed, no light showing beneath it.

Ridge reached for the handle.

The door swung open before he could touch it.

A servant stood there—a young man in a nightshirt, his eyes wide with sleep and confusion. He had heard something, had come to investigate. Now he stared at the two figures in the hallway, at the bow in Rain's hands, at the blood on Ridge's knife.

“What—” he began.

Ridge hit him with the butt of his knife, dropping him to the floor. The servant groaned, tried to rise. Ridge hit him again, harder, and this time he stayed down.

Rain was already past him, through the door, into the bedroom.

Van Buren was sitting up in bed, awakened by the noise. He was an old man, smaller than Rain had expected, his hair wild from sleep, his eyes blinking in the darkness. He wore a white nightshirt that made him look frail, almost ghostly. He saw Rain and the bow and understood.

“Wait,” he said. His voice was hoarse, trembling. “Wait—please—”

Rain drew the bow. The string bit into her fingers, familiar and sure. She had made this bow herself, had shaped it from ash wood in the first weeks of the journey. She had fletched these arrows with crow feathers, had imagined this moment while sitting by the fire as the others slept.

She had thought it would feel different. Triumphant, maybe. Or righteous. Instead she felt nothing—just the tension of the bow, the weight of the arrow, the steady rhythm of her own breathing.

Van Buren’s hands came up, palms out, as if he could stop what was coming. His mouth was moving, forming words she didn’t hear.

She loosed the arrow.

It took him in the chest, punching through the nightshirt, pinning him to the headboard. Van Buren made a sound—not a scream, more like a sigh—and his hands came up to grasp the shaft. Then they fell, and he slumped forward, and the President of the United States was dead.

Rain stood motionless, looking at what she had done. The man in the bed was just a man now—an old man with an arrow in his chest, his eyes open and staring at nothing. He had signed papers. He had given orders. Four thousand people had died because of those papers, those orders. And now he was dead too, and nothing was balanced, nothing was made right. It was just done.

Ridge moved past her to the bed. He pulled the arrow free—it came out with a wet sound that seemed too loud in the silent room—and laid it on the sheets beside the body. A message. A signature.

“We need to go,” he said.

Rain nodded. She turned toward the door, then stopped.

The servant was moving. He had crawled to his knees, one hand pressed to his bleeding head, the other reaching for something on the floor—a small bell, the kind used to summon help. His fingers were closing around it.

Ridge’s knife found him before he could ring it.

The servant died with his fingers still reaching, his eyes fixed on Rain’s face. She looked back at him for a long moment. He had done nothing wrong. He had just woken up, had just come to see what the noise was.

The weight of it settled on her shoulders, heavier than she had expected. She turned and walked out of the room.

Stone moved through the darkness like something that belonged there.

He had always been comfortable in the night. Even as a boy, he had preferred to hunt when the sun was down, when the world grew quiet and the prey grew careless. The darkness was his element. He wore it like a second skin.

Poinsett’s townhouse was exactly as he remembered from his reconnoiter the previous night—a narrow building on a quiet street, no guards at night, the back door accessible through a window that never quite closed. Stone found the window, reached through, unlatched the door, and stepped inside.

The house smelled of tobacco and old paper, the accumulated scent of long days spent reading reports and signing orders. Stone moved through a kitchen, past a pantry, into a hallway that led toward the front. The stairs were to his left, narrow and steep, carpeted to muffle footsteps.

He climbed without hurrying. There was no reason to rush. The house was quiet, the servants asleep in their quarters at the back. Poinsett was alone.

Stone thought about his brother as he climbed. Walks Far had been the quick one, the one who laughed easily, the one who could track a deer on solid rock. He had died at the Brazos, shot by soldiers who hadn't even bothered to speak first. Stone had found his body three days later, already starting to bloat in the Texas sun. He had buried him there, in a grave marked with stones that would be scattered by the next hard rain.

The bedroom door was closed but not locked. Stone opened it slowly, letting his eyes adjust to the deeper darkness within.

Poinsett was sleeping on his back, his mouth open, his breathing slow and regular. He was older than Stone had expected—his hair white, his face lined with age. The man who had overseen the removal of forty thousand Indians. The man who had bragged about it in his reports. The man who had sent the soldiers who killed Walks Far.

Stone crossed to the bed and stood looking down at him. For a moment he considered waking him, letting him see who had come, letting him understand why. But that would be foolish. That would be the kind of thing Fox would do—the glory-seeking, the need to be seen.

Stone didn't need to be seen. He just needed the man to be dead.

He drew his knife and put it into Poinsett's heart in one smooth motion.

The Secretary of War died without waking. His body jerked once, twice, then lay still. Some blood oozed across the night clothes, black in the darkness, pooling in the hollows of the fabric.

Stone stood over him for a moment, watching the blood spread. It was something that had needed to be done, and now it was done.

He took the note from his belt—a single piece of paper, folded twice, with words written in Ridge's careful hand.

For the 4,000.

He pushed an arrow through the note, and laid both on Poinsett's chest.

Then he turned and walked out of the room, down the stairs, through the kitchen, out the back door. The whole thing had taken less than five minutes. Poinsett had probably dreamed through most of it.

Stone moved through the empty streets toward the edge of the city, toward Crow's position, toward the horses and the road south. The night was quiet around him, the city sleeping, unaware of what had happened in its heart. Behind him, the townhouse sat dark and still, holding its secret until morning.

He didn't look back.

Crow heard them before he saw them.

Footsteps on the road, moving fast but not running. Two sets—Ridge and Rain, coming from the direction of the White House. He raised his head slightly, watching them approach. They moved well, staying low, using the shadows.

They passed his position without stopping. Ridge glanced toward the fallen oak and gave a slight nod, barely visible in the darkness. Then they were past, heading for the camp.

Crow settled back into his depression and waited.

Stone came next, a few minutes later. He moved differently than Ridge—slower, more deliberate, as though he had all the time in the world. He didn't look toward Crow's position, didn't acknowledge him at all. Just kept walking, steady and sure, until he too had passed.

Crow counted to a hundred. Then to a hundred again.

He was about to rise and follow when he heard it.

Another set of footsteps. Faster than the others. Someone moving with purpose, following the same path that Stone had taken.

Crow sank lower into the depression, his hand finding his bow. He nocked an arrow without looking, his eyes fixed on the road.

The figure appeared out of the darkness—a man, moving at a half-run, his head turning as he tried to follow people he could no longer see. He wore a coat and carried no weapon that Crow could see. Not a soldier. A servant, maybe. Or a watchman who had seen something, had decided to follow on his own, to confirm his suspicions before raising the alarm.

Someone who had made a mistake.

Crow drew his bow. The familiar tension in his arms, the creak of the wood, the arrow steady against his cheek. He had done this a thousand times—hunting deer, hunting elk, hunting enemies in the old days before the world changed. The motion was as natural as breathing.

The man was thirty feet away when the arrow took him. He made a sound—surprise more than pain—and stumbled, his hands going to his chest where the shaft protruded. He took two more steps, then fell.

Crow rose from his position and moved to the body. The man was still alive, his breath coming in short gasps, his eyes wide and staring at the sky. He looked at Crow without comprehension, without understanding what had just happened.

Crow pulled the arrow free. The man shuddered and lay still.

For a moment, Crow stood there looking down at him. A stranger. A man who had been alive five minutes ago, who had woken this morning not knowing that today would be his last. He had made the wrong choice at the wrong time.

All his life, Crow had watched. Watched his people, watched the land, watched the slow encroachment of the white world into everything he knew. He had watched his son grow up, had watched him ride out that morning toward the Brazos, had watched Two-Kettles return alone with the news.

Now he was the one who acted.

Crow pulled the body into the brush so that it would remain hidden for a few days. Then he wiped the arrow on the grass and returned it to his quiver, and turned and walked toward the camp.

Fox had the horses ready when they arrived.

He had spent the hours of waiting in a state of controlled tension, checking the saddles, adjusting the packs, walking the perimeter of the camp to burn off the energy that threatened to overwhelm him. Every sound in the

darkness had made him turn, his hand going to his knife. Every rustle in the brush had made his heart pound.

Now, as the others emerged from the darkness one by one, he felt something loosen in his chest.

They were alive. All of them. It was done.

Ridge came first, with Rain close behind. Fox saw the blood on Ridge's knife and the pallor of Rain's face, and he knew without asking that they had succeeded. Stone arrived a few minutes later, silent as always, his expression unchanged. And finally Crow, materializing out of the night like a ghost, his bow in one hand and rifle in the other, his face carrying something Fox had never seen there before.

"It's done," Ridge said. His voice was quiet, matter-of-fact. "Both of them. Van Buren and Poinsett."

Fox felt the words settle into him. The President was dead. The Secretary of War was dead. Killed by Indians, in the heart of the nation's capital, in the middle of the night. The world would wake to chaos.

"Any problems?" he asked.

"A guard at the White House. A servant." Ridge paused. "They're dead too."

Fox nodded. He didn't ask for details. The details didn't matter now.

"Someone followed," Crow said. It was the first time he had spoken. "From the city. I stopped him."

Fox looked at his uncle. Crow's face was calm, but Fox had seen that same calm on Stone's face, on Ridge's. It meant something had been settled.

"We need to move," Stone said. "They'll find the bodies at dawn. We need to be far away by then."

They mounted without further discussion. The horses were fresh, eager to move after hours of standing. The donkey and mule fell into line behind them, their packs secured, their movements steady.

Fox looked back once as they rode out of the camp. The fire was dead, the ground swept clean of their presence. In a few hours, the sun would rise on

a world that had changed forever. But this place would hold no evidence of what had happened here.

They rode south, toward Tennessee, toward Jackson, toward the final reckoning. Behind them, Washington slept on, unaware that its leaders lay dead in their beds.

The night swallowed them whole, and they were gone.

They rode until dawn, then kept riding.

The roads were empty in the early morning hours—farmers still sleeping, travelers not yet stirring. They moved at a steady pace, not fast enough to attract attention but fast enough to put miles between themselves and the city.

No one spoke. There was nothing to say.

Rain rode beside Crow, her face set, her eyes fixed on the road ahead. She had not spoken since leaving the White House, had not looked at anyone. Crow wanted to reach out to her, to say something, but the words wouldn't come. She had killed a man. She had killed the President of the United States. There were no words for that.

Ridge rode at the front, his eyes on the horizon. His face was calm, almost peaceful. Two of the three targets were dead. The architect remained.

The man who had started it all. The man who had signed the Indian Removal Act. The man whose signature had killed four thousand Cherokee on the Trail of Tears, had killed Ridge's wife and daughter, had killed everything he had ever loved.

Jackson was waiting in Tennessee. And Ridge was coming for him.

The sun rose behind them, painting the sky in shades of red and gold. They rode on, five figures on a dusty road, heading south.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The first light came gray and reluctant, like it knew what the day would bring.

They had ridden hard through the remains of the night, pushing the horses as much as they dared. Now, with dawn seeping over the eastern hills, Ridge called a halt in a shallow creek bottom where a stand of willows offered cover. The horses were blowing hard, their coats dark with sweat despite the October chill.

“Water them,” Ridge said. “Ten minutes. No more.”

Fox slid down from his paint and led the horse to the creek. His legs felt strange beneath him—not tired exactly, but disconnected, like they belonged to someone else. The whole night had that quality. Unreal. Something that had happened to other people in some other place.

But the blood on Ridge’s sleeve was real enough. And the silence that hung over all of them—that was real too.

The donkey waded into the creek up to its knees and stood there, drinking in long slow pulls. The mule stayed on the bank, suspicious as always, testing the water with its muzzle before committing. Fox watched them without really seeing. His mind kept circling back to the moment when the others had emerged from the darkness—the blood, the pallor, Rain refusing to meet anyone’s eyes.

The President is dead.

The words still didn’t quite fit inside his skull. They were too large, too heavy. Like trying to carry a boulder in a parfleche bag.

Stone appeared beside him, leading his own horse to drink. The big man said nothing—he rarely did—but his presence was steadying. Stone was unchanged. Stone would always be unchanged. The world could catch fire around him and he would simply stand there, solid as his name, waiting for the flames to pass.

“You did well,” Stone said finally. “The horses were ready. The camp was clean.”

Fox didn't know how to respond. He had wanted to be part of it—had burned to be part of it—and instead he had spent the night checking saddle straps and walking the perimeter of an empty camp, jumping at every sound. Useful work. Necessary work. But not the work he had imagined for himself.

"Anyone could have done what I did," he said.

Stone took a long moment before answering. He let his horse drink, watching the animal's throat work as it swallowed.

"No," he said. "They couldn't. Someone needed to be there when we came back. Someone needed to have everything ready. That was your job, and you did it." He paused. "The rest of it—" He shook his head slowly. "The rest of it was killing, and you don't need to be in such a hurry to do that."

Fox wanted to argue. Wanted to say that he could have helped, that he was ready, that he wasn't the boy they all still saw when they looked at him. But something in Stone's voice stopped him. There was a weight there that Fox didn't fully understand—a weariness that had nothing to do with the long night's ride.

"Uncle," he said quietly. "Was it—" He didn't know how to finish the question.

Stone looked at him. His face was the same as always. But the set of his jaw was different—tighter, older.

"It was necessary," Stone said. "That's all. Don't make it into more than it was."

He led his horse away from the water and began checking the girth straps. The conversation was over.

Rain sat apart from the others, her back against a willow trunk, her eyes fixed on nothing. She had not spoken since leaving Washington, had not eaten the dried meat that Crow pressed into her hand, had barely responded when Ridge asked if she was hurt.

Crow watched her from across the small clearing. He wanted to go to her, to sit beside her, to say something—anything—that might ease the weight she was carrying. But he didn't know what words those would be. He had never known.

She had killed a man. The President of the United States. She had drawn her bow and loosed the arrow and watched him die. Crow had seen death in many forms over his long life—had dealt it himself, both before last night and during—but there was something different about what Rain had done. Something that went beyond the simple mechanics of killing.

She had ended something. Not just a life, but a whole world of plans and orders and signatures on paper. The man who had sent seven thousand troops to force their people from their homes—she had put an arrow through his heart.

And now she sat alone, staring at nothing, and Crow didn't know how to reach her.

Ridge appeared beside him, moving quietly despite his weariness. His sleeve was crusted with dried blood—the guard's blood, not his own—and his face was drawn and pale. But his eyes were clear.

"We need to move soon," he said. "They'll find the bodies when the servants wake. The roads will be full of militia by noon."

Crow nodded. "Which way?"

"Southwest. Stay off the main roads. There's a trace that runs through the backcountry—it'll add two days to the journey, but it's safer." Ridge paused, looking toward Rain. "How is she?"

"Quiet."

"She'll come through." Ridge said it with a certainty that Crow didn't share. "She's stronger than she knows."

"She killed a man."

"She killed the man who commands the army." Ridge's voice was flat, matter-of-fact. "The same army that killed Hawk at the Brazos. The same government that pushes all of us off our land—Cherokee, Comanche,

everyone. She did what needed to be done. The rest—" He shrugged slightly. "The rest comes later."

Crow wanted to ask how much later. Wanted to ask if it ever really came at all, or if you just learned to carry it, like a stone in your chest that you pretended wasn't there. But he knew the answer already. He had learned it himself, in the hours since he had loosed his own arrow at a stranger on a dark road.

"We should go," he said.

Ridge nodded and moved away to check on the horses.

They rode through the morning, staying to the woods where they could, following deer trails and dry creek beds that wound through the hills west of the city. The land here was different from the plains they had left behind—greener, softer, broken up by small farms and woodlots. Smoke rose from distant chimneys. Dogs barked at their passage.

They saw no other riders.

Fox kept expecting to hear hoofbeats behind them, to see dust rising on the road they had just crossed. But the countryside was quiet, going about its morning business as if nothing had happened. As if the world hadn't changed in the night.

"They don't know yet," Rain said.

They were the first words she had spoken since Washington. Her voice was hoarse, rusty with disuse.

Crow looked at her. She was sitting straight in her saddle now, her eyes moving over the landscape with something like her usual alertness. The hollow look was still there, but it had retreated somehow—pushed back behind a wall that she had built in the hours of silent riding.

"They'll know soon," Ridge said from the front of the column. "News like this travels fast."

"How fast?"

Ridge considered. "There are express riders who carry government messages. They can cover sixty miles in a day if they push. By tonight, every town between here and Philadelphia will know. By tomorrow night, Baltimore, Richmond, all the cities of the coast." He paused. "And word will go west too. To the army posts. To the frontier."

"Jackson," Stone said.

"Yes." Ridge's voice carried a note of something that wasn't quite satisfaction. "Jackson will hear. And he'll understand what it means."

"He'll run," Fox said. "He'll go somewhere they can't find him."

Ridge shook his head. "Jackson doesn't run. He never has. It's not in his nature." A thin smile crossed his face. "He'll stay at the Hermitage and wait for us to come. He'll probably sit on his porch and watch the road. He's proud. He always was. Too proud to let anyone see him afraid."

"Then he's a fool."

"Yes," Ridge agreed. "He always was that too."

They stopped in the early afternoon to rest the horses and eat something. Ridge found a spot where a limestone outcrop created a natural shelter, hidden from the trail by a screen of young oaks. The horses grazed on what brown grass they could find while the riders sat in the shadow of the rock and chewed dried meat in silence.

The donkey, as always, found its own spot—a patch of ground slightly removed from the others where it could observe without being observed. Fox had stopped wondering at the animal's habits. The donkey did what it wanted, when it wanted, and the rest of the world could accommodate itself accordingly.

But he noticed that it stayed closer to Ridge than it used to. The animal that had once regarded the Cherokee with such obvious disdain now seemed to tolerate his presence—even, in its peculiar way, to seek it out.

Rain was eating. That was something. She had taken the meat that Crow offered her and was working through it methodically, without any apparent

pleasure but without refusal either. Her eyes still had that distant quality, but she was present now in a way she hadn't been earlier.

Crow sat close to her, not touching, just there. It was enough.

"Tell me about the one you killed," Rain said suddenly.

Everyone looked up. The question hung in the air, strange and raw.

Crow was silent for a long moment. Then: "He was following. From the city. He must have seen something—Stone leaving Poinsett's house, or you coming from the White House. He was following on foot, trying to confirm what he had seen before raising the alarm."

"What did he look like?"

Crow closed his eyes briefly. "Young. About Fox's age, maybe a little older. He wore a coat but no uniform. A clerk, probably. Or a watchman."

"Did he see you before—"

"No." Crow's voice was quiet but certain. "He never saw me. He was looking ahead, trying to find the people he was following. He never thought to look to the side."

Rain nodded slowly, absorbing this. "It was quick?"

"One arrow. He fell and I went to him and—" Crow paused. "He was still alive. Looking at the sky. Looking at me. He didn't understand what had happened. Then he was dead."

The silence stretched. Fox found himself staring at his uncle—at this man he had known all his life, who had taught him to track deer and read the weather and identify the call of every bird in the grassland. A man he had thought he understood.

"How does it feel?" Rain asked.

Crow considered the question as if it were something physical, something he could turn over in his hands and examine from different angles.

"Heavy," he said finally. "Like something you didn't know you were carrying until you picked it up. And now you can't put it down."

Rain nodded again. “Yes,” she said. “That’s right.”

They sat in silence for a while. The wind moved through the oaks, carrying the smell of fallen leaves and distant wood smoke. Somewhere far off, a crow called—a harsh, lonely sound in the quiet afternoon.

“The servant,” Rain said. “In the President’s bedroom. He was—” She stopped, breathed, continued. “He was reaching for a bell. To summon help. Ridge—” She looked toward the Cherokee, who sat apart from the others with his back against the stone. “Ridge killed him. But I saw his face. He was just—he was just a servant. He hadn’t done anything. He was just there.”

“He would have raised the alarm,” Ridge said. His voice was gentle, without defense. “If he had rung that bell, we would have died in that house. And the mission would have failed.”

“I know,” Rain said. “I know it was necessary. But—” She pressed her palms against her eyes. “I keep seeing his face. He looked at me. Right at me. And then Ridge’s knife—” She didn’t finish.

Crow moved closer to her. His arm came up around her shoulders, tentative at first, then firmer when she didn’t pull away. She leaned into him, her body shaking slightly with sobs she wouldn’t let come.

Fox looked away. It felt wrong to watch—like witnessing something private, something sacred. He busied himself with his saddle bags, checking straps that didn’t need checking.

“It doesn’t get easier,” Stone said.

Everyone looked at him. Stone rarely spoke, and never about anything like this.

“The first man I killed,” he continued, his voice steady and quiet, “was a Pawnee who came into our camp at night. I was sixteen. He was trying to steal horses. I heard him and I came out of my lodge and I put a knife in him before I knew what I was doing.” He paused. “I thought it would feel like something. Victory, maybe. Or satisfaction. But it just felt—” He spread his hands slightly, a gesture that might have meant anything or nothing. “Empty. Like a hole in the world where something used to be.”

“Did it stay that way?” Rain asked, her voice muffled against Crow’s shoulder.

“No.” Stone’s eyes went distant, looking at something no one else could see. “It filled up eventually. With other things. But the shape of it never changed. It’s still there. All of them are still there—every man I ever killed. They don’t haunt me, exactly. But they’re there. Part of me now, whether I want them or not.”

Rain was quiet for a moment. Then: “Van Buren. Will he be part of me?”

“Yes.” Stone’s voice was neither gentle nor harsh—just honest. “He’ll be part of you. The servant too. Everyone we killed last night. You’ll carry them with you until you die. That’s the cost of what we did.”

“Is it worth it?”

Stone looked at her for a long moment.

“Yes,” he said.

They rode on through the afternoon, angling southwest, keeping to the back trails Ridge had mapped in his head. The land grew hillier as they went, the farms fewer and farther between. By late afternoon they were in country that felt almost wild—dense hardwood forest broken by rocky outcrops and the occasional rushing stream.

Ridge pushed them hard, but not recklessly. He let the horses walk when they needed to walk, let them drink when they came to water, let them rest when the trail grew steep. He knew what Fox was only beginning to learn—that the animals were the mission now. Without sound horses, they would never reach Tennessee. Without sound horses, they would be caught on some lonely road and cut down before they ever saw Jackson’s face.

Fox thought about Jackson as they rode. He remembered the stories—the bodies along the trails, the children crying, the silence where voices used to be.

The trail narrowed, winding through a stand of hickory, and the donkey stopped. It didn't shy or spook; it simply planted its feet and lowered its head, blocking the path.

Ridge looked back, annoyed. "Move it."

The donkey didn't move.

Fox rode past Stone. He didn't shout or kick. He slid from his saddle and walked to the donkey's head. He put a hand on the animal's neck—the way Stone would have—and felt the tremor there.

"What is it?" he whispered.

He looked where the donkey was looking. A copperhead, coiled and silent on a sun-warmed rock at the trail's edge. It blended perfectly with the limestone, invisible unless you knew how to look.

Fox picked up a loose stone. He didn't throw it. He just tapped it against his saddle stirrup. *Clack*.

The snake uncoiled, tasting the air, and flowed away into the brush.

Fox tugged the lead rope. The donkey exhaled, a long shuddering breath, and stepped forward.

Fox mounted up. He felt Stone watching him.

"Good eyes," Stone said.

Fox didn't answer. He just fell back into line. He understood the animals now. They were all afraid. They just had to keep moving anyway.

They camped that night in a hollow between two ridges, where the trees grew thick enough to hide their fire. Ridge had been reluctant to light one at all, but the night was cold and getting colder, and Rain was shivering despite her blanket.

"Small fire," Ridge said. "And we let it die before midnight. I don't want to be seen."

Stone built the fire—a tiny thing, hardly larger than a man’s palm, but enough to take the edge off the cold. They ate more dried meat and some of the hardtack they had brought from the city. No one talked much.

Crow sat with Rain near the fire, their shoulders touching. She had steadied through the afternoon’s ride—something had shifted in her. She had come to some quiet accomodation with the reality.

Fox took the first watch. He sat at the edge of the hollow, where he could see the trail they had followed and the dark shapes of the trees beyond. The moon was rising—a thin crescent that gave little light. Stars burned cold and distant in the black sky.

He thought about his father again. About the morning he had ridden out, the easy way he had sat his horse, the casual wave he had given over his shoulder. Be back before dark. Those were the last words Fox ever heard him say.

Be back before dark.

But he wasn’t. And the darkness had lasted ever since.

Fox closed his eyes and felt the cold air on his face and tried to imagine what it would be like when this was over. When Jackson was dead and they were riding home, back across the plains, back to the camp by the dry wash. Would anything be different?

He didn’t know. He only knew that he had to see it through. Had to be there when Ridge faced Jackson, even if all he did was watch. He owed his father that much. He owed everyone who had died that much.

The night was quiet around him. The fire crackled softly in the hollow. Somewhere in the darkness, an owl called—a low, mournful sound that seemed to carry for miles.

Fox kept his eyes on the trail and waited for morning.

The second day out of Washington was easier than the first. They had found their rhythm now—the steady pace that ate up miles without killing the horses, the wordless coordination of seasoned travelers who knew how to

move together. Ridge led, reading the land, choosing trails by some instinct that the others didn't question. Stone brought up the rear, watching their back trail for signs of pursuit. The others rode between them, silent and watchful.

They saw people now and then—farmers in distant fields, a woman drawing water from a well, a child herding geese along a country lane. No one challenged them. No one seemed to take particular notice of five riders moving through the backcountry.

The news hadn't reached here yet. Or if it had, these people hadn't connected it to the strangers passing through.

"They'll be looking for Indians," Ridge said when they stopped to water the horses at noon. "War paint. Feathers. The things they imagine when they think of us."

"And instead they see—what?" Fox asked.

Ridge smiled thinly. "Five people who could be anything. Farmers, traders, families moving west. They don't expect us to look like them." The smile faded. "That's why they're dangerous, and that's why we're still alive."

Fox thought about the suit Ridge had worn into Washington, the perfect English he had spoken, his ease moving through the city as though he belonged there. It had seemed like a disguise at the time—a trick.

But looking at Ridge now, riding tall in his saddle with his eyes scanning the ridgeline, Fox realized it wasn't the clothes that made the disguise. It was the confidence. The way he made the world believe he belonged exactly where he was.

The afternoon brought clouds, then rain—a cold, steady drizzle that turned the trails to mud and seeped through their clothes despite their best efforts. They rode on anyway. There was nothing else to do.

The donkey, predictably, made its displeasure known. It stopped every few hundred yards to shake water from its ears, braying its objection to anyone who would listen. The mule, equally predictably, ignored these

performances entirely—plodding along with the same stoic patience it had shown since the day they acquired it.

“Those two,” Crow said to Rain, his voice carrying a hint of humor that surprised even himself. “Still can’t decide if they’re enemies or partners.”

Rain looked at the animals—the donkey’s flat ears, the mule’s deliberate unconcern—and a smile crossed her face.

“Like us,” she said. “At first.”

Crow nodded slowly. “Like us.”

They rode on through the rain.

By evening the clouds had broken and the sky was clearing, though the trails remained muddy and treacherous. Ridge found them shelter in an abandoned farmhouse—the roof was mostly intact, and there was a rough stone hearth where they could build a fire without too much risk of being seen.

“What happened here?” Fox asked, looking around at the empty rooms, the broken furniture, the signs of hasty departure.

“Bank took it, probably,” Ridge said. “Or the farmer just gave up. Happens all the time in country like this. Man works all his life to build something, and then one bad year, one failed crop, and it’s gone.” He shrugged. “The land doesn’t care who owns it.”

They built a fire and dried their clothes and ate the last of their dried meat. Tomorrow they would need to hunt, or risk going hungry. But tonight they were warm and dry and, for the moment, safe.

Fox took the first watch again. He sat by the empty window frame, looking out at the moonlit fields, the trees beyond, the silver gleam of a creek in the distance. The rain had cleared the air, and he could see farther than he had been able to see in days.

Somewhere out there, Washington was waking up to chaos. The bodies had been found by now. The alarm had been raised. Riders were carrying the news in every direction, spreading word of what had happened.

And somewhere out there, Jackson was waiting.

Fox thought about what Ridge had said—that Jackson wouldn't run, that he was too proud to let anyone see him afraid. He wondered if that was really true, or if it was just what Ridge needed to believe.

It didn't matter, he decided. Whether Jackson ran or stayed, they would find him. They had come too far to stop now. They had done too much to turn back.

The mission would be finished. One way or another, it would be finished.

Fox watched the moon rise over the empty fields and waited for morning.

The third day brought them to the edge of Virginia, where the hills grew steeper and the roads more traveled. Ridge angled them south, keeping to the high ground where they could see riders coming from a distance.

They heard talk for the first time that afternoon.

A farmer with a cart of apples was heading north along a road they needed to cross. Ridge held up his hand and they waited in the trees, watching the man approach, listening to him talk to his horse in the easy way that people do when they think they're alone.

"—terrible thing," he was saying. "Just terrible. President dead in his bed, they're saying. And Poinsett too. Same night. Indians done it, that's what they're saying. Indians in Washington, can you imagine?"

The farmer shook his head and clicked his tongue, urging the horse on. He passed within fifty feet of where they waited, never once looking toward the trees.

When he was gone, they crossed the road in silence.

No one spoke for a long time after that. The words hung in the air between them—Indians done it—heavy and strange and somehow unreal.

They had known, of course. They had known what people would say, how the killings would be understood, what story the world would tell. But

hearing it spoken aloud by a stranger, in that casual way, made it real in a way it hadn't been before.

The story was out there now. The story was spreading.

And soon it would reach Jackson.

They made camp that night on a wooded hillside overlooking a valley where lights burned in distant windows. The town below was small—perhaps a hundred souls—but it was the largest settlement they had seen since leaving Washington.

Ridge studied it for a long time, his face unreadable.

“We could go down,” Fox said. “Buy supplies. Hear what people are saying.”

Ridge shook his head. “Too risky now. Word has spread. People will be watching for strangers.”

“We can't avoid towns forever.”

“No. But we can avoid them for a few more days.” Ridge turned away from the lights. “Tennessee isn't far. Three days, maybe four. We'll find food along the way.”

He moved off to check on the horses, leaving Fox alone with his thoughts.

Three days. Maybe four.

And then Jackson.

Fox looked down at the lights in the valley—the small human warmth in the vast darkness—and wondered what the people down there would say if they knew. If they knew that the killers they were talking about, the Indians who had murdered the President, were camped on the hillside above their homes. Watching their lights. Counting the days until the next killing.

Would they be afraid? Would they reach for their guns?

Or would they simply not believe it? Would they look at Fox and his companions and see nothing but travelers, strangers, people who could be anything?

He didn't know. He only knew that the distance was closing, day by day, mile by mile. And soon there would be no more distance left.

Soon it would be finished.

Fox pulled his blanket tighter around his shoulders and tried to sleep.

Part IV: Chapters 15-17 (The Reckoning)

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

They rode out before dawn, the fifth morning since Washington.

No fire again. Four nights running. The cold was hard, but discovery would be harder. Crow checked the horses in the gray light—the bay mare Ridge rode was favoring her left foreleg slightly. Not lame, not yet, but tired. They were all tired.

The donkey stood apart, watching him with that expression of weary judgment it had worn since the day they left camp. But something had changed in the animal. It no longer brayed its objections at every inconvenience. It had grown quieter, more watchful, as if it understood that noise could kill them now.

They moved south on back trails and deer paths, avoiding the main roads where news would travel fastest. The landscape had changed—the steep Virginia hills giving way to gentler piedmont country, farms appearing more frequently along the roads they crossed.

Ridge led them hard. He had been this way before, Crow realized. Years ago, maybe, when he was someone else. He knew which trails to take, which roads to avoid, where the land would hide them and where it would expose them.

“There’s a crossroads ahead,” Ridge said when they stopped to water the horses at a cold stream. “A store. Last chance before we hit empty country.”

“How far to Tennessee?” Fox asked.

“Another day or two, depending on the roads.”

“The store,” Stone said. “Is it safe?”

“No store is safe. But we need supplies.” Ridge looked at Rain. “You and I will go in. The others wait with the horses.”

Rain was already reaching for the bundle that held the widow’s black dress—the costume she had worn weeks ago, when she had played Ridge’s wife

and seen the white world from the inside. Crow watched her unwrap it, shake out the wrinkles. She moved with efficiency now, no hesitation.

“We’ll be an hour,” Ridge said. “Maybe less. If we’re not back by noon—”

“We come looking,” Stone said.

“No.” Ridge’s voice was flat. “If we’re not back by noon, you ride south. Don’t stop until you reach Tennessee. Find Jackson. Finish it.”

Stone’s jaw tightened, but he said nothing.

“We’ll be back before noon,” Rain said. She had finished changing, cinching the too-large dress with a belt, pinning her hair up in the style she had learned from watching white women. When she turned to face them, she looked like someone else. Someone who belonged on a road in this country.

Crow watched them walk away—Ridge slightly ahead, Rain a half-step behind, moving with the easy pace of travelers who had nowhere particular to be.

The store sat at a crossroads where two dirt tracks met and continued on in four directions. A low building, rough-hewn logs with a shake roof, a covered porch. A single wagon hitched outside, its mule standing with head down.

Ridge and Rain approached on foot, having left their horses with Stone a quarter mile back. They walked like people with nothing to hide.

The shopkeeper was an old man, gray-bearded, with the weathered face of someone who had spent his life working with his hands. He looked up when they entered.

“Morning. Help you with something?”

“Just passing through.” Ridge’s voice was different—flatter, clipped, with an accent Rain didn’t recognize. Kentucky, maybe. “Need some supplies for the road.”

“Whereabouts you headed?”

“South. My wife’s family.”

The shopkeeper's eyes lingered on Rain for a moment, taking in the darkness of her skin. She kept her eyes down, her hands folded in front of her.

"Long way to travel," the shopkeeper said.

"It is."

They moved through the store—a sack of cornmeal, a cone of salt wrapped in paper, a small bag of coffee beans, a tin of gunpowder, a pouch of lead shot. Rain stayed near the door, watching the road through the dusty window.

"That'll be two dollars and six bits," the shopkeeper said.

Ridge counted out coins. The shopkeeper swept them into a drawer and began wrapping the goods in brown paper. He worked slowly, methodically, like a man with no reason to hurry.

"You hear what happened up in Washington?"

Rain felt her stomach tighten.

"We heard something," Ridge said. "On the road."

"Terrible thing." The shopkeeper shook his head. "President dead in his own bed. Secretary of War too, same night. Indians done it, that's what they're saying. Can you imagine? Indians in Washington, killing the President."

"Terrible," Ridge agreed. "They catch them yet?"

"Not that I heard. Army's out looking, half the militia in Virginia too. They're saying it was Cherokees, on account of that business with the removal." The shopkeeper leaned forward, lowering his voice. "I heard they left a note. Something about four thousand dead. You know anything about that?"

"Just what we heard on the road." Ridge picked up the bundle of supplies.

"They should hang them when they catch them. String them up for what they did. That's what I say. String them up and let the crows have them. World's going to hell. When you got Indians walking into the capital and killing the President, what's the world coming to?"

“Hard to say.” Ridge turned toward the door. “Thank you for the supplies.”

“Travel safe now. Both of you. Lot of dangerous people on the roads these days.”

Rain followed Ridge out, down the porch steps, onto the dirt road. She walked beside him with her eyes forward, her pace steady, her heart hammering so hard she was sure he could hear it.

They didn’t speak until they were around the first bend, out of sight. Then Ridge stopped and let out a long breath.

“You did well,” he said.

“I almost spoke. When he said they should hang them—”

“But you didn’t.”

Rain looked at him. “How do you do it? Stand there and agree with them?”

Ridge was quiet for a moment. “I’ve been doing it for thirty years. Standing in rooms full of white men who smiled at me and shook my hand and then went home and wrote laws to steal everything I had. I learned to smile back.” He picked up the bundle. “It’s easier when you know they’re going to die for it.”

They walked back to where the horses waited.

Crow saw them coming through the trees and felt something loosen in his chest. They were walking steadily, not hurrying, not looking back.

But when they reached the clearing, he could see the tension in Rain’s face.

“Trouble?” Stone asked.

“News,” Ridge said. “The whole country’s talking about Washington. They know it was Indians. They’re looking for us.”

“Did anyone—”

“No. They saw what they expected to see.” Ridge handed the bundle to Fox.

“But the net is closing. We need to move.”

They mounted and rode out, heading south on a trace that wound through cutover woodland and past abandoned farms. Crow rode beside Rain, close enough to touch but not touching.

“What happened?” he asked quietly.

Rain told him—the shopkeeper, the news, the casual talk of hanging.

“He said they should let the crows have them,” she said. “He looked right at me when he said it.”

Crow didn’t answer. He could think of nothing to say. This was the world they moved through.

After a while, Rain moved her horse closer to his, so their knees almost touched as they rode.

Fox was riding point when he saw the soldiers.

He raised his hand—the signal they had agreed upon—and the others stopped instantly. No sound, no movement. Five riders frozen on a forest trail.

Hoofbeats. Maybe half a mile ahead. Coming toward them.

Ridge was beside Fox in seconds, his voice barely a whisper. “How many?”

“Can’t tell. Five or six.”

“Patrol.” Ridge looked around quickly. To their left, a steep ravine choked with brush. To their right, dense young pine. Behind them, the trail curved back toward the crossroads.

“This way.”

They moved fast, leading the horses into the ravine, pushing through brush that grabbed at their clothes and scraped along the animals’ sides. The donkey objected—but quietly now, a soft grunt rather than the braying that could get them killed.

The mule went first, picking its way down the slope with sure-footed patience. Stone had tied the more nervous horses to the mule’s saddle,

letting the older animal's calm spread to the others. The horses followed without panic, their eyes showing white but their feet steady.

They reached the bottom and stopped. Above them, through the screen of brush and bare branches, they could see glimpses of the trail.

The hoofbeats grew louder. Fox pressed himself against his horse's neck, one hand on the animal's muzzle.

The mule stood like stone. Absolutely still. The professional, doing professional work. That steadiness spread to the other animals—they took the cue, stayed quiet.

Fox didn't move. Didn't flinch. He watched the trail through the branches, counting heartbeats.

The soldiers appeared—a flash of blue, the glint of metal, voices.

"...said they were heading south. Captain thinks they'll try for Tennessee."

"Makes sense. Jackson's there. That's the one they really want."

"You think they'll really go after Jackson? He's got half the army protecting him now."

"Hell if I know. I just do what they tell me and hope I don't get an arrow in my throat."

Laughter. The voices faded. The hoofbeats passed, growing fainter, and were gone.

No one moved. Fox counted—one hundred, two hundred, three hundred heartbeats. His hand was cramped from pressing against his horse's muzzle.

Finally, Ridge raised his hand. All clear.

They climbed out of the ravine slowly, checking the trail in both directions before leading the horses back onto the path.

"Good eyes," Stone said quietly, falling into step beside Fox.

Fox nodded.

Stone held his gaze for a moment, then moved ahead to take his position at the rear.

They found the cabin as the light was failing.

It sat in a small clearing surrounded by oak and hickory, its log walls gray with age, its roof sagging where the shakes had blown away. A garden plot beside it, gone to weeds and bramble. The remains of a split-rail fence.

Ridge stopped his horse and sat looking at it.

“Cherokee,” he said.

Crow looked more closely. He could see it now—the style of construction, the proportions of the doorway, faded symbols carved into the frame. Someone’s home before removal.

They settled the horses in what remained of the lean-to stable. The donkey and mule stood together in one corner.

The cabin was empty except for ghosts.

A broken chair in one corner. A cold hearth holding ashes from a fire that had burned years ago. On a shelf near the window, covered in dust and cobwebs, a small wooden doll—roughly carved, with a dress made from a scrap of faded cloth.

Rain picked it up carefully.

“A child lived here,” she said. “A little girl.”

Ridge took the doll from her hands, looked at it, and handed it back.

“We should sleep,” he said. “Tomorrow will be hard.”

They ate cold food in the darkness and spread their blankets on the cabin floor. The wind rattled what remained of the shutters, carrying the smell of coming rain.

Crow lay beside Rain, close enough to feel her warmth through the blankets.

“I keep thinking about her,” Rain said quietly. “The girl who lived here.”

Crow found her hand in the darkness, wrapped his fingers around hers.

Rain squeezed back. She moved closer, her head on his shoulder. They lay like that in the ruins of someone else's life, listening to the wind, waiting for sleep to come.

Crow woke before dawn. Rain was still beside him, breathing slow and steady.

He rose quietly and walked outside. The rain had come and gone in the night, leaving the world wet and gleaming. Ridge was already up, standing at the edge of the clearing, looking south. His hand was in his pocket—the ribbon, Crow knew. His daughter's ribbon.

Crow walked to stand beside him.

"Did you sleep?"

"Some." Ridge didn't turn his head.

They stood in silence, watching the sky lighten. After a while, Ridge's hand came out of his pocket. For a moment Crow saw the ribbon—faded, worn, barely recognizable. Then Ridge tucked it away.

"Wake the others," he said. "We have a long way to go."

Crow went to wake the others.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Tennessee was different.

The land flattened as they rode south, the hills giving way to broad valleys and prosperous farms. The houses here were larger, the fields better tended. Crow saw slaves working in the fields—the first he had seen in numbers. They moved slowly in the winter cold, bent to tasks that would never end.

This was the country that had swallowed Cherokee land. This was what removal had brought.

They kept to back trails, but the roads here were better, the settlements closer together. Harder to disappear. Ridge led them with the same quiet certainty he had shown since Washington, but Crow noticed how often his hand went to his pocket now.

They were close.

Midmorning, Fox raised his hand from the front of the column.

Crow pulled up beside Ridge. On a distant ridge to the east, maybe a mile away, two riders moved slowly along the crest. They weren't traveling—they were scanning, searching.

"Bounty hunters," Ridge said quietly.

The riders disappeared over the far side of the ridge without looking their way. But Ridge watched that spot for a long time after, his eyes narrow, his jaw set.

"They're everywhere now," Stone said.

"Yes." Ridge turned his horse back to the trail. "We need to move."

They rode on. The distant riders didn't reappear. But Crow felt their presence like a weight on his shoulders—the hunt was real, and it was closing in.

They found the place Ridge was looking for in the early afternoon—a wooded hollow a mile and a half from the main road, screened by a stand

of old oaks. A creek ran through the bottom, barely more than a trickle this time of year, but enough for the horses.

“Cold camp,” Ridge said. “No fire until this is finished.”

They had been making cold camps for days now. The horses were tired, the bay mare still favoring her left foreleg. The donkey stood apart, watching them with its ancient, judging eyes. The mule waited beside it, patient as stone.

Fox watered the horses while Stone checked the perimeter. Rain unpacked what food they had—dried meat, the last of the cornmeal from the cross-roads store. They ate in silence.

“Crow,” Ridge said when they had finished. “You and I will scout.”

Crow nodded. He had expected this.

“The rest of you stay here,” Ridge continued. “Stone, watch the approaches. If we’re not back by dark—”

“We come looking,” Stone said.

Ridge shook his head. “If we’re not back by dark, we were caught. You take the others and ride. Find another way.”

Stone’s face was expressionless, but his eyes said he wouldn’t do it. Ridge saw it too. He didn’t argue.

“We’ll be back before dark,” Crow said.

They rode partway, then tied the horses in a thicket of young pines and continued on foot. The land rose gently toward the estate, hardwood forest giving way to cleared fields and pasture. Through the bare winter trees, Crow caught his first glimpse of white columns.

The Hermitage.

It was smaller than he had expected. A two-story house with a columned portico, painted white, sitting on a slight rise. Outbuildings scattered behind it—slave quarters, stables, a smokehouse. A garden to the south, brown and dormant now, with rows of dead corn stalks standing like sentries.

This was where the architect lived. The man who had signed the paper in Washington, who had condemned four thousand Cherokee to die on a frozen road, slept peacefully in that house. Crow tried to feel something—rage, perhaps, or the cold satisfaction of vengeance approaching. But all he felt was tired.

Ridge crouched beside him in the tree line, utterly still. His eyes moved across the property, noting, measuring, planning.

“Four soldiers at the main entrance,” Ridge said quietly. “See them?”

Crow looked. Four men in blue uniforms stood near the front of the house, muskets shouldered. They looked bored, cold, wishing they were somewhere else.

“They’ve given him protection,” Crow said.

“The President is dead. They know someone might come for him next.” Ridge’s voice was flat. “They’re right.”

They waited. Servants moved between buildings. A wagon arrived with supplies, was unloaded, departed. The soldiers stamped their feet against the cold and talked among themselves. Normal life, continuing as if the world hadn’t changed.

Then the front door opened, and an old man stepped out.

Crow knew him immediately. Andrew Jackson—Old Hickory, the Hero of New Orleans, the man who had broken the Cherokee nation. He was thinner than Crow had imagined, gaunt and stooped, his white hair wild around his face. But he still walked like a soldier, each step deliberate and proud.

“He’s dying,” Ridge said. There was no satisfaction in his voice. Just observation. “But not fast enough.”

Jackson descended the front steps slowly, one hand on the railing. A single soldier fell in beside him—younger than the others, alert, with two pistols visible at his belt. They walked together toward the garden.

“One guard,” Ridge said. “Two pistols. He’ll be fast.”

They watched Jackson move through the garden, pausing at the rows of dead corn. The old man reached out and touched one of the dry stalks, his fingers gentle. He stood there for a long moment, looking at nothing.

The soldier waited a few paces behind, watchful but relaxed. This was routine. They had done this before.

Then hoofbeats on the main road. Crow tensed, but Ridge put a hand on his arm.

An officer rode up to the main entrance, his horse lathered from hard riding. He spoke urgently to the four soldiers—Crow couldn't hear the words, but he could read the body language. Something had happened. Something that needed attention.

The four soldiers mounted their horses and rode off with the officer, heading north at a canter.

Jackson continued his walk through the garden. The single guard remained.

"There," Ridge said softly. "That's where we do it—in the corn rows."

They watched until Jackson finished his walk and returned inside. The guard followed. The four soldiers had not returned.

"Tomorrow," Ridge said. "When the pattern repeats."

They slipped back through the trees, retrieved their horses, and rode for camp.

"Four soldiers at the entrance," Ridge told the others when they returned. "But they don't stay. An officer came—some business elsewhere. They rode off and left Jackson with one guard."

"One guard," Stone repeated.

"One guard. Two pistols. He stays close during the garden walks." Ridge drew a rough map in the dirt with a stick. "The house here. Garden to the south, corn rows here. Tree line about two hundred yards from the garden."

Rain leaned forward, studying the marks. Tomorrow she would walk that ground with Ridge.

“Rain needs to see it,” Crow said.

Ridge nodded. “Before dark. Stone goes with her—stay back, don’t get close. Just see the approach.”

Stone rose without a word. Rain followed. Crow watched them go, then sat down heavily against a tree. His legs ached from crouching in the cold.

Fox was watching him. The boy had been quiet all day, quieter than usual.

“You saw him,” Fox said. “Jackson.”

“Yes.”

“What did he look like?”

Crow thought about it. The gaunt figure, the wild white hair, the proud walk of a man whose body was failing but whose will remained iron.

“Old,” Crow said. “Dying. But not beaten.”

Fox nodded slowly. “Good. I wouldn’t want him to be beaten before we got there.”

Rain and Stone returned as the last light faded. Rain’s face was pale but set.

“I saw it,” she said to Ridge. “I know the way.”

“Good.”

They ate cold food in the gathering dark. No one spoke much. The weight of tomorrow pressed down on all of them.

Crow found himself watching Fox. The boy sat apart, cleaning his bow, checking his arrows one by one. But his eyes kept moving—to Stone, to Ridge, to the trees around them. Learning. Preparing.

“Fox,” Crow said quietly.

The boy looked up.

“What are you doing?”

Fox was silent for a moment. Then: “Figuring out how I’d do each job. If I had to.”

“You won’t have to.”

“I know.” Fox went back to his arrows. “But if I did.”

Crow watched him work. The hot-headed boy who had wanted to fight the farmer, who had declared himself what was left of his father—that boy was gone. This one was quieter, steadier. This one was thinking three moves ahead.

Stone would be proud, Crow thought. He wasn’t sure if that was good or not.

Later, as the others settled into their blankets, Crow saw Fox approach Ridge.

Ridge sat alone at the edge of camp, his bow across his knees, a small stone in his hand that he was using to sharpen arrowheads. There was something different about him tonight. A stillness that went deeper than concentration.

Fox stopped a few feet away at first, and then sat.

For a while neither of them spoke. Ridge worked on his arrows, methodical and unhurried. Fox watched.

“You’re not worried,” Fox said finally.

Ridge didn’t look up. “No.”

“About tomorrow. About what might happen.”

“No.”

Fox was quiet. Then: “You’re not coming back.”

Ridge’s hands stopped moving. He looked at Fox—really looked, for the first time in days.

“I came here to finish something,” Ridge said. “When it’s finished, I’ll be finished.”

“That’s not—” Fox stopped. Started again. “You could come back. After.”

“No.” Ridge picked up another arrow, ran his thumb along the fletching. “I died on that road with my daughter. With four thousand of my people. What’s walking around now—” He shrugged. “It’s just the part that hasn’t stopped moving yet.”

Fox didn’t say anything. Crow, listening from his blankets, didn’t either.

Ridge looked at the boy. “You’re different. You have something to come back to. People who need you.” He tilted his head toward where Stone’s bulk was visible in the darkness. “Don’t throw that away trying to be brave.”

Fox nodded slowly. “I understand.”

“Good.” Ridge went back to his arrows. After a moment, Fox rose and walked back to his own blankets.

Crow watched Ridge continue working in the darkness—alone, methodical, almost peaceful. The look of a man who had let go of everything except the one thing that still mattered.

Tomorrow, he would kill Andrew Jackson. And then he would rest.

Rain came to Crow in the darkness.

She slipped under his blanket without a word, pressing close against him. He wrapped his arms around her, feeling the cold of her skin, the warmth beneath.

“Tomorrow,” she whispered.

“Yes.”

“I’ll be with Ridge. At the end.”

Crow said nothing. His arms tightened around her.

“I wanted you to know—” She stopped. Started again. “When I shot Van Buren. When the arrow left my bow. I thought of Hawk.”

Their son. Dead in a patrol’s ambush eight months ago. The wound that would never fully heal.

“I’ll think of him tomorrow too. When I see Jackson.”

"I know," Crow said.

Crow pressed his face against her hair. She smelled of smoke and horse and the cold Tennessee night. She smelled like home.

"Come back to me," he said.

Rain's hand found his in the darkness. She squeezed.

"I'll try."

They lay together in the ruins of what their life had been, listening to the wind in the bare branches. Around them, the others slept or pretended to sleep. The donkey stood watch at the edge of camp, ears forward, eyes on the darkness.

Crow woke to gray light and the sound of birds.

Ridge was already up, standing at the edge of the trees, looking south toward The Hermitage. His bow was strung across his back. His hand was in his pocket.

Crow rose and went to stand beside him.

"Did you sleep?"

"Some." Ridge didn't turn his head. "Enough."

The others were stirring now. Stone checking weapons. Fox saddling horses. Rain braiding her hair back, the way she did before a fight.

"If the soldiers leave like they did today," Ridge said, "we move. Rain and I approach from the south. You and Stone hold the horses at the tree line. Fox stays here."

"I know."

Ridge finally turned to look at him. His eyes were clear, calm, empty of everything except purpose.

"You've been a good friend these weeks, Crow."

"Don't," Crow said. "Don't say goodbye."

Ridge almost smiled. "I'm just saying thank you." He put his hand on Crow's shoulder, squeezed once, and let go. "Wake the others. We have work to do."

Crow went to wake the others.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

They were in position before dawn.

Crow crouched at the tree line with Stone, holding the horses in a small hollow where the animals couldn't be seen from the house. The donkey stood among them, still and watchful, as if it understood what was about to happen. The mule waited beside it, patient as always.

Fifty yards ahead, hidden in a drainage ditch at the edge of the corn rows, Fox lay flat against the cold earth. He had insisted on being closer. Ridge had allowed it.

And somewhere beyond the corn, Ridge and Rain waited in the trees on the south side of the garden. Crow couldn't see them. That was the point.

The Hermitage sat quiet in the gray morning light. Smoke rose from two chimneys. The four soldiers stood at the main entrance, stamping their feet against the cold, talking in low voices that didn't carry. Normal. Routine.

They waited.

The sun climbed. An hour passed, then another. Crow's legs cramped from holding still. Beside him, Stone was motionless, his eyes fixed on the house.

"What if they don't leave?" Crow asked quietly.

"Then we wait another day."

"And if they never leave?"

Stone didn't answer. They both knew what that would mean—finding another way, or accepting that there was no way. But Ridge wouldn't accept that. Ridge would walk up to the front door and die trying before he'd turn back now.

A servant emerged from a side door, carrying a basket toward the smoke-house. A dog barked somewhere behind the main house. The soldiers talked and laughed about something. The world went on, unaware that death was waiting in the trees.

Then Crow heard hoofbeats on the main road.

His hand tightened on the reins. Stone's head turned slightly, tracking the sound.

An officer appeared on the road, riding hard, his horse dark with sweat. He pulled up at the main entrance and spoke urgently to the soldiers. Crow couldn't hear the words, but he could see the soldiers' body language change—straightening, nodding, reaching for their horses.

The four soldiers mounted and rode off with the officer, heading north at a canter. The sound of hoofbeats faded into the distance.

The main entrance stood empty.

Stone let out a slow breath. "There it is."

They waited. Five minutes. Ten. The front door of the house opened.

Andrew Jackson stepped out onto the porch, one hand on the railing. The single guard followed—young, alert, two pistols at his belt. They descended the steps and walked toward the garden.

Crow watched Jackson move across the grounds. The old man walked slowly but steadily, his white hair bright against his dark coat. He looked frail. He looked like someone's grandfather.

He looked like the man who had killed four thousand Cherokee.

Jackson entered the garden, the guard a few paces behind. They moved toward the corn rows, following the same path Crow had watched yesterday.

"Now," Stone said quietly. "It happens now."

Crow saw them emerge from the trees on the far side of the garden.

Ridge first, moving fast across the open ground. Rain a step behind, to his left. They weren't running, but they weren't walking either—the pace of hunters closing on their prey.

The guard saw them at the same moment Crow did. The young man's hand dropped to his pistol, but he hesitated—he could not make out faces, and two people approaching wasn't necessarily a threat. Not yet.

Ridge and Rain reached the corn rows and disappeared into the dead stalks. For a long moment, Crow couldn't see anything except the brown tops of the corn swaying slightly as they pushed through.

Jackson had stopped walking. He stood at the far end of the garden, facing the corn, as if he sensed something. The guard stepped closer to him, hand still on his pistol.

Then Ridge stepped out of the corn. Twenty yards from Jackson. Maybe less. Rain emerged beside him, her bow already raised.

Jackson turned.

Crow watched the old man's face. He was too far away to see the details, but he could read the body language—the slight stiffening, the lift of the chin. Not surprise. Recognition.

Jackson had known they would come. He had been waiting.

No one spoke. No words across that garden, no final accusations or defenses. Just two men looking at each other across twenty yards of Tennessee dirt—the architect and the avenger, the president and the Cherokee.

Ridge raised his bow.

The arrow flew.

Jackson fell.

The guard was fast.

His first pistol was out and firing before Jackson hit the ground. The shot cracked across the garden, and Crow saw Ridge stagger—hit in the side, spinning half around but staying on his feet.

Rain's arrow took the guard in the throat.

The young man stumbled backward, hands going to his neck, his second pistol coming up even as he fell. The shot went wild—Crow heard Rain cry out, saw her grab her arm—but the guard was down, choking on his own blood, dying in the dirt beside the man he was supposed to protect.

Three bodies in the garden. Two of them still.

Ridge was swaying on his feet, one hand pressed to his side. Even from this distance, Crow could see the blood spreading through his fingers.

“Go,” Stone said.

They moved.

Fox reached them first.

He burst from the drainage ditch and ran across the garden, heedless of any threat. By the time Crow and Stone arrived with the horses, Fox had Ridge’s arm over his shoulder and was half-carrying him away from Jackson’s body.

“I’m fine,” Ridge said. His voice was steady, but his face was gray. “The token. I need to leave the token.”

“You’re shot,” Fox said.

“I need to leave the token.”

Ridge pulled away from Fox and stumbled back toward Jackson. He fell to his knees beside the old man’s body—Crow couldn’t tell if it was deliberate or if his legs had simply given out.

Jackson’s eyes were open, staring at the gray sky. The arrow had taken him in the chest, a clean kill.

Ridge reached into his pocket and pulled out the ribbon. Faded rose, worn soft from handling, the last piece of his daughter he had left. He laid it on Jackson’s chest, beside the arrow.

Then he pulled out a folded piece of paper—the note he had written days ago, the words he had carried all the way from the Llano Estacado. He tucked it into Jackson’s coat.

“For them,” Ridge said quietly. “For all of them.”

He tried to stand and couldn’t. Fox caught him before he fell.

“We need to go,” Rain said. She was holding her arm, blood seeping between her fingers, but her voice was calm. “Now.”

Shouts from the house. Someone had heard the shots.

Stone was there, lifting Ridge like he weighed nothing, carrying him toward the horses. But Ridge couldn't sit a horse—Crow could see that immediately. He was too weak, losing too much blood. He would fall before they'd gone a hundred yards.

"The donkey," Stone said.

The donkey had followed them from the tree line. It stood now at the edge of the garden, watching with those ancient, knowing eyes.

Stone carried Ridge to the animal and set him on its back. The donkey—the same stubborn creature that had judged Ridge with profound disapproval the day he'd arrived at their camp, the same animal that had complained and balked and brayed its objections at every inconvenience—stood perfectly still.

No resistance. No complaint.

Ridge slumped forward, his hands gripping the donkey's mane. Blood dripped onto the animal's gray coat.

"Ride," Stone said.

They rode.

They pushed hard for the first hour, putting distance between themselves and The Hermitage. Crow kept looking back, expecting to see soldiers on the road behind them, but the pursuit never came. Maybe the officer had taken all the men who could ride. Maybe no one at the house had seen which direction they'd gone.

Or maybe they'd been lucky. Whatever luck meant for people like them.

Ridge was fading. Crow could see it in the way he sat—slumped lower with each passing mile, his grip on the donkey's mane growing weaker. Rain rode beside him, her wounded arm bound with a strip torn from her shirt, watching him with dark eyes.

"We need to stop," she said finally.

“Not yet.” Stone’s voice was hard. “Not far enough.”

“If we don’t stop, he dies on that donkey.”

Stone didn’t answer, but he slowed his horse. They found a hollow a quarter mile off the trail—a small clearing beside a creek, sheltered by a stand of old oaks. Hidden. Quiet.

Stone lifted Ridge down from the donkey.

The animal followed them into the clearing and stood a few feet away, watching. It hadn’t made a sound the entire ride.

They laid Ridge on the ground beside the creek. Rain knelt beside him, her hands moving over the wound, but Crow could see from her face that there was nothing to be done. The bullet had gone deep. Ridge was bleeding inside, where no one could reach.

Ridge knew it too. His eyes were clear, and he looked up at the gray sky with something that might have been peace.

“It’s done,” he said. His voice was quiet, but steady. “I finished it.”

Stone knelt on his other side. Fox stood a few feet back, his face pale, his eyes fixed on Ridge.

“You finished it,” Crow said.

Ridge’s hand moved, reaching for something that wasn’t there. Then he remembered—the ribbon was gone. He had left it with Jackson.

“My wife,” he said. “My daughter.”

“We know,” Rain said softly.

“The four thousand.” Ridge’s breath was coming shorter now. “Tell them... tell them it was for them. All of them.”

“They’ll know,” Crow said.

Ridge looked at each of them in turn—Stone, Rain, Fox, Crow. His eyes lingered on Fox for a moment, and something passed between them. An acknowledgment. A farewell.

Then Ridge looked up at the sky again. The clouds were breaking apart, and a patch of blue showed through.

“I’ll see them now,” he said. “My wife. My daughter. I’ll see them.”

He took a breath. Let it out slowly.

He didn’t take another.

They buried him in the hollow, beside the creek.

Stone did most of the digging. Fox helped, his face set in hard lines, his eyes dry and distant. Rain sat against a tree, Crow helping to clean and bind her wound properly now, watching them work.

The donkey stood at the edge of the clearing, still and silent. Waiting.

Crow stood watch, his eyes on the trail, but no one came. The world didn’t know yet what had happened. The world would find out soon enough—Jackson dead, the President and the Secretary of War dead before him, Cherokee arrows in all of them—but for now, this hollow was quiet. For now, they had this moment.

When the grave was finished, they lowered Ridge into it and covered him with earth. No marker—they couldn’t risk it being found. No ceremony—there wasn’t time. Just five people standing over a mound of fresh dirt, and the sound of the creek, and the wind in the bare branches.

Stone stood with his jaw tight, his hands clenched at his sides. His eyes were wet. In all the weeks they’d traveled together, all the violence and death and hardship, Crow had never seen Stone close to breaking. He was close now.

Fox stood beside him, not touching but near. The boy who had wanted glory, who had declared himself what was left of his father—he seemed older now. He looked like someone who had seen too much to ever be young again.

Rain’s hand found Crow’s. He squeezed it and didn’t let go.

They stood in silence for a long moment. Then Crow spoke.

“He finished what he came to do,” Crow said quietly. “Now he can rest.”

Stone made a sound—not quite a word. He turned away, walked to the edge of the clearing, and stood with his back to them. He did not move for a long time.

Fox watched him, then looked at Crow. Crow nodded. Fox went to stand beside Stone, not speaking, just present. After a moment, Stone put a hand on the boy’s shoulder.

Rain leaned against Crow, her weight warm against his side.

“We should go,” she said quietly.

“I know.”

But they stood there a moment longer, in the hollow beside the creek, with the wind in the branches and the sound of the water and the grave of the man who had brought them here.

Then they mounted their horses and rode on.

The donkey followed without being led.

It walked behind them as they made their way south and west, away from Tennessee, away from The Hermitage, away from everything they had come to do. It carried no rider now. Its back was still stained with Ridge’s blood.

Fox kept looking back at it. “Should we—”

“Leave it,” Stone said. His voice was rough, but steady again. “It’ll follow or it won’t.”

The donkey followed.

Crow rode beside Rain, watching her wounded arm, but she didn’t complain. The bleeding had stopped. She would heal.

They all would heal, eventually.

The trail wound through winter-bare forest, past abandoned farms and fields gone to seed. They saw no one. The world felt empty, as if everyone had gone somewhere else and left these hills to the dead.

Crow thought about what they had done. The President of the United States—Rain’s arrow. The Secretary of War—Stone’s knife. And now the man who had started it all—Ridge’s arrow, with Rain killing the guard who shot him. They had changed something. He wasn’t sure what, exactly, or whether it mattered. But they had changed something.

And Ridge was dead. The man who had walked into their camp like a ghost and given them a purpose was gone. They were carrying his memory now, the same way he had carried his daughter’s ribbon.

The sun was setting behind the hills when Stone finally called a halt. They made a cold camp in a stand of pines, not risking a fire. Rain checked her wound and pronounced it clean. Fox saw to the horses.

The donkey stood at the edge of the camp, facing east, toward the place they had left Ridge. As if it was waiting for him to catch up.

“It misses him,” Fox said quietly.

“Maybe,” Crow said. “Or maybe it’s just a donkey.”

But he didn’t believe that. None of them did.

They ate cold food and rolled into their blankets as the darkness settled. Rain curled against Crow’s side, her breathing slow and steady. Fox was already asleep, exhausted by the day’s violence. Stone sat at the edge of camp, first watch, his silhouette dark against the stars.

Crow lay awake for a long time, looking up at the sky.

Now they had to go home. It was a long way back to the Llano Estacado, through country that would soon be hunting them.

Crow closed his eyes. When he slept, he dreamed of home.

Part V: Chapter 18 (The Return Home)

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The weeks blurred together.

They rode west, then south, following trails that Crow half-remembered from the journey out. The land changed beneath them—Tennessee hills giving way to Arkansas lowlands, then the slow rise toward the plains. They crossed rivers whose names Crow didn't know, skirted towns they couldn't risk entering, slept in hollows and thickets and once in an abandoned barn that smelled of old hay and rot.

Rain's wound healed as they traveled. The flesh knitted slowly, leaving a scar on her upper arm that would fade with time but never disappear entirely. She didn't complain. None of them did. They were too tired for complaints, too hollowed out by what they had done and what they had lost.

The donkey followed.

It walked behind them without being led, its gray coat still showing the dark stain where Ridge's blood had soaked in. Crow had tried to wash it out at a creek crossing, but the mark remained—faded now, but visible. A reminder. The donkey didn't mind. It just followed, patient and silent, as if waiting for a rider who would never come.

They saw soldiers twice.

The first time was in Arkansas, a patrol moving along a main road while they watched from a ridge a quarter mile away. Blue coats, rifles, the purposeful movement of men with orders. Crow's hand went to his bow, but the soldiers passed without looking up.

The second time was closer—a group of five men stopped at a creek crossing, watering their horses. Crow and the others went to ground in a stand of willows and waited, barely breathing, while the soldiers talked and laughed and splashed water on their faces.

"...saying it was Cherokee," one of them said. "Arrows in all three. Can you believe it? Indians walking into Washington and killing the President."

“They’ll catch them eventually. Whole army’s looking.”

“Looking where? Could be anywhere by now. Could be in Mexico. Could be dead.”

The soldiers mounted up and rode on, heading east.

Crow watched them go. Cherokee arrows—that was what the world knew. But which Cherokee? There were thousands scattered across Indian Territory, broken remnants of a nation that had once stretched from the mountains to the sea. The soldiers could search for years and never find the right ones.

They were ghosts. They had done the impossible and disappeared.

The plains opened up around them, vast and empty under the winter sky.

Crow felt something loosen in his chest as they crossed into familiar country. The grass was brown and dead, waiting for spring, but he knew these hills. He knew the way the wind moved across them, the smell of the earth, the quality of light in the late afternoon.

Home. They were almost home.

Stone rode at the front now, leading them by instinct more than memory. Fox stayed close to his uncle, quieter than he had been before Tennessee.

Rain rode beside Crow. Her wound had closed cleanly, leaving only stiffness when she drew her bow. She would heal fully in time.

“How much farther?” she asked.

“A day. Maybe less.”

Rain nodded. She didn’t say anything else, but her hand reached out and found his. They rode like that for a while, fingers intertwined, watching the horizon.

They smelled the camp before they saw it—woodsmoke and horses, the scent of home. Stone raised his hand, and they stopped on a low rise overlooking the draw where the band had made their winter camp.

It looked the same. The tipis arranged in their familiar pattern, smoke rising from cook fires, horses grazing in the pasture they had fenced with brush. Children running between the lodges. Dogs barking. Life continuing as it always had, as if nothing had changed.

But everything had changed. The people down there just didn't know it yet.

"Ready?" Stone asked.

No one answered. What was there to say?

They rode down.

The dogs saw them first, setting up a chorus of barking that brought people out of their lodges. Crow watched faces turn toward them—confusion first, then recognition, then something else. Joy, maybe. Or relief. Or the complicated mix of emotions that came with welcoming home people you had expected might never return.

Two-Kettles was among the first to reach them. The old warrior who had survived the patrol attack that killed Hawk and Walks Far, who had wished he could go with them when they rode out, who had stayed behind to guard what remained.

He looked at them—Stone, Fox, Rain, Crow—and his eyes went to the spaces where others should have been.

"Ridge?" he asked.

"Gone," Stone said. "He finished what he went to do."

Two-Kettles nodded slowly. He had known. They all had known, when Ridge walked into their camp like a ghost with murder in his eyes, that he wasn't coming back. He had just needed to finish dying.

"And the others? The targets?"

"All three." Crow's voice was steady. "Van Buren, Poinsett, Jackson. All three."

Two-Kettles stared at him. For a moment, his weathered face showed nothing. Then something shifted—a light in his eyes, a straightening of his spine.

“You did it,” he said. “You actually did it.”

“We did it.”

Two-Kettles reached out and gripped Crow’s forearm, warrior to warrior. His hand was trembling slightly.

“I kept them safe,” he said. “While you were gone. I kept the camp safe.”

“I know. Thank you.”

Two-Kettles released him and stepped back. His eyes were wet, but he was smiling—a fierce, proud smile that Crow had never seen on his face before.

“Tell me everything,” he said. “Tonight, at the fire. Tell me everything.”

Sage was waiting at Stone’s lodge.

She stood in the entrance, her arms crossed, her face unreadable. The same sharp, guarded expression she had worn the morning they left, when she had touched Stone’s face and told Fox not to be first through the door and threatened Ridge with cold fury.

Stone dismounted slowly. He walked toward her without speaking, his massive frame somehow diminished by exhaustion and grief. He stopped in front of her, and for a long moment they just looked at each other.

Then Sage reached up and touched his face. The same gesture as before—her palm against his cheek, her fingers tracing the lines that the journey had carved deeper.

“You came back,” she said.

“I came back.”

Her hand slid down to his chest, resting over his heart. “And the boy?”

“He’s a man now.” Stone’s voice was rough. “He did well. Walks Far would be proud.”

Sage closed her eyes. When she opened them again, they were bright with unshed tears. She pulled Stone toward her, and he went—the rock that had held them all together finally letting himself be held.

Crow looked away. Some things were private.

That night, they told the story.

The whole camp gathered around the central fire—warriors and elders, women and children, everyone who had stayed behind while five of their people rode east to do the impossible. Crow did most of the talking. He was the observer, after all. The one who watched and remembered.

He told them about the journey—the rivers crossed, the farms skirted, the hostile and friendly faces they had encountered. He told them about Washington, about Rain walking into the White House with Ridge while Stone killed the Secretary of War. He told them about the escape, about the long ride south, about Tennessee and The Hermitage and the old man who had walked in his garden waiting for death to find him.

He told them about Ridge's arrow flying across the garden. About Jackson falling. About the guard's pistol and Rain's answering shot. About lifting Ridge onto the donkey and riding until they couldn't ride anymore.

He told them about Ridge's last words. About burying him in a hollow beside a creek, in Tennessee soil that had once belonged to his people.

When he finished, the fire had burned low and the stars wheeled overhead. No one spoke for a long time.

Then Two-Kettles raised his voice—not speaking, but singing. An old song, a warrior's song, one that Crow's father had taught him when he was young. One by one, others joined in. The sound rose into the night sky, carrying the names of the dead—Hawk, Walks Far, Ridge, and the four thousand Cherokee who had died on a frozen road.

Rain's hand found Crow's in the darkness. Her fingers were warm, her grip strong.

They had done it. They had struck back against the men who thought themselves untouchable.

It wouldn't bring back the dead. But it was something.

Dawn came slowly, gray light seeping across the plains.

Crow stood at the edge of camp, watching the horizon. Rain stood beside him, her shoulder touching his. They had slept little—too much to process, too many memories crowding behind their eyes. But they had slept together, and that was good.

The donkey stood a few yards away, in the spot where Ridge used to stand when he looked out at the land and thought whatever thoughts a dying man thinks. It had found its way there sometime in the night, as if guided by instinct or memory. Now it stood motionless, its ears forward, watching the same horizon Crow was watching.

"It misses him," Rain said.

"Maybe."

"It carried him at the end. When it mattered most."

Crow nodded. The donkey had judged Ridge harshly when he first arrived—that look of profound disapproval, the constant complaints and objections. But somewhere along the way, something had changed.

Fox emerged from Stone's lodge and walked over to join them. He looked older in the morning light, the softness of youth burned away by what he had witnessed.

"Stone says we should rest today," Fox said. "Start thinking about spring hunting tomorrow."

"He's right," Crow said.

Fox nodded. He looked out at the horizon, then at the donkey, then back at Crow.

"Do you think they'll ever find us? The soldiers?"

Crow considered the question. Somewhere to the east, men were searching for Cherokee assassins. They would search for months, maybe years. They would question and investigate and follow trails that led nowhere.

“No,” he said finally. “They’re looking for ghosts. And ghosts don’t leave tracks.”

Fox almost smiled.

He walked back toward the lodges, leaving Crow and Rain alone with the donkey and the dawn.

The sun rose higher, painting the plains in shades of gold and brown. The camp stirred behind them—voices, laughter, the sounds of a life continuing. Children who would grow up knowing what their people had done. Elders who would tell the story until it became legend.

Rain leaned into Crow, her head against his shoulder.

“What now?” she asked.

Crow thought about it.

“We live,” he said.

Rain nodded. Her hand slipped into his.

They stood there together, watching the horizon, while the donkey stood nearby in the space where Ridge used to be. The wind moved across the grass, carrying the smell of sage and earth and home. Somewhere in the camp, a child laughed.

The world would keep turning. The soldiers would keep searching. And someday, maybe, the story of what they had done would fade into myth—a tale of five warriors who rode east and killed the men who had tried to erase a people from the earth.

But for now, there was this: a man and a woman standing in the morning light, alive, together, home.

It was enough.